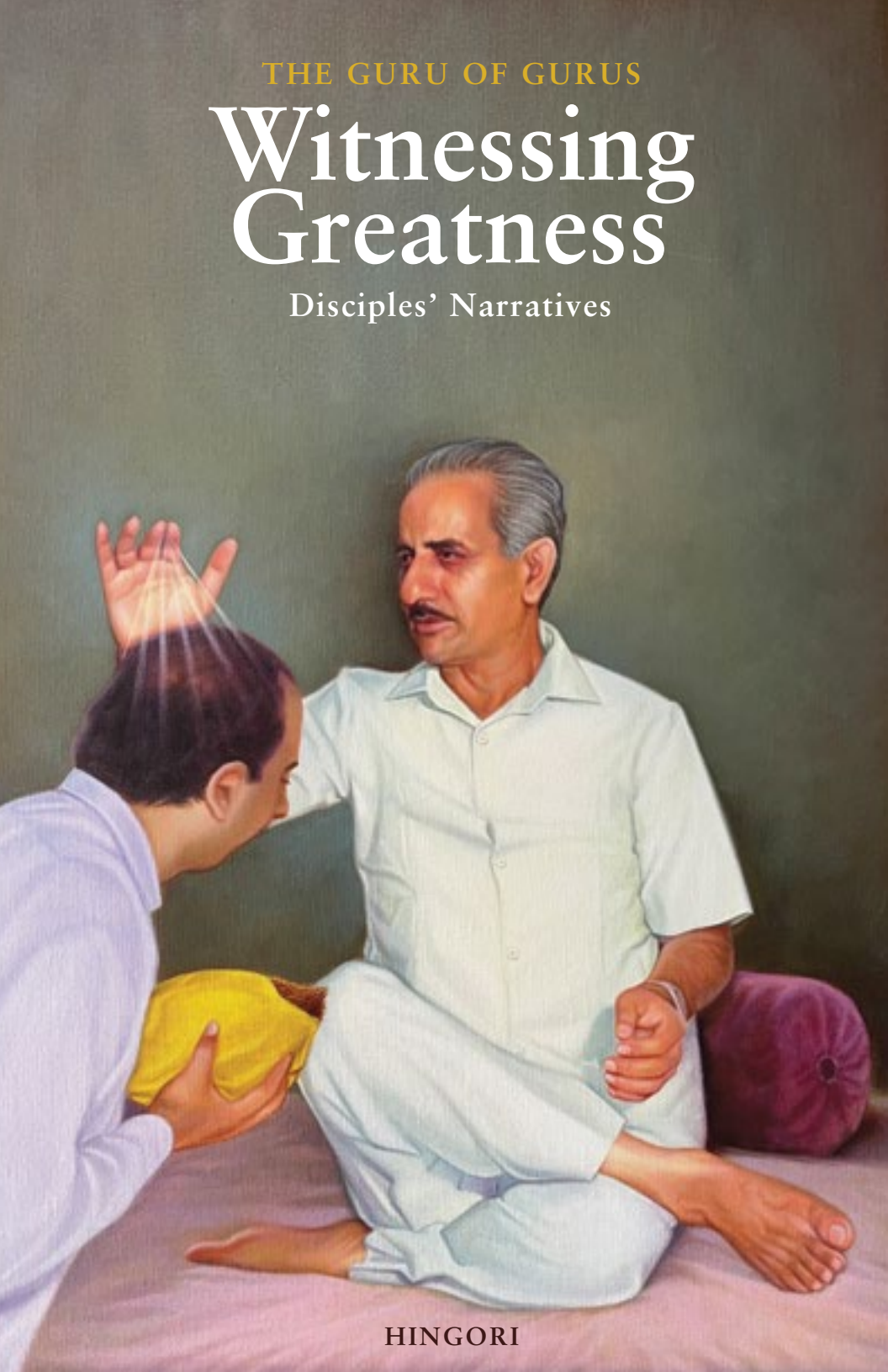
THE GURU OF GURUS

Witnessing Greatness

Disciples' Narratives



HINGORI

Witnessing Greatness

Disciples' Narratives

by Hingori

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Gifted to those who deserve it.

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His magnificence, even in silence, spoke.
He was a sage of solace for the lost,
the weary and broke.
Not just in words but in all that he'd do,
He lived the higher truths he knew.

Witnessing his greatness, my life changed its hue.
In his light, I found perspectives anew.
Like a lighthouse in life's vast, turbulent sea,
He guided me to my essence,
To who I was meant to be.

A file photo of Gurudev at the sthan in Gurgaon

Foreword

Gurudev lived for 53 years, the last 18 of which were spent as a revered mahaguru, having attained guruhood at age 35. Despite the brevity of his time as a spiritual leader, his impact was far-reaching. He was a simple man, an enlightened spiritual mentor, and a supernatural healer. His interventions were not just miraculous but transformative, enriching our lives and spirits and leaving lasting imprints on every aspect of our existence.

His temporary stay on earth was foretold in the *Brighu Samhita*,[1] predicting his mission to serve countless beings in the earthly dimension, both visible and invisible. His compassion for the spirits that had left their physical bodies or those about to enter wombs was of a different order. He nurtured them from before the cradle to after the grave. The chain of continuity in lifetimes was not an idea he discreetly nurtured; it was what he openly propagated, revealing to many that he had to wait for over 500 years to ensure that his disciples from previous lives could be born at the same time as him to evolve collectively. His deliberate synchronisation of lifetimes was proof that our destinies were linked beyond time and space. This interconnectedness, a cornerstone of his teachings, demonstrated that our spiritual journeys are not solitary paths but intricately intertwined across the ages, uniting us in a shared spiritual transformation.

Bound by past connections yet consciously oblivious to their deep spiritual ties, his disciples took birth wherever they could.

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1 An ancient Sanskrit astrological manuscript ascribed to Rishi Bhrigu, one of the revered *Saptarishis* (seven great sages) of the Vedic period. This comprehensive astrological text offers insights into one's past, present, and future lives, encompassing many predictions

They were drawn to him for different reasons, at different times, and even saw life differently. But somehow, their paths and perspectives converged around him. His care and guidance catapulted them into seva and sieved them from nebulae to spiritual stardom. Witnessing his greatness was their privilege. And sharing their stories, both tiny and tall, modest and monumental, is mine.

The narratives in this book are bound to fascinate you, although the intention is more for them to become your stories, not just his. Gurudev maintained that all that he could do, we could too. He endowed us with his powers and encouraged us to excel and surpass him. Many of his fourth-generation disciples have not met him physically but have experienced his guidance through dreams and visions and travelled with him astrally.

The mahaguru moved on in 1991, departing physically but remaining ethereally present. From Mount Kailash and his *samadhi*[1] at Neelkanth Dham in Najafgarh, he continues to help, heal, and guide millions within the radius of his gaze.

As you read this book, may you feel his presence and be inspired to embark on your spiritual journey. Let the lessons within these pages guide you toward a life of greater purpose and connection, helping you reach your highest potential.

Good luck!

Hingori

1 The final resting place or shrine of a saint

Chapter 1

Back To The Future

Every element of Gurudev's early life—from the auspicious signs at his birth to his professional affiliations—was strategically reverse-engineered to sculpt him into the spiritual titan he was to become. His journey was not merely a path he traversed but a destiny carefully crafted, uncovering the elaborate blueprint of a life designed for the Guru of Gurus.

Water was one of the leitmotifs in Gurudev's life. He was born through the blessings of *jal*[1] and, in later years, healed through it.

Gurudev's sister Rashmi ji shares the fascinating story of her grandfather's pilgrimage to Gurudwara Santoksar Sahib in Amritsar, Punjab. The pilgrimage had one goal—to obtain blessings for his daughters-in-law so that they could give birth to boys. A sage at the Gurudwara gifted him two fruits and *jal*, hinting at the name of a future child: Santprakash. However, the pages of the *Bhrighu Samhita* whispered a different prophecy. The ancient Rishi[2] Bhrigu foretold the rise of a *divya aatma*[3] with a different name who would be born in the small town of Hariana in Hoshiarpur, Punjab.

An unusual downpour—a sign seen as auspicious—coincided with Gurudev's birth. Initially intended to be named Santprakash,

1 Water energised through mantras
2 Ancient sages or seers who were believed to have received spiritual knowledge through intense meditation or direct insight, which they later expressed in the form of sacred texts such as the *Vedas*
3 A divine being

his grandmother interpreted the rain as a significant omen and chose a name that symbolised mastery over rain—a name also prophesied with remarkable accuracy by Rishi Bhrigu.

From Gurudev's earliest days, signs of his extraordinary destiny were evident, drawing parallels to the likes of the Buddha, Jesus Christ, and Lord Krishna, whose births, too, were accompanied by prophetic revelations.

"I recall our mother describing an incident shortly after my brother's birth," Rashmi ji shares. "As he rested peacefully in a crib on our terrace, a cobra sat atop him, its hood spread wide in a protective stance. The very sight petrified our mother. But before long, the snake retreated, disappearing into the crevice of a wall. Desperate for answers, she sought the wise counsel of a *pandit*.[1] He interpreted the event as an omen, signalling that my brother was destined for unparalleled greatness."

Some years later, another ascetic foresaw that when Gurudev reached 35, he would become 'someone like Shiv'.

Subbhash Sabbharwal ji grew up in Hariana with Gurudev. When Gurudev relocated to Delhi after high school, their lives diverged, but fate had a way of reconciling them. Subbhash ji reached out to his former friend after learning that he had become a guru capable of guiding, helping and healing others. He sought and received spiritual direction and became an integral member of the administrative team at Gurudev's sthan[2] in Gurgaon. Despite the evolution of their relationship dynamics, the essence of their childhood bond remained intact.

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1 A priest, particularly one well-versed in Vedic scriptures, philosophy, and rituals
2 Centre for help and healing established by Gurudev

"Gurudev never had a keen interest in academics," Subbhash ji recalls, the amusement in his tone evident. "To be honest, neither of us were at the top of our class."

The notion that the future shapes the strategies of the past finds a compelling illustration in young Gurudev's disinterest in conventional education. Though he did not know it at the time, he was destined for omniscience, a state he would achieve through the awakening of his third eye. As a mahaguru, his extraordinary powers enabled him to view the past, present, and future in ways others could not comprehend. He revealed significant visions to his disciples, such as the chemistry of blood and the precise blueprint of a drainboard sink. He healed ailments that were deemed incurable by modern science. Traditional subjects such as history, chemistry, biology, and physics were reinvented through his cosmic lens. How could mundane geography interest someone who, in the future, would regularly and wilfully traverse astral dimensions?

"Our shared adventures often led us to nearby fields, where we would pick fruits or get up to some other mischief, only to face the consequences when we got home," Subbhash ji chuckles. "On our way home from school was a *dargah.*[1] We would visit it to pluck *bers*[2] from the trees that grew nearby. The *fakir*[3] who lived there would say, 'You create a lot of trouble; at least bow your head here'. I found out much later that Gurudev often visited the *dargah* alone."

"Every Thursday, without exception, Gurudev would light a *diya*[4] at the *dargah,*" Gaggu ji, Gurudev's nephew, recalls. "Even when nature's fury caused floods, or traditional *diyas* were hard to come by, he would innovate—sometimes using a handmade mud or clay lamp."

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1 A shrine built over the grave of a revered spiritual figure, typically a Sufi saint, where followers come to offer prayers and seek blessings
2 Jujubes
3 Title for a saint free from greed. Colloquially, it could refer to an ascetic who lives on alms
4 Oil lamp

Born into Hinduism, the boy destined to be a mahaguru embodied spiritual universality from the beginning. Throughout his life, he generously shared his wisdom with individuals from every faith and walk of life. His path, marked by alliances with many spiritual luminaries, epitomised a seamless fusion of faiths. At the heart of his philosophy was a fundamental principle: to respect and cherish all spiritual paths, to connect rather than convert. In today's fractured world, this ethos of harmony and inclusiveness thrives in every sthan linked to him.

A defining episode in Gurudev's formative years was his unsettling encounter with black magic.

Gurudev's wife, reverentially known as Mataji, shares an insightful episode from her husband's childhood: "When he was in the fifth or sixth grade, an acquaintance gave him something infused with negative energy to eat. This made him quite ill, and he was bedridden for about two years. When conventional medical treatments failed to heal him, my mother-in-law proposed seeking help from the Baba Balak Nath temple in Hamirpur, which is about 103 kilometres from Hariana. Despite my father-in-law's reservations, my mother-in-law's conviction won out, and together, they embarked on the challenging journey to the temple, hopeful for a cure. At the temple, a devotee of Baba Balak Nath gave Gurudev *jal* to drink, leading him to vomit a mixture of undigested buttermilk and ashes from a *masaan*.[1] Only after this purge did his health begin to improve."

According to Mataji, this ordeal was a turning point in Gurudev's spiritual journey: "He struggled with the idea of an external force wielding such power over his body for so long. This unsettling realisation catalysed his deep dive into spirituality."

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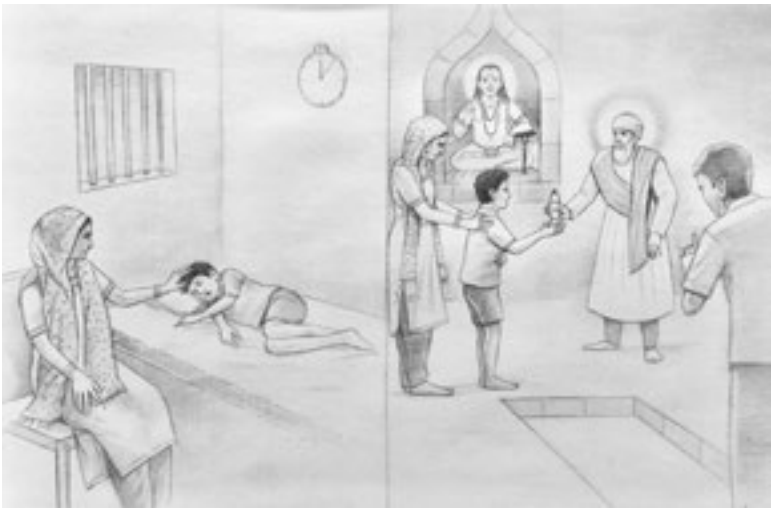
1 Cremation ground



Young Gurudev recovers from an ailment caused by black magic by drinking jal

This incident brought to light two significant insights. First, despite attaining considerable power in past lives, Gurudev was still susceptible to black magic in this life. This suggests that his true potential was yet to be unveiled, with his vast abilities lying dormant, poised for future emergence. Second, his natural fortitude and latent spiritual strength enabled him to tolerate and subsequently overcome the potentially lethal attack.

In his early years, Gurudev was drawn to the company of *sadhus*,[1] eager to absorb their learnings. His early spiritual pursuits were an assortment of practices as he meandered through various teachings without a clear path. The undercurrent of his journey was deeply rooted in the significant spiritual power inherited from his past lives and his destined future as the Guru of Gurus. At the time, though, the present was like a fertile field being prepared for the seeds of the future.

1 Ascetics who have renounced worldly life to pursue spiritual enlightenment. They often live a life of celibacy, dedicating themselves to meditation, penance, and spiritual practice

Sitaram ji of Dasua mentors young Gurudev at the Sheetla Mata temple

Two pivotal figures who significantly influenced Gurudev's spiritual upbringing during this time were Sitaram ji of Dasua and Sitaram ji of Benaras.

RC Malhotra ji, the mahaguru's first disciple, shares, "Sitaram ji of Dasua began living at the Sheetla Mata temple near Gurudev's house. His guru, Sitaram ji of Benaras, who lived in Haridwar, later joined him. They both mentored Gurudev."

Together, they provided young Gurudev with a structured approach to spirituality. They guided him in acquiring quite a few *siddhis*,[1] which allowed him to heal diseases and grant wishes. While these early abilities were instrumental in teaching him mental discipline, focus, perseverance, and resilience, they were just the beginning of his spiritual journey. Years later, under the guidance of his guru, Buddhe Baba, Gurudev transcended these initial *siddhis*, embarking on a spiritual path that led to his eventual emergence as a mahaguru.

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1 Mentioned in texts like the *Yoga Sutras of Patanjali*, they refer to spiritual capabilities attained through rigorous practices, including yoga, mantra recitation and meditation. They range from mundane skills like healing snake bites to significant abilities like clairvoyance, levitation, or telepathy

Gurudev's strong inclination towards spirituality over academics persuaded his family that moving to Delhi might steer him towards a more conventional and successful career path. After completing his tenth grade, Gurudev relocated to Delhi, where he lived under the care of his uncle in Shahdara.

Life in India's bustling capital was not without its trials for young Gurudev. Ever the pragmatist, he embraced any available job to support himself. At his uncle's home, he was not merely a guest but an integral part of the household, contributing to daily chores. Frequently, he would carry heavy sacks of wheat to the grinding mill, epitomising the spirit of dedication as he sought to repay his gratitude towards his uncle and his family.

Throughout his life, the mahaguru embodied and championed a lifestyle free from debt. He exemplified the virtues of generosity over personal gain, setting a powerful example for others.

Gurudev's early life was woven from a series of events that seemed to stitch together the pieces of his destiny. During a walk in Shahdara, he aided a stranger who turned out to be the spouse of the principal at Delhi's PUSA Institute. This meeting led to Gurudev's enrollment in a technical course at the Bharat Sevak Samaj, setting him on a path to becoming a soil surveyor for the Government of India. This job seemed designed to extend his future spiritual influence into India's remote areas, reaching far beyond urban centres.

The initial group of Gurudev's disciples—RC Malhotra ji, Dr Shankarnarayan ji, FC Sharma ji, RP Sharma ji, Bade Jain Saheb, RK Sharma ji, Dutta Saheb, and Suraj Sharma ji—emerged strategically from his workplace. Born during the same era as the mahaguru, these men were destined to be pivotal in his spiritual

franchise. It was as if destiny had reverse-engineered the perfect assembly of souls, aligning their births and careers to facilitate their meeting and training under Gurudev. This orchestrated convergence at their common workplace enabled the mahaguru to impart his teachings and shape their spiritual paths effectively.

At work, one of the first people Gurudev formed a friendship with was a colleague, KL Nagpal, affectionately known as Naaga. Their friendship had a curious origin: due to a clerical mix-up, Nagpal ji received a position meant initially for another with the same name. The situation unfolded more comically than tragically, as the other KL Nagpal's influential father bestowed his blessings on Nagpal ji, accepting that destiny had played its hand. This unexpected error forged a bond that greatly supported the mahaguru's future spiritual mission.

Nagpal ji resided in a modest apartment in East Delhi, sharing the space with his landlord and longtime friend, Dwarkanath ji, who fondly recalls, "Nagpal and I went back to our days as youngsters in Agra. After relocating to Delhi, we secured jobs and became roommates. One day, Nagpal mentioned that a colleague from Hariana was searching for a place to stay. I was open to the idea, suggesting he could move in with us if we got along well. Upon meeting Gurudev, I was immediately struck by his humility and intellect. Consequently, the three of us agreed to share the apartment."

"Gurudev's job as a soil surveyor required him to travel extensively, so he was only home for about half the year. I yearned for his delightful company when he was away on tours. It is worth noting that my elder brother only came to visit when Gurudev was around," Dwarkanath ji chuckles. "Gurudev had a way of telling jokes and sharing anecdotes that left everyone wanting more. Such was his charisma that every meeting transformed casual acquaintances into ardent admirers."

In the realm of human abilities, one can aspire to master 16 or more *kalas*.[1] However, a mahaguru's range of abilities often exceeds these. A sharp sense of humour is essential among these *kalas*, and Gurudev was endowed with it in spades.

As time unfurled, I observed Gurudev's adeptness at weaving humour and wit to leave a lasting impression. On the surface, his comments seemed light-hearted, yet the underlying messages always landed, resonating deeply with those who understood.

"One trait of his that profoundly impacted me was his complete detachment from money," Dwarkanath ji recalls.

From a young age, Gurudev spent his pocket money on feeding animals and birds or treating his friends to sweets and soft drinks. He rarely spent money on himself, preferring to use it to benefit others. In the later years, I noticed that Gurudev's approach to money was paradoxically unique. Despite earning modestly, he gave generously, always making ends meet in seemingly mysterious ways. One notable habit illustrating his detachment was his reluctance to accept leftover change during transactions. Having tried to adopt this habit myself, I can attest to its difficulty—it is far more challenging than it appears.

Occasionally, Gurudev would reach into his pockets and, to everyone's surprise, pull out a bundle of notes. I wonder if he begrudgingly wielded some power to conjure up the currency, using it solely in circumstances that demanded *nisvarth seva*.[2] It seems plausible that this extraordinary ability was granted to him later in life as an acknowledgement of his steadfast altruism and complete detachment from money.

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1 Refers to the divine qualities (in Hindu and Yogic traditions) that manifest in a person or deity. These qualities can range from wisdom and strength, to artistic expression, humour and moral virtues
2 Service rendered selflessly without expectation of monetary compensation; also referred to as seva

I have seen this gift of his manifest in my life. At Gurudev's insistence, I travelled to Gurgaon monthly for Bada Guruvar.[1] The mahaguru insisted that I fly instead of taking the train. Miraculously, during those years of frequent financial shortfalls, the necessary funds for the flight tickets would somehow materialise—found under my mattress, hidden in a cupboard drawer, or secreted in a coat pocket. I am confident that the mahaguru's benevolence was at work.

Dwarkanath ji reflects on Gurudev's early spiritual inclinations with a sense of awe. "Living together for so long, we were oblivious of his spiritual powers. He was far more evolved than we realised. While we slept, he often rose, unfolded his cot, wrapped himself in a blanket, and meditated for hours. Nagpal would question him, and he would say he was doing his *paath*.[2] He often made predictions that would invariably come true. And then there were the unexplained conveniences, like arriving at a movie theatre without tickets, only to find someone waiting with exactly three tickets for us. We experienced many such mysterious events."

Despite this, nothing could fully prepare Dwarkanath ji for their reunion after Gurudev had ascended to the status of a mahaguru.

"During my visit to Gurgaon, it was challenging to reconcile my memories of my old friend with his new role as a guru," he admits. "However, as time passed, I began to grasp the extent of his spiritual influence. During one of our meetings, Gurudev gestured for me to sit beside him. Out of deep respect, I chose to sit on the floor, struck by the powerful energy he radiated. His presence was so commanding that it seemed to dissipate any negativity around us."

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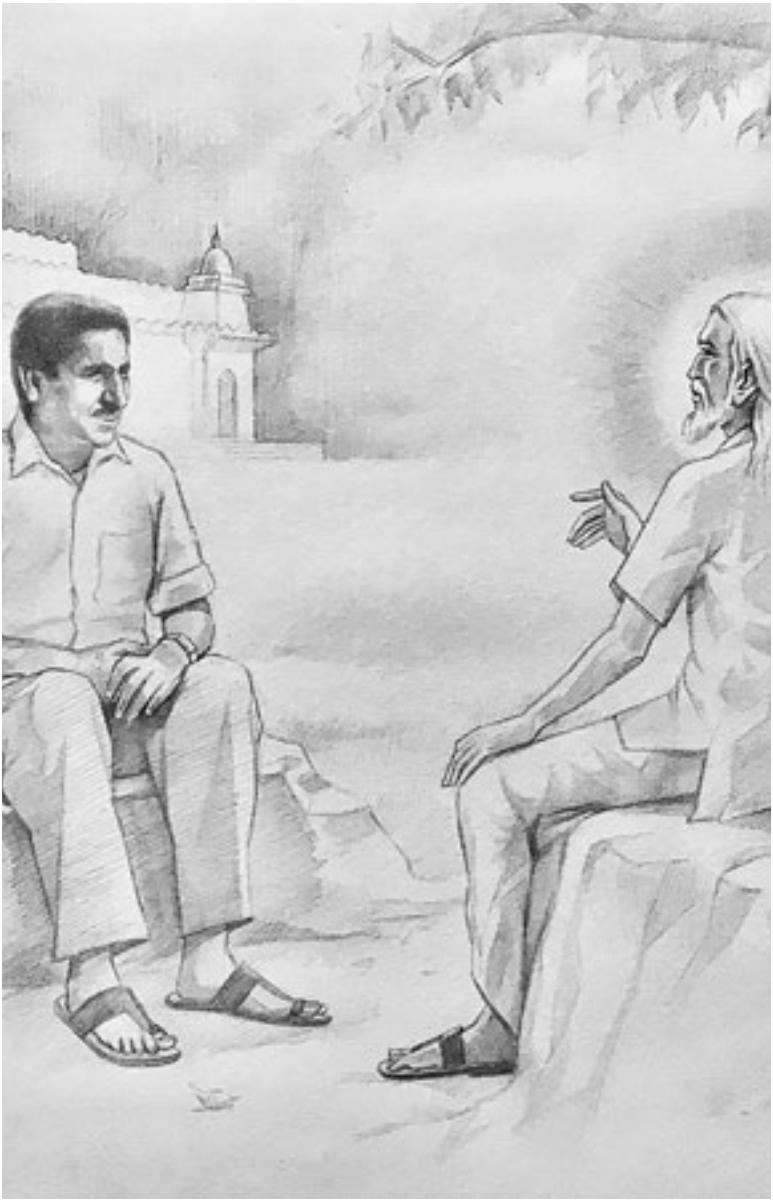
1 A special Thursday each month designated for seva at sthans established by Gurudev or his disciples. It typically falls on the Thursday following *Amavasya*, or the new moon

2 Focused practice of mantras while lying down or sitting in a meditative pose. For Gurudev, it also implied out-of-the-body travel

While the narrative of transitioning from friends to foes is standard, evolving from a friend to a devotee is unique. It speaks volumes about Dwarkanath ji's humility and wisdom in acknowledging and honouring his once roommate as his spiritual guru.

Gurudev's destiny as a mahaguru reverse-engineered his early years, imbuing them with qualities that would pave his path to spiritual eminence.

His extraordinary empathy, discipline, inclusive acceptance of diverse faiths, inherent wit, humility, and deep-seated selflessness were not merely personal traits but the building blocks of his spiritual journey. These foundational elements, predestined by his ultimate role, shaped him from the beginning, enabling his ascent to great heights under the guidance of Buddhe Baba.



Gurudev meets Buddhe Baba for the first time

Chapter 2

Invisibly Yours, Buddhe Baba

In the world of spiritualism, where identities often blur like wisps of incense, the role of a guru in guiding beings along their evolutionary journey is crucial. Our conscious awareness, typically limited to a single lifetime, requires the enlightenment of a guru to awaken and nurture the latent qualities of Shiv[1] consciousness. Even manifestations of Shiv, such as Adi Shankaracharya, the Buddha, Guru Gobind Singh, Guru Nanak Dev, and many others, needed a guru during their earthly lives to shepherd their spiritual evolution and fulfil their destined roles.

At the heart of Gurudev's spiritual journey stands his guru, Buddhe Baba. The mahaguru deeply revered his spiritual mentor, yet he maintained an aura of secrecy around his identity, fueling ongoing speculation and intrigue.

Gurudev's journey from spiritual aspirant to a revered mahaguru was one of remarkable transformation. In his youth, under the tutelage of Sitaram ji of Dasua, he mastered many *siddhis*. These were not parlour tricks of an average practitioner; they were fruits of deep spiritual practices. However, Buddhe Baba saw that for someone destined to embody the finest qualities of Shiv, these powers, though impressive, were preliminary achievements—significant, yet not the zenith of spiritual development.

1 Often misunderstood as a physical form, Shiv is a set of attributes and capabilities that manifest in higher states of consciousness. At lower levels of consciousness, these attributes and capabilities remain dormant

He urged Gurudev to strive for the ultimate state of spiritual enlightenment, where his initial abilities would seem minor in comparison. Following this advice, Gurudev relinquished his *siddhis* into the Ganges at Har ki Pauri in Haridwar. This act was not about forsaking his hard-earned spiritual attainments but a deliberate step to make room for his ultimate role as a mahaguru.

Guided by the omnipresent influence of his ethereal mentor, Gurudev surpassed his previous spiritual achievements and reached new heights in his lifetime.

Suresh Kohli ji of Sunet in Himachal Pradesh remembers a conversation with Gurudev about the origins of his mystical abilities. The mahaguru narrated an intriguing story from his past: "Once, while stationed in Madhya Pradesh for a soil survey camp, I took a long walk and stumbled upon an old temple. Inside, a sage was in deep meditation. I indulged in tobacco then, and the sage asked me to share some with him. To my surprise, he mentioned that the mantra I quietly chanted to myself was incomplete. He then guided me to add eight words to it."

"As I walked back to the camp," Gurudev continued, "the new mantra continuously echoed in my mind. That evening, when I meditated on it, the sage from the temple appeared in my vision. He told me that all I was seeking was already within me. He then told me to look at my palm. To my surprise, a glowing OM symbol had appeared on my hand. Another OM had appeared on my chest. I quickly covered my hand with a cloth and put on a vest to hide the graphics. The following morning, just as the sage had foretold, I discovered a *kada*[1] beneath my pillow."

"I returned to the temple, hoping to see the sage again. However, I found the place completely deserted, as if no one had ever been there. Intrigued, I questioned the locals about the sage, but

1 A bracelet (often made of copper) energised by the guru with his aura, which serves as a link between him and his disciple

they all insisted that the temple had been vacant for years. Later, during my *paath* at night, the sage reappeared in my vision. He assured, 'You do not need to seek me physically. I will always be present during your *paath* to guide you. But remember, you must do *nisvarth seva*'. Puzzled, I asked, 'How should I do *nisvarth seva*?' The sage clarified, 'Serve selflessly. Whoever you touch will be healed, and I will guide you every step of the way.'"

Suresh ji further elaborates, "The next day, Gurudev encountered a group hurriedly transporting a man on a charpoy. On inquiring about the man's condition, he was told, 'He has an unbearable stomach ache'. At this moment, Gurudev heard an inner voice instructing him to intervene. Following the voice, he placed his hand on the sick man's stomach and silently recited his mantra. The man's pain disappeared in mere moments, leaving everyone present amazed!"

Under the guidance of Buddhe Baba, Gurudev immersed himself further in his spiritual practices, receiving new mantras and advancing steadily on his spiritual journey.

The mahaguru remained reserved about his mentor's identity. This silence fuelled widespread speculation and assumptions about who Buddhe Baba truly was.

FC Sharma ji, one of Gurudev's humblest disciples, states, "For many of us, Gurudev stood alone in his spiritual journey. Yet, he occasionally shared anecdotes about his guru, who would guide him, even restraining him from certain actions. He often directed those in need to seek his guru's blessings at the sthan in Sector 7, Gurgaon. He advised them that lighting a *dhoop*[1] there would bring comfort and fruition. Even when presented with a wedding invitation, he gently instructed, 'Place the card at the sthan, and ensure Buddhe Baba is invited first.'"

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1 Incense, typically made from aromatic herbs and resins

Gurudev surprises Rajpal ji by selectively declining garlands from certain devotees

"When the sthan in Sector 7 at Gurgaon was established, Gurudev frequently acknowledged the ever-present aura of Buddhe Baba," Ravi Trehan ji, who manages a sthan in Kirti Nagar, New Delhi, recalls. "Whenever individuals approached him with their troubles, he would gently advise, 'Visit the sthan, offer your respects to Buddhe Baba, and confide in him. He will address your concerns.'"

Gurudev attributed all his seva to Buddhe Baba, often saying, "He does. I don't". At times, when faced with deeply profound questions, he would say that he needed to consult Buddhe Baba before providing an answer. Though Buddhe Baba was an unseen force, Gurudev remained perpetually conscious of his presence.

Rajpal Sekhri ji, a disciple, reflects on this enigmatic bond: "During significant events such as Guru Purnima[1] and Mahashivratri,[2]

1 A traditional Hindu festival dedicated to honouring spiritual teachers. It is celebrated on the full moon day (*Purnima*) in the Hindu month of *Ashadha* (June to July)

2 Every human being is a blend of three energy forms: male, female, and the union of both. The right side of the body represents the male energy, which becomes fully active on the night of Mahashivratri after a dormant phase that begins a few days after Diwali. This dormant phase, known as the Shakti Period, is when the female energy is more dominant and influential

visitors at the sthan typically presented one garland at the sthan and another to Gurudev. I vividly remember one Mahashivratri when Gurudev accepted garlands from certain devotees while gently declining others. I observed this selective gesture for hours, wondering why he was doing so. Unable to contain my curiosity, I approached him with the question. Amidst blessing his followers, Gurudev paused, turned to me, and shared, 'I have to consider my guru, and I certainly cannot wear more garlands than my guru does.'"

Reflecting on the mysterious figure guiding her husband's spiritual journey, Mataji offers faint glimpses into the enigma: "I never once heard Gurudev mention Buddhe Baba around me. However, one night, a soft murmur woke me. I heard him whisper 'Baba'[1] and converse with someone. Then, he suddenly stopped speaking. The next morning, when I asked about it, he lightly dismissed it, claiming he was speaking with his *maalik*,[2] who had warned him I might be listening, which caused him to end the conversation abruptly," she shares with a laugh.

"Only Gurudev truly knew the identity of Buddhe Baba," FC Sharma ji explains. "While the sthan in Gurgaon has photographs of various deities, an image of Buddhe Baba is notably absent. Yet, Gurudev invoked his presence regularly. I believe Buddhe Baba might be a manifestation of Shiv or Mahashiv."[3]

Santlal ji, a disciple from Sonepat, adds: "Gurudev once said that during seva, Shiv would appear and sit beside him and guide him." Two significant insights emerge from this statement. One, Gurudev probably used Shiv as a synonym for Buddhe Baba. Two, Buddhe Baba's presence was perceptible only to the mahaguru.

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1 A term of reverence used to address male elders, father figures or wise individuals. It is often associated with religious figures or gurus
2 Term of reverence used to personify the supreme consciousness
3 The powerful convergence of the energies of the trinity—Brahma, Vishnu, and Maheshwara—combining their distinct divine forces into a singular, potent energy

"Let me tell you about a time I was talking with Gurudev in his room," Ashok Bhalla ji, a devotee, adds. "In the middle of our conversation, he said, 'My *maalik* controls life and death'. As he said this, he gazed intently at a picture of Lord Shankar with a white beard hanging over his bed."

Alka ji, Gurudev's youngest daughter, supports Ashok ji's observations, stating, "Daddy would often point to a picture and say, 'This is Buddhe Baba'. That image showed Lord Shankar with white hair and a flowing white beard."

Ravi ji adds another layer of intrigue to the unfolding mystery, stating, "I believe Gurudev had two gurus: Sitaram ji of Dasua and Shiv."

I analyse Ravi ji's comment: Throughout history, spiritual journeys have been marked by mentorship and transformative encounters. This path is often punctuated with various guides, each illuminating a different facet of the seeker's quest. To understand this better, think about how we learn in school. We have different teachers for distinct levels of our education, each helping us learn in several ways. Just as a budding scientist might first learn the basics from one teacher, only to delve into deeper complexities under another, a spiritual aspirant might have different guides at different junctures.

From the nurturing guidance of *sadhus* and *fakirs* during his formative years to the spiritual teachings of Sitaram ji of Dasua and Sitaram ji of Benaras in his adolescence, and later, the wisdom imparted by Buddhe Baba in adulthood—each played an important role in the mahaguru's spiritual ascent. All were teachers, essential to his journey, yet in his destiny's grand design, only one held the reins to his *aatma*[1]*'s* odyssey—Buddhe Baba.

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1 The essence of an individual that is eternal, unchanging, and indistinguishable from the rest of the universe. It can also be interpreted as the supreme consciousness, either in its entirety or as a divisible individual segment present in each being (in which case it is referred to as *jivaatma*)

While many disciples perceived Buddhe Baba as a manifestation of Shiv, others contend that he was Sitaram ji of Benaras.

Sitaram ji of Benaras was an exceptionally evolved saint who departed from this world *seh sharir*[1]—an extraordinary feat achieved by only a handful of spiritualists, including Jesus and Saint Kabir.

Raji Sharma ji, a disciple, explains, "I have never personally met Buddhe Baba, yet I understand him to be the Shiv *roop*[2] of our *par dada*[3] guru, Sitaram ji of Benaras. Our *par dada* guru is one with Shiv. Let me elaborate on their connection. Gurudev often posed the question: What truly is Shiv? Is Shiv simply the figure perched on a mountain peak with a trident in hand and matted hair? In reality, Shiv symbolises Brahman[4] consciousness or cosmic consciousness—this is the true essence of Shiv. This cosmic consciousness is what our *par dada* guru embodies."

Gurudev's sister-in-law, affectionately known as Chachi ji, throws her hat in the ring and claims that Buddhe Baba was none other than the mahaguru's enlightened *jivaatma*.[5] She asserts, "Gurudev was Shiv himself, and he referred to his evolved form as 'Buddhe Baba'."

My confusion about Buddhe Baba's identity only deepened when I had a powerful vision in which Gurudev guided me to a riverbank where a raft was moored. Upon it stood a divine being wearing a green toga with a distinct square-shaped face that hinted at an ethereal nature. The way Gurudev acted around this figure indicated that this being was of a higher order, even superior in some spiritual aspect. As we boarded the raft, Gurudev reverently

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1 Literally translates to 'along with the body'. Connotes the ability of very evolved saints to ascend to higher realms or *lokas* along with their physical bodies
2 Form
3 Great-grandfather
4 Refers to the ultimate, unchanging reality; *Brahman* is considered the highest principle in the *Vedas* and *Upanishads*, representing the infinite and eternal truth
5 An individualised part of the supreme consciousness or *param-aatma*

offered the only seat to the divine figure accompanying us. He and I stood still as the raft glided seamlessly across the water. The journey unfolded in silence, and I felt I was on that raft because Gurudev wanted to introduce me to this divine being.

Was this figure the elusive Buddhe Baba? Was he a powerful saint of yore? Was he Sitaram ji of Benaras? Amidst various possibilities, certainty eludes me.

The mystery of Buddhe Baba endured throughout Gurudev's eighteen years as mahaguru and remains to this day. Only a select few, such as Gurudev's eldest daughter Renu ji, have had the privilege of seeing him in physical form.

"My first encounter with Buddhe Baba was during my childhood at our home in Shivpuri, Gurgaon. Until that day, I had only heard about him. Daddy would ask us to silently share any deep-seated wish with Buddhe Baba at the sthan," she shares, her voice tinged with nostalgia. "I was home alone, sick with a fever, while Mummy and Daddy were at work. Suddenly, a man dressed in white appeared from the storeroom. He had long white hair and a flowing beard. I don't recall his height, but his upright posture made him seem imposing. Terrified, I covered myself with a blanket, hoping he wouldn't see me. When Mummy returned, I clung to her, saying, 'I am scared.' She reassured me, 'Why are you afraid? This is our home, and we have the sthan here. Chant your mantra'. I told her that even while chanting, I felt his presence linger. 'That was Buddhe Baba,' Mummy calmly assured me, 'He watches over this sthan and all of us.'"

It was widely believed that Buddhe Baba watched over the sthan, shielding both its inhabitants and visitors from negative forces.

A common thread in the stories of those who have seen Buddhe Baba physically or in visions is his portrayal as an elderly, slim, tall figure dressed in white with white hair and a white beard.

Puran ji, a disciple who spent many years at Gurudev's home in Gurgaon, vividly recalls his encounter with Gurudev's guru: "I was privileged to see Buddhe Baba in my dreams. He was a towering figure, robust, dressed in pure white, with a mane of white hair and a distinguished white beard. He was distributing grains to the needy, a sight that still fills me with awe."

In the captivating records of Gurudev's life, his sister Rashmi ji recounts a compelling tale that blends misunderstandings, grief, and mystical experiences.

During a session in which Gurudev imparted wisdom to his disciples, he mentioned that the true depth of his teachings would only be understood after he was 'gone'. Rashmi ji, who overheard this, misinterpreted his words as a forewarning of his imminent departure, which plunged her into deep despair.

Recounting the experience, she says, "The thought of losing my brother left me grief-stricken, and I found myself weeping on the floor of his empty bedroom. Then, a luminous white light materialised, revealing an older man dressed in white with long flowing white hair. Seeing my distress, he gently encouraged me to eat. When I refused, he inquired about my reluctance."

Overcome with emotion, Rashmi ji replied, "How can I eat when my brother will no longer be with me?" The compassionate figure reassured her, "Your brother is not leaving you; he is embarking on a soil survey tour and will return in a few months." With that, the being faded away.

Finding solace in the older man's words, Rashmi ji regained her composure and ate her food. Upon Gurudev's return, she shared her experience with him, convinced that the serene figure wrapped in white light was none other than her brother's enigmatic mentor, Buddhe Baba.

Sightings of Buddhe Baba have also been reported in the years following Gurudev's departure from the physical realm. Mrs Bhalla, Ashok ji's wife, asserts that she has seen Buddhe Baba near Gurudev's *samadhi* at Najafgarh in Delhi. She recounts her experience, "He had a towering presence, emerging almost as a translucent figure before my eyes. Dressed in a *tehmat*,[1] revealing a slender yet strong physique, he moved swiftly and gracefully. Malhotra ji later confirmed my sighting, acknowledging that the figure was indeed Buddhe Baba, the revered guru of Gurudev."

Shifting to a mind-bending dream narrative, Ashok ji shares an account from RC Malhotra ji: "Malhotra ji found himself with Gurudev and Buddhe Baba in what seemed to be an astral meeting. During the meeting, Malhotra ji expressed his opinions, which seemed to upset Buddhe Baba. Holding a *yog dand*,[2] Buddhe Baba struck Malhotra ji on his back. When Malhotra ji awoke in the morning, what he had thought was only a whack in a dream left him with real pain in that same spot. Upon having someone examine his back, they discovered an imprint resembling that of a *yog dand*!"

When Ashok ji asked about the surreal experience of an ethereal beating manifesting physically, Malhotra ji responded cryptically, emphasising the complexities of such spiritual phenomena.

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1 A traditional garment, similar to the *dhoti*. It features a single colour and lacks any border, distinguishing it from other regional variations

2 An ancient tool, conceived by yogis, crafted specifically to manipulate the flow of breath

An upset Buddhe Baba hits Malhotra ji with a yog dand

The notion of bodily repercussions originating from dreams or astral realms is indeed perplexing, almost defying the bounds of logic for many. To entertain the idea that a wound sustained in a dream could manifest physically upon waking stretches the imagination. Yet, I have experienced this phenomenon. During an out-of-the-body experience, I moved upward through a ceiling fan to the room above. On my descent, my astral form briefly intersected with the fan blades. I heard a distinct cracking sound at my ankles, accompanied by sharp pain. By morning, my ankle showed clear signs of injury, leaving me with a limp that lasted several weeks.

The spiritual path toward embodying Shiv involves transcending conventional boundaries linked to names and societal roles. The pursuit of fame and recognition is not merely a worldly distraction but poses significant spiritual risks, potentially rekindling the ego and ensnaring the soul in materialism.

Buddhe Baba chose anonymity as a strategic means to sidestep the constraints and diversions associated with a public identity. He understood that being known could undermine his deeper spiritual objectives, specifically his role in developing Gurudev into a mahaguru and guiding his spiritual growth. He likely stressed to Gurudev the importance of remaining unknown, highlighting that the true worth of their spiritual endeavours extended beyond personal recognition. Selfless service without attachment to one's own identity exemplifies true seva.

In our hyper-connected world, retaining anonymity is challenging, yet it is crucial to recognise that self-promotion and self-glorification will impede spiritual advancement. As the saying goes, *"Hum yahaan apna astitva mitaane aaye hain, banaane nahin"*—we are here to erase our identity, not to construct it.

Chapter 3

Impossible Is Possible

In 1976, Gurudev initiated Shambu ji, a resident of Jwalaji, into seva at Kathog in Himachal Pradesh. Years later, this journey led to an extraordinary moment in Gurgaon, where Shambu ji, Raji Kapoor ji, and others experienced something surreal.

Raji Kapoor ji shares, "Gurudev had extended Shambu ji's life by five years during a previous visit to Himachal Pradesh. Driven by curiosity, Shambu ji requested that Gurudev reveal his five-headed form when he visited Shivpuri. Despite Gurudev's warning that such a vision could cost him his life extension, Shambu ji's determination to witness Gurudev's mystical form was unwavering."

In a display of his spiritual powers, Gurudev revealed his five-headed form exclusively to Shambu ji while others in the room observed Shambu ji's reaction. Overwhelmed by what he saw, Shambu ji fainted. Upon regaining consciousness, he shared his extraordinary vision with the others—Gurudev had transformed into a magnificent, five-faced being, emitting such light that Shambhu ji could not withstand it.

Gurudev later remarked to Shambu ji, "You need a lot of spiritual strength to withstand what you witnessed." In an act of tremendous grace, Gurudev allowed Shambu ji to retain the boon of extended life. Shambu ji eventually passed away in the late 1980s, having lived the life extension of five years granted by the mahaguru.

Kwatra ji sees Gurudev enveloped in blinding, luminous light

A few years after Shambhu ji saw Gurudev's five-headed form, Kwatra ji, a resident of Gurgaon, witnessed a spectacle of light that turned him from a sceptic to a believer. He recalls. "It was 3 am on Mahashivratri. When I arrived at the sthan, there was a long queue to see Gurudev. When I finally met him, I told him I would bow at his feet if he could persuade me that he is my guru. Gurudev sat in *padmasana*[1] with his hands raised. The room instantly filled with dazzling light as if hundreds of suns had risen! I could not stand how bright it was and collapsed at his feet. He blessed me by placing both hands on my head. I am not sure how long I was lying at his feet, but the memory of the incident gives me goosebumps!"

Humsa Dhir ji has been a devoted *sevadaar*[2] for many decades. At the age of 35, she developed muscle fatigue that severely limited

1 A cross-legged seated yogic meditative pose in which each foot is placed on the opposite thigh
2 Someone who serves at a sthan established by Gurudev or his disciples. They engage in various duties, which can include offering refreshments to visitors, managing queues, providing healing to patients, and preparing meals in the kitchen, among other chores

her mobility, requiring her to use a cane to walk. Over time, her condition deteriorated—both legs grew stiff and unresponsive to treatment—plunging her into the throes of negativity. Feeling overwhelmed by the well-intentioned but excessive sympathy from friends and family, Humsa ji reached a decisive moment: "I resolved to bravely face my circumstances, accepting my physical condition and whatever destiny had laid out for me."

That same night, a remarkable event occurred: "I suddenly awoke to see a tall being made entirely of orange-golden light doing something to the lower half of my body."

Initially filled with fear, she watched as the figure stopped its actions and dissolved into the wall behind her bed. "After the initial shock faded, I cautiously touched my leg and attempted to lift it. To my amazement, it moved lightly and rose effortlessly—a feat I had not achieved in many months." She experienced the same miraculous ease with her other leg.

"I was healed," Humsa ji states confidently. "And I believe that the radiant light form was none other than Gurudev."

With his seemingly ordinary exterior, Gurudev epitomised the saying, 'Appearances can be deceptive'. To the casual observer, he might have appeared as just another man walking the path of life. However, beneath this unassuming facade lay a reservoir of extraordinary spiritual force.

Ravi Trehan ji remembers, "One day, I asked Gurudev, 'You are not who you appear to be. I would like to see you in your spiritual form'. In a dream a few days later, I saw him seated on tiger skin on the floor of a cave. A snake was wrapped around his neck and arms, ash was rubbed all over his body, and a trishul[1] was placed

1 A trident or three-pronged spear, often associated with Lord Shankar; it represents the 3 fundamental forces of creation, preservation, and destruction

nearby. The form resembled Lord Shankar, but his face belonged to Gurudev. I did not tell Gurudev about my experience when I met him the next day, but when he saw me, he put his finger to his lips and implied that I should keep quiet about it."

The connection between Gurudev and Shiv transcends simple faith; it is rooted in the conviction that the mahaguru is an *ansh*[1] of Shiv, a belief supported by Rishi Bhrigu in the *Bhrigu Samhita*. This significant connection undoubtedly influences how disciples perceive and internalise their interactions with him.

Raj Laxmi ji, also known as Guddan ji, who manages a sthan in Kanpur, shares, "A few years after I began my spiritual journey with Gurudev, I had a dream where my father's health was worsening. In that dream, I urgently looked for Gurudev. Someone suggested I could find him in a certain room. When I entered the room, I observed Gurudev seamlessly shifting his form between himself and Lord Shankar, back and forth, in a continuous transformation."

The usual constraints of size do not bind the physical forms of evolved saints. It is a well-documented phenomenon in spiritual circles that many saints have manifested in their immense *viraat roops*.[2] These grand appearances, sometimes extending to 20 feet or more, have been witnessed in spiritual figures such as Krishna during the *Mahabharat*[3] and Augarh at Gurudev's home.

There is a lesser-known aspect to these transformations: the ability of saints to reduce their physical size significantly.

Recounting a personal experience, Gupta ji, a disciple from Parwanoo, an industrial town in Himachal Pradesh, shares,

1 In a spiritual context, it refers to a manifestation of a divine entity
2 The celestial form of an entity with the capability to expand up to 20 feet or more in height
3 A historical narrative that recounts the Kurukshetra war between the Pandavas and the Kauravas; the epic is attributed to Rishi Vyasa and is considered one of the longest literary works in the world

"I was fortunate to visit Noorpur to meet Gurudev, who was stationed at a farm at the time. As I waited outside, I saw him briefly through the farmhouse's glass door. Astonishingly, Gurudev, typically around five feet eight inches in height, looked remarkably different. He seemed to be only about four feet tall!"

Gurudev's bilocation represents his mastery over time and space, enabling him to exist in multiple places simultaneously.

KL Bakshi ji, who does seva at the Najafgarh sthan, shares, "Sunil Ghai, from England, called to tell me that Gurudev had visited his shop in London earlier that day. I was stunned because, at the exact time Sunil claimed to have seen Gurudev in London, I was sitting with Gurudev in Gurgaon!"

Dr Shankarnarayan ji once experienced an extraordinary sighting when the mahaguru directed him to visit a hilltop temple established by Adi Shankaracharya. Exiting the temple after chanting his mantras, Shankarnarayan ji was surprised to see Gurudev standing at a distance. Reflecting on this encounter, he shares, "Gurudev appeared to be there, yet when I returned to the office, he had not left the office at all. Upon telling him what I saw, he responded, 'What's the big deal?' and continued his work."

Exploring the concept of *nirman kaya*, or the created body, is essential to understanding bilocation. *Nirman kaya* refers to a unique form crafted through internalising and manipulating energy. This process involves envisioning oneself in a particular *asana*[1] and then utilising specific mantras to shape this visualisation into an energy body that mirrors the physical form. This practice, believed to have been mastered by ancient advanced

1 A physical posture or seat used in yogic practice

yogis, allowed them to create energy duplicates of themselves. These energy bodies were used in conjunction with their physical forms to discharge their karmic liabilities, proving to be a more efficient means than relying solely on the physical body. Given this yogic theory, it is plausible that Gurudev's ability to bilocate stemmed from his adeptness in creating multiple *nirman kayas*.

Many of the mahaguru's disciples have also been seen in places where they were not physically present. This occurrence suggests that they are capable of bilocating, even if they are not consciously aware of this ability.

The names of Virender ji, a distinguished judge, his brother Narender ji and Narender ji's wife, Saroj ji, are recorded in the *Bhrigu Samhita*, anchoring their family's legacy in a historical tapestry that stretches back thousands of years.

Soon after Virender ji's first meeting with Gurudev, the mahaguru promised, "I will create two of you—one to work in the court and the other to assist me". This proclamation was difficult for Virender ji to comprehend at the time.

"In 1988, when I was stationed in Rohtak, Dr Jaising Kharap and his wife approached me one day with a curious inquiry. 'Where were you hurrying to this morning? We tried calling you, but you did not answer,' they said. Confused, I asked, 'At what time?' 'At 6 am,' they responded. I explained, 'I was praying at home at that time. It must have been someone else'. But they insisted, 'No, it was you. You walked past our gate while we were outside'. Despite their insistence, I dismissed the event."

"Another incident happened after a month or so. Mr Bhan Singh Choudhary rang my doorbell one morning. When I opened the door, I said, 'Choudhary Saheb, how are you here?' He replied, puzzled, 'You invited me this morning for tea'. I asked, 'What

time did we meet?' He said, 'It was about 6 am'. Days later, I went to Gurudev and informed him about these incidents. He said, 'I have already told you that I have created two of you.'"

Recalling a memorable incident, Ashish Khanna ji, who manages a sthan at the Moolchand Hospital campus in Delhi, says, "I was in Goa for business, and my cousin and I decided to have lunch at a restaurant. When we asked the waiter for menu suggestions, he recommended prawns. I had been advised against consuming seafood on my first visit to the sthan, but somehow, this slipped my mind. After ordering prawns, my cousin excused himself to use the washroom, leaving me to finalise the remaining selection. As I placed the menu on the table, I was stunned to see my guru, a disciple of Gurudev, sitting across the table. 'How are you here?' he asked. I told him I was with my brother. He remarked, 'I hear the food here is excellent'. I replied, 'Yes, we have ordered prawns'. He smiled; we chatted briefly, and then he left."

Ashish ji immediately phoned his gurubhai[1] in Mumbai, excitedly sharing that he had just met their guru. However, he was stunned when his gurubhai informed him that he had been in a long meeting with their guru in Mumbai and had left just two minutes earlier! Witnessing his guru's uncanny supernature triggered Ashish ji's complete surrender to him, and eating seafood became a footnote in his culinary history.

Nakul Malhotra ji, a Mumbai-based *sevadaar*, shares a mystifying experience that unfolded during his visit to the sthan in Bandra on a Bada Guruvar. At that time, his mother was hospitalised at Bombay Hospital in Marine Lines. After offering his respects to his guru (Gurudev's disciple), Nakul ji set off for the hospital. A few minutes later, he received an unexpected call from his father. "Guruji just visited your mother at the hospital," his father shared.

1 Spiritual brother; spiritual associate

"He looked in through the door, smiled, and left". Confused, Nakul ji responded, "It can't be. I was just with him at the sthan moments ago". His father was adamant, asserting, "I am certain it was him". Given that the travel time between Bandra and Marine Lines typically takes about 40 minutes, even without traffic, this bewildering occurrence left Nakul ji utterly amazed.

Highly advanced yogis can transform the molecular structure of their bodies, effectively stopping light from reflecting off them and, thus, vanishing from sight.

Bindu Lalwani ji recalls two experiences shared by her father, Rajpal Sekhri ji: "Gurudev and Papa travelled from Gurudev's office in Connaught Place to his home in Gurgaon. A large crowd had gathered outside the gate of Gurudev's home. 'Gurudev, there are so many people to meet you. It will take us hours to get to your room', Papa said. 'They will stop us only if they see us', Gurudev remarked casually. Papa was perplexed hearing this, but what happened next was unbelievable!" she exclaims, with a grin. "Gurudev exited the car and began walking briskly towards the gate. No one stopped him or Papa, and they entered the house, proving that he could choose to make himself and anyone accompanying him fully invisible!"

In a spontaneous moment, while visiting the renowned Badrinath temple, I convinced Gurudev to come along. Despite the long queues meticulously managed by the priests, we glided in and out of the temple's precincts completely unnoticed.

Gurudev usually exhibited his powers consciously. Interestingly, his disciples and their downlines have experienced similar phenomena but without their deliberate intent. A striking example occurred with Ashish ji during a vacation in a frozen lake region near Almaty, Kazakhstan. He recounts a sudden and inexplicable transformation upon stepping out of the car:

"Within five minutes of getting out of the car, I felt three times my size. My demeanour and tone of voice changed, and I felt incredibly powerful. My friends were taking photographs as people do on vacation. I sternly warned them not to take mine, but they ignored my advice."

However, they were awestruck when they reviewed the photos at their hotel. One of the pictures of Ashish ji was inexplicably incomplete: it showed only the lower half of his body, with everything above the waist absent, as though he had become partially invisible!

Ordinarily, once individuals pass away, they do not manifest physically, but Gurudev defies this norm. Asha Sekhri ji, a long-time devotee, brings us yet another story showcasing how Gurudev continues to make his presence felt beyond the constraints of the physical world.

She shares, "My daughter called Gurudev on her wedding day and said, 'Gurudev, I will not proceed with the ceremony if you don't attend the wedding'. Gurudev declined as a huge crowd would be at the wedding venue, but my daughter stood her ground. On the night of her wedding, I went upstairs to call her when the *baraat*[1] arrived. She said, 'Mom, Gurudev had come to meet me'. I was stunned. People were at every gate, and no one had seen him enter the venue! He gifted her his ring, assuring her of his presence whenever she looked at it."

"After her marriage, my daughter relocated to Oslo, Norway. She also began attending a class to learn the local language. The area she lived in was quite isolated. One evening, as she was returning from her class, three men started following her, leaving her quite

1 A traditional Indian wedding procession where the groom, accompanied by family and friends, arrives at the bride's home or wedding venue

scared. She remembered the ring Gurudev had gifted her on her wedding day and silently sought his protection. Suddenly, the sound of footsteps intensified behind her. Turning in apprehension, she saw Gurudev, even though he had passed away, walking protectively between her and the men. He accompanied her all the way home and disappeared the moment she opened her front door!"

Rajneesh Sharma ji, who is married to Gurudev's youngest daughter, Alka ji, shares, "Before my wedding, a neighbour who lived on the first floor of my building came to our house. When she saw Gurudev's picture on the wall, she asked my mother if he was related to our family. My mother said he was our guru. The lady then inquired if he was visiting us. We informed her that he had passed on in 1991. She refused to believe us. She claimed that recently she had seen him around our building premises for three or four days in a row! I was delighted that Gurudev was around and watching out for us," he says, smiling.

In July 1992, Narender ji and his wife Saroj ji organised the Maharudra *yagya*.[1] During this time, about 16 priests participated in the rituals. A day before the *yagya*, they were at the sthan in their home when they recall briefly seeing Gurudev in his physical form. On another occasion, they saw a person in all white approaching the *yagshaala*.[2] Everyone in the family was in agreement that it was Gurudev. A few years later, their daughter noticed Gurudev standing at their sthan in Karnal. Before she could react, he had vanished into thin air.

Detractors may write this off as wishful thinking or an overactive imagination, but the reality is that nothing is beyond the mahaguru's abilities. What most people find difficult to accept is just another day in his world.

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1 A Vedic ritual where fire serves as a medium between human and spiritual energies
2 Altar for performing fire rituals

Sudhir, my childhood friend, navigated a life marked by significant triumphs and deep struggles. He achieved considerable success and travelled extensively, only to later grapple with alcoholism and financial woes. After a hard fight, he overcame his addiction, but he still faced other difficulties. Long after Gurudev's passing, Sudhir had a mysterious experience that led him to follow the mahaguru's teachings.

"I was lying in bed one morning, eyes wide open, when suddenly there was a complete hush, and I saw a gentleman, larger than life, about seven to eight feet tall, shirt sleeves folded, in white, looking at me with very kind eyes," he explains. "He put his hand out and said, 'Come, son'. All my senses shut down, leaving only an awareness of this person I had never seen before. From the back of my head, there seemed to be a voice roaring, 'Guruji of Gurgaon'. And then, everything came back. The outward awareness returned, as did the sights and sounds of normal life. I went on the internet to look up 'Guruji of Gurgaon'. After a few false starts, I eventually found an address. I went to Sector 10 in Gurgaon, and lo and behold, I saw Gurudev's images hanging on the walls of the sthan!"

"This was neither a vision nor a dream," Sudhir emphasises. "It has happened more than once. Whenever Gurudev appears, I am completely aware. It is a clear dimension of here and now."

This experience, like many others, leads to a realisation: the limitations imposed by Maya[1] cause ordinary beings to perceive miracles where advanced spiritualists see ordinary occurrences. Advanced spiritual practices combined with *gyan*[2] expand consciousness, making what seems impossible both conceivable and achievable.

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1 Refers to the illusion of the phenomenal world that makes it seem real to human perception. It is the force that creates the illusion of duality and separateness, concealing the true nature of reality, which is unified and divine

2 Refers to an understanding that transcends mere intellectual comprehension

Uddhav ji swings a nunchaku at two triangles that float into his room

Uddhav Kirtikar ji was a Mumbai cop whose story is a lesson in the unexpected nature of spiritual encounters. Despite his robust, athletic exterior, he was curious, often provoking Gurudev to grant him spiritual experiences. When the moment finally arrived, it caught him completely off guard.

"It was half-past nine at night; I was lounging in my room," he recounts. "Suddenly, two black figures shaped like triangles, with eyes glowing a faint yellow, floated in through a window."

Acting on instinct he reached for his nunchaku to swing at them, only to find himself frozen in place. Upon sharing this bizarre incident with Gurudev, he received a humorous response. "You clamour for my visit, and when I oblige, you greet me with a nunchaku," Gurudev playfully chastised.

The next time a triangle with white eyes visited Uddhav ji, he welcomed it with reverence instead of aggression.

I have not had such an experience, but Bade Jain Saheb, a disciple of Gurudev, once encountered a triangle that materialised

before him. Unlike Uddhav ji, he instantly recognised it as a manifestation of a divine being.

Such events reveal the many unseen forces around us. They might be spirits living in our space, guardians protecting us from danger, or manifestations of our own spirits developed with the guidance of a mahaguru.

A story unfolds in the village of Asthal in Dehradun, Uttarakhand, at a site, which was known for an unfinished Shivalay[1] that had not been touched in 16 years. Gurudev appeared in a disciple's dream, asking for its completion, leading to the establishment of a temple and sthan there.

Karamjit ji, a devotee closely linked to this tale, shares a vision he had 35 years ago: "Gurudev showed me a place in Dehradun that would draw and help many people". His surprise grew when he visited Asthal for the temple's inauguration. "The newly established sthan and temple were quite similar to the place Gurudev had shown me in a vision three decades earlier!"

The temple at Asthal has transformed into a powerful site, home to statues of Gurudev and Mataji which are associated with many mystifying events. The creation and consecration of these statues were substantial undertakings. Over a dozen disciples of Gurudev were involved in overseeing their making. More than 65 disciples and their downlines performed the *pran pratishtha*,[2] a ritual vital to infusing consciousness into the statues. This collective effort has amplified the temple's spiritual potency.

Ridhim Thapar ji, who does healing seva at Asthal, shares, "Once, while praying at the temple, I looked up at the statue. Gurudev's

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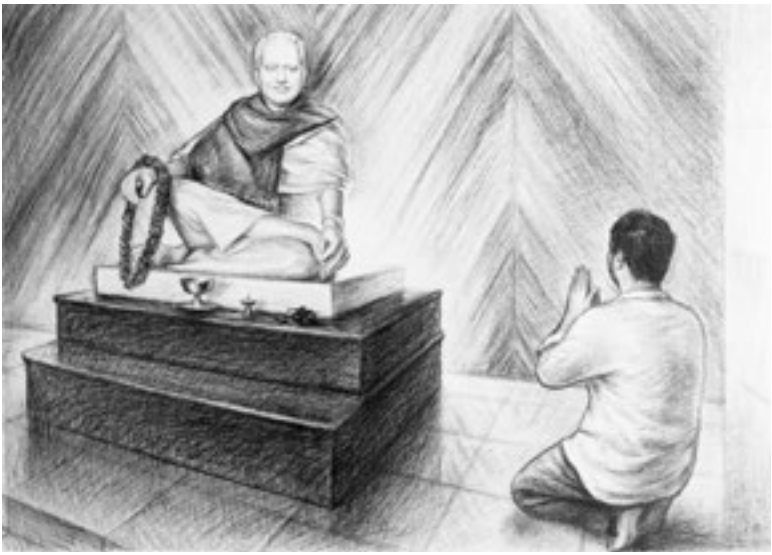
1 A place of worship dedicated to Shiv, where a Shivling is enshrined
2 Refers to a ritual where life (*pran*) is symbolically infused into a deity's idol or statue. This ceremony is considered essential for consecrating new idols in temples or even in home shrines



Ridhim ji sees Gurudev's statue smiling at him

face had turned, and he was smiling at me. It was as though the statue had come to life."

Alpana ji, a devotee of Gurudev, reflects on a particularly difficult period in her life: "I was facing the worst financial crisis ever. During that time, I often visited Asthal, sitting in the temple and confiding in Gurudev's statue as though it were my father". She recalls a moment of connection, "Once, as I spoke to the statue, I could have sworn it smiled at me!"

She continues, "When my son lost his job in Canada, I implored Gurudev's statue to help him find employment. It felt as though Gurudev was truly listening to me. The very next morning, my son called to tell me, 'Mumma, I've been contacted by Hilton for an interview'. And, miraculously, he secured the job!" Her voice fills with wonder as she adds, "On another occasion, it wasn't Gurudev I saw, but Lord Shankar, sitting in meditation with folded hands, radiating light from where the statue stands. The statue took on a blue hue, glowing with an aura. I was sceptical at first, but each time I looked, I witnessed the same form."

Asthal proves that inanimate objects such as statues, once ordinary, have become imbued with the mahaguru's consciousness, turning them into more than mere symbols of devotion; they have become extensions of his spiritual presence and grace.

Shilpa Malhotra ji, who has dedicated decades to seva, recounts her experience of grace standing in prayer before Gurudev's statue. "In my mind's eye, I saw Gurudev appear in a towering form behind the statue. He looked down at me and extended his hand, offering me a ball of light". When she shared this vision with her guru, he explained that the vision symbolised the transfer of the mahaguru's energy to Shilpa ji.

Mohan, the temple's *pandit*, evolved from scepticism to belief through his experiences with Gurudev's statue. Though he often sought healing during my visits to Asthal, he doubted the power of the sthan. "Initially, I doubted Gurudev's powers," he confesses. "However, a visitor encouraged me, saying, 'Don't just see this as a statue; consider it as Gurudev's presence'. I decided to test this belief. Plagued by a toothache, I addressed the statue, requesting healing. I placed a glass of *jal* at its feet, which I drank shortly after. To my amazement, my toothache disappeared. I later sought relief from some ongoing urinary tract-related problems. Incredibly, that issue was also resolved, and I remained symptom-free for the next two to three years!"

Gautam Bhushan ji, who conducts healing seva at the Delhi sthan, recounts another compelling experience: "While meditating at the temple at Asthal, I experienced a powerful surge of energy that seemed to transport my consciousness inside Gurudev's statue. Looking through the statue's eyes, I felt an overwhelming sensation of omnipotence, as if I understood everything there was to know. During this state, I saw a devotee from Delhi meditating in the temple. He had been suffering from severe pain and was part of a remote healing group where *sevadaars* offer healing via

video conferencing. I directed my intention toward healing him. The entire experience lasted about 20 minutes."

He continues, "About a week later, during a video healing session, the same devotee from Delhi informed us that the intense pain, which he had previously described as '20 on a scale of 10', had completely vanished!"

The mahaguru's statue has made my role almost redundant, and it is an honour to witness and embrace this irrelevance.

This book offers a mere glimpse into Gurudev's expansive supernature, yet it powerfully compels us to reflect deeply on the extraordinary potential of spiritual capabilities. Gurudev's life was a testament to the possible, transforming sceptics into believers and leading many to become beacons of what once seemed impossible. So, ask yourself this: If one individual can manifest as Shiv, what might you, too, be capable of achieving?

Chapter 4

Saint-maker

The enigma of how Gurudev chose his disciples is a peculiar tale, as most of his chosen ones, including myself, hardly fit the mould of traditional spiritual seekers. We were diverse, pulled from different professions and academic backgrounds, with many among us, like me, barely grasping the basics of spirituality. We did not realise then that our outwardly ordinary attributes belied the underlying connection we shared with the mahaguru.

Decades ago, I had a vision of Gurudev resting on an invisible platform suspended in the sky with five or six of us in attendance. We witnessed hundreds of bald monks dressed in cream-coloured togas descending to earth on an invisible escalator. I intuitively sensed that they would be part of a joint spiritual mission of personal development and changing the ethos of millions on this planet. These beings were born into whatever wombs were available, aligning with the mahaguru at different stages in life. Some wombs were designated for a second wave of disciples, others for future generations. This spiritual relay is set to unfold over approximately 250 years, with the overarching goal of guiding individuals to reassess their attitudes and evolve into saints.

Gurudev gathered the first wave of these scattered disciples in this lifetime, drawing them back into his spiritual sphere. Some found their way to him in pursuit of healing for themselves or loved ones, while others came searching for guidance through life's tumultuous journey. Upon their arrival, Gurudev welcomed them with the knowing phrase, "*Tu aa gaya, putt*! (You have come, my child)"—a simple greeting that held layers of

recognition mired in ancient bonds. Though they did not know it then, these words were far from mere pleasantries; they were an acknowledgement of a reunion centuries in the making.

Ravi ji shares a poignant observation: "The guru shoulders the duty of guiding his disciples, binding his evolution to theirs. He cannot progress until they do; they are in his charge, and he cannot forsake them mid-journey. Gurudev made it clear that he returned to this life to advance his spiritual family beyond the point they had reached in their past lives."

Under Gurudev's guidance, the rekindled connections became channels for spiritual awakening. He nurtured their spiritual growth and equipped them with the tools and symbols of seva, empowering them to extend their seva to others.

Puran ji reflects on the deep bonds that tied Gurudev's disciples to him: "Gurudev often spoke of the 500-year journey to reunite us in this lifetime. Our destinies were entwined long before."

Gurudev's gathering was a meticulous orchestration, drawing individuals from across the globe, artfully cloaking destiny as coincidence. Puran ji himself was privy to revelations about his past connections with Gurudev—once during a period of seva in Ujjain and then again in the era of Guru Nanak Dev, over 500 years prior.

Giri Lalwani ji, a disciple, was told by Gurudev, "Our bond goes beyond a single lifetime and spans across many". He was made to understand that this connection is not unique to them but includes other disciples who have accompanied Gurudev through his previous incarnations as a guru.

Gurudev also shed light on my past existence, which provided a key to understanding the link between my former and current lives. He described the past-life me as a respected saintly figure whose *ashram*[1] commands reverence and visitation to this day. Initially, I was sceptical. Yet, with time, I have witnessed the convergence of my past with my present, an unfolding of the spiritual continuity that Gurudev foresaw with clarity.

After pondering the depth of the disciple-guru bond, Ravi ji approached Gurudev with a request: "I am eager to understand the nature of our past-life connections". Gurudev responded with a touch of mystique: "My son if I were to simply recount your past, where would be the wonder in that? Recite the Mahaguru mantra as you drift into sleep and find out for yourself."

"While doing the mantra, I was transported back 150–170 years to a grand mansion, a dwelling with 20 or more rooms where Gurudev would visit and reside for months," Ravi ji recounts. "It was a place visited by those who are my gurubhais today."

He drew the mansion and presented the sketch to Gurudev, who confirmed it stood in Shahjahanpur, Uttar Pradesh. Fuelled by curiosity, Malhotra ji went to Shahjahanpur with Ravi ji's sketch. There, the congruence between Ravi ji's dreamt memories and the present reality was affirmed, except that the courtyard, once paved with mud, had since been replaced with cement.

When Ravi ji probed further into the nature of their spiritual relationship, Gurudev urged him to seek the answers within. Persevering in meditation, Ravi ji was transported even further back in time to the mountains of North India in a vision. There, he saw his past self, an ascetic of old age, meditating in caves with Gurudev and a few gurubhais. The clarity of the vision was

1 A spiritual hermitage or retreat, led by a spiritual teacher or guru that serves as a place for learning, self-reflection, and spiritual growth

Ravi ji is transported to a past incarnation in his dream

striking, from the pattern of his blanket to the cave that was Gurudev's sanctuary.

Through these visions, Ravi ji understood that the threads of his and his gurubhais' association with the mahaguru were not woven in a single lifetime but were part of a continuous spool, stretching back through centuries of shared devotion and spiritual pursuit.

Santlal ji's transformation from a life of bureaucratic arrogance to spiritual enlightenment is a tale of stark metamorphosis. Initially, he was far from what one might consider a potential disciple, yet he evolved into an exemplar of disciplehood.

He recounts his pursuit of a spiritual guru: "In the heart of Punjab lies Gangowal, where I heard of a wise *sadhu*. My first encounter with him was anticlimactic; he asked me to return the next day. Disappointed but persistent, I requested an early meeting, only to be asked to return every day for five days. I waited for hours in

long queues to meet him. On the fifth day, the *sadhu* confessed that he could not take me under his wing, for my spiritual allegiance lay elsewhere—with someone present at the time in the same town, no less!"

Years passed before fate finally guided Santlal ji to the guru he sought. A business journey brought him to Gurgaon, where chance encounters ushered him to meet the mahaguru. They met at midnight, and Gurudev's simple *lungi*[1]-clad appearance took Santlal ji aback, challenging his preconceived notions of a guru's grandeur. He admits, "I was sceptical because I had trouble believing that a man so simple could be a guru. I asked him if he had visited Gangowal in 1960, and he said he had. I wondered whom he had met, and he perfectly described the *sadhu* I had met."

During their first meeting, Gurudev shared an important insight: the journey to finding a guru is not driven by the disciples' search but by the guru's intuitive selection of his disciples. He also revealed the remarkable breadth of his bond with Santlal ji, which extended across nine previous incarnations. Additionally, he mentioned that the blessings Santlal ji's mother bestowed upon her son had brought forward their destined encounter by two years!

Many of us approached the idea of meeting the mahaguru with scepticism. The thought that a mere man, as he appeared, had the power to transform our destinies, bring about remarkable changes in our lives, and heal us and our loved ones seemed to challenge our rational minds. Persuasion was often required for us even to consider such a meeting. Yet, once we were in his presence, we found ourselves drawn into his spiritual influence.

1 A traditional garment worn by men in South Asia, particularly in India, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka. It is a simple piece of cloth, usually cotton, wrapped around the waist and tied in place

This reminds me of a couplet by Saint Kabir: *Laali mere laal ki, jit dekhoon tit laal. Laali dekhan main gayi, main bhi ho gayi laal.* The couplet captures the disciple's experience, who, upon finding the master, becomes imbued with the same rich hue that colours the master's greatness. Similarly, our very essence was altered by the impact of the mahaguru's formidable presence.

Lal Saheb's initiation into the sthan was marked by a nonchalant curiosity rather than a quest for solutions, setting his story apart from the rest. As a self-described average Indian-Canadian, his life was filled with social festivities until a chance meeting at a temple piqued his interest in a guru visiting Toronto. Following an impromptu decision, Lal Saheb was embroiled in a seemingly endless waiting game that tested his patience over several days.

"I had no pressing issues and no ailments. Merely a whim led me to Gurudev's doorstep," he recalls. His bemusement with the concept of a guru would soon take a turn. On the third day of his persistent visits, he received half a cup of tea, a gesture he initially thought of as a mistake. Nonetheless, he drank it, and later, when called upon by Gurudev, he found himself agreeing to undertake seva, a concept alien to him at the time. Though Lal Saheb was unaware, the half-consumed tea was the medium through which Gurudev imparted a part of his spiritual essence.

Months later, a visit to Gurgaon subjected Lal Saheb to a similar pattern of wait and brief encounters, culminating in Gurudev's cryptic instruction to be present when Mataji lit a *jyot*[1] at the sthan at dawn on the first day of the new year. These interactions, though fleeting, marked the beginning of Lal Saheb's transformation into a devout disciple.

1 A Sanskrit term meaning light or flame. In Hindu rituals, it typically refers to a sacred flame lit during prayer or acts of worship

Gurudev had set his sights on Lal Saheb even before setting foot in Toronto, a fact I was privy to when he expressed his intent to travel there to give someone seva. The ensuing events were a testament to faith and patience, virtues that Lal Saheb unknowingly exhibited, which led to his spiritual awakening.

Like Lal Saheb, other disciples were led to Gurudev either through family and friends or within larger gatherings. Each disciple's path to the mahaguru was uniquely tailored yet perfectly woven into a preordained spiritual assembly.

At the pinnacle of Gurudev's spiritual hierarchy stood Malhotra ji, his first disciple, with whom he embarked on the quest to refine the quintessence of guruhood. "Gurudev and I shared a close friendship," Malhotra ji recalls, subtly highlighting the challenge of acknowledging a friend as a spiritual mentor.

Malhotra ji's past lifetimes, adorned with sainthood, barely lingered in his conscious memory. The powers he received from Gurudev were to him as novel as a child's toy, and he approached them with the same experimental curiosity.

An anecdote encapsulates this phase: an impolite fruit vendor's comment ignited Malhotra ji's temper, prompting him to telepathically incite a bull to charge at the fruit cart. Complying with his silent command, the bull aggressively gored the cart with its horns, overturning it. Though a showcase of Malhotra ji's emerging powers, this incident was a departure from Gurudev's teachings, who consistently emphasised using one's spiritual gifts for the greater good, not personal retribution. In this instance, Malhotra ji's misuse of his abilities led to a stern reprimand from the mahaguru.

Through his rigorous spiritual journey and the refinement of his qualities, Malhotra ji grew adept at handling the potent spiritual

Malhotra ji wills a bull to upend a fruit cart

powers he had been endowed with. His evolution in spiritual stature enabled him to assist Gurudev in guiding the new waves of disciples and devotees entering the transformative fold of Gurudev's saint-making factory. Affectionately called Papaji,[1] Malhotra ji's insightful wisdom and heartfelt devotion won him the cherished title of '*Chote* Guruji',[2] signifying his spiritual prowess and role as a living manifestation of his guru's principles.

Choosing a life of celibacy, he devoted over half his life to seva and managing the affairs of the sthan. His efforts saw the establishment of the sthan at Najafgarh, adjacent to Gurudev's *samadhi*. In the wake of Gurudev and Mataji's transcendence from the physical realm, Malhotra ji steered the institution, preserving its sanctity and vision until his last breath. His legacy, seeped in the essence of his guru, continues to inspire and nurture the path of countless seekers.

1 Punjabi term of endearment for an elder brother or male elder
2 Term used to signify a spiritual heir

Gurudev's quest for his predestined disciples was a spiritual endeavour that demanded much of his attention. Those from Himachal Pradesh and other North Indian states were more receptive to his call, quickly blending into his spiritual milieu. The Mumbaikars, however, presented a greater challenge with their agnostic leanings and scepticism towards spirituality.

I, a typical Mumbai sceptic, witnessed Gurudev's miraculous healing powers when he cured me of severe arthritis. Yet, I could not develop faith. It took another five years and a series of surreal events to finally shift my perspective. It was during my time in Africa that the undeniable influence of Gurudev became apparent. Every time I veered towards forbidden escapades, an unseen force intervened. With each thwarted attempt at impropriety, the image of the *kada* Gurudev had energised and placed on my wrist years earlier would emerge in my mind's eye. As peculiar as they were, these events occurred too frequently to be mere chance. It dawned on me that these were not coincidences but Gurudev's subtle influence at work. His invisible hand quite masterfully browbeat me to faith.

The legacy of the mahaguru as a saint-maker endures, with his teachings continuing to cultivate saints with the same fervour as during his lifetime. Numerous individuals who have never encountered him physically but are linked to him from previous lifetimes are reawakening to the deep connections they share.

Roshini Dhir ji, a *sevadaar*, shares a dream she had a few years after coming to the sthan: "I was at a place where rows and rows of Shivlings[1] emerged from the ground. Many people were circumambulating these structures and watering them. Gurudev was walking among these rows, invisible to everyone but me. When I touched his feet, he blessed me and said, '*Putt, tera mera*

1 An abstract representation of Shiv; it is typically a rounded, elliptical, aniconic image that sits on a circular base called the *Yoni*, which symbolises Shakti

janmaan janmaan da rishta hai (Our connection spans many, many lifetimes)'. I then realised that even though I have never seen him in physical form in this lifetime, he has been a vital part of my existence far longer than I consciously know."

Many others, engaged in seva at Gurudev's sthans around the globe, echo this realisation. Khozu Arsiwalla ji, who serves devotedly at the sthans in Mumbai and Lonavala, shares: "In my dream, I encountered Gurudev and Guruji (Gurudev's disciple) seated together. Guruji approached me and drew something on my forehead, and declared, '*Ab se tu ek guru hai* (From now onward, you are a guru).'" This moment highlighted Khozu ji's spiritual elevation, which was marked personally by the mahaguru's presence despite Khozu ji never having met him in the physical realm.

Every day, more individuals report experiencing the mahaguru's guidance through dreams, visions, and even rare physical encounters, highlighting his ongoing commitment to the continuity of the spiritual institution he founded with Buddhe Baba's guidance.

For some, the path is smooth; for others, it is challenging, yet several others seamlessly blend into the mix. Gurudev's saint-making factory has become a remarkable success story, where many of his disciples and devotees have found their roles and purpose. United by this communal journey, our gratitude towards him is not just a fleeting emotion but a perpetual state of being. We bask not only in his reflected glory but also in the collective radiance of our transformed selves, forever indebted to his transformative touch.

Chapter 5

Seva

During an insightful conversation with Rajpal ji, Gurudev shared his wisdom: "God or *param-aatma*[1] lives within every being. If you want to please God, please the gods in human form. Every person faces struggles, be it pain, illness, or adversity; your mission is to ease their suffering and minimise their distress."

Gurudev's transformative view on seva focused on serving the divine essence within each person, not merely the individuals themselves. This method proposes that by achieving a higher state of consciousness and recognising aatmic equality, one can connect with the inner divinity of others while remaining anchored in the material world. While this concept might seem straightforward, its implications are profound.

"Gurudev provided food, shelter, clothing to the less fortunate, and even financially assisted in the weddings of his devotees," Subbhash ji notes. "He readily dipped into his savings and provident fund to offer a helping hand."

The mahaguru advocated assisting in the *kanyadaan*[2] of girls from underprivileged families. Yet, in his humility, he undertook these gestures silently, never craving recognition. In addition to using his financial resources for seva, he contributed through his hands-on efforts.

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1 The supreme consciousness; often equated with *Brahman* or the ultimate reality
2 A traditional Hindu ritual in which the father of the bride gives his daughter away in marriage, symbolising the gifting of his daughter to the groom. It is considered a higher form of seva

"Gurudev was passionate about farming and did not mind getting his clothes dirty," Giri ji recalls. "He often said, 'Inspire others to serve, but also do seva yourself. Beyond physical acts, extend seva through your words. Speak kindly and avoid being harsh or rude. Turn every situation into an opportunity for seva.'"

Pratap Singh ji, Gurudev's superior at work and an agnostic, was witness to the mahaguru's dedication. Even though his years of knowing Gurudev never made him a devotee, it fostered a deep respect for his junior. He recalls, "The man hardly had a moment to spare. Both at home and work, he was met by crowds seeking his guidance. Despite this, he always greeted each person with a genuine smile."

From the moment the mahaguru embraced his calling of seva, he became a constant source of hope that anyone could turn to at any time. Neither personal discomfort nor concerns of his family could hold him back.

"He was genuinely concerned about the public's comfort," Alka ji recalls. "I never heard him say, 'I am tired'. He would do seva, meet people, work, visit the farm, and do his *paath*, but he never said, 'It is tiring. I am not going to do it'. He listened to everyone patiently and tried to bring them relief. He never took a break from seva."

Bharat Dalal ji, a *sevadaar* at the Mumbai sthan, received a pivotal message in a dream from the mahaguru. He recounts, "Two individuals led me to a barren expanse that felt like a different dimension. There, I beheld a striking scene—thousands seated in neat rows before Gurudev. Despite Gurudev speaking in an unfamiliar language, the essence of his words about seva and karma resonated with me intuitively."

As Gurudev moved among the assembled crowd, offering blessings, the moment for Bharat ji's interaction arrived. He

recalls, "Gurudev gazed at me with deep intensity. His words were clear and resonant, 'Seva never stops. It continues 24/7.'"

Naubatram ji, who lived near Gurudev in Shivpuri in the 1970s, often talks about how reliable the mahaguru was, especially regarding his sick son, who struggled with a chronic allergy and had many tough days and nights. Gurudev had told him, "Whenever your son is unwell, do not hesitate to come to me, no matter how late it is". Naubatram ji did precisely that, visiting Gurudev at all hours, whether it was eleven at night or two in the morning. Gurudev was always ready to help. The amazing part? Every time Naubatram ji returned home, he would find his son feeling better.

This spirit of generosity and accessibility extended beyond Gurudev's neighbours and encompassed his colleagues as well. Despite earning a modest salary, the mahaguru regularly allocated a portion to assist others, a practice observed first-hand by Haribabu Gupta ji, who operated a tea stall at Gurudev's office block at Curzon Road in Delhi.

While Gurudev attended to visitors at the tea stall, he offered tea as a warm gesture to those around. A few colleagues took advantage of his kindness, ordering tea and quietly adding the expense to his tab. When Dwarkanath ji pointed out that some opportunistic co-workers were exploiting his generosity, the mahaguru responded with his characteristic philosophy: "*Yeh kal bhi peete the, hum kal bhi peelate the. Yeh aaj bhi peete hain, hum aaj bhi peelate hain. Yeh kal bhi piyenge, hum kal bhi pilayenge*". The response metaphorically highlighted the enduring nature of selfless service. Gurudev viewed it as the fate of his co-workers to receive and his to give, reinforcing the idea that the act of giving should remain unaffected by the nature or behaviour of the receiver.

"Gurudev always emphasised the irrelevance of a visitor's deeds, whether virtuous or sinful," Krishanmohan ji, who manages a sthan in Durgarpur, West Bengal, adds. "Bearing that in mind, my sole focus in seva has been to serve unconditionally without casting judgment. I see only the divine essence in every individual I meet."

An anecdote about Gurudev vividly exemplifies this ethos. Once, while embarking on his journey of seva under Buddhe Baba's guidance, two individuals with seemingly questionable pasts approached him for help. Torn between helping and the moral ambiguity of their past actions, a clear inner voice directed him, "Serve all who come to you, free from bias or preference". Gurudev embraced this principle wholeheartedly, urging us to do the same.

In a world where the allure of wealth and luxury tempts many spiritual leaders, Gurudev's unwavering integrity shines through. He remains an example of ethical leadership, refusing to commodify his spiritual guidance for personal gain.

Rajpal ji compares Gurudev's approach to other spiritual leaders: "Many spiritual leaders take money from devotees and live the high life. They usually are the first to eat at gatherings and expect the best accommodations and logistics. But I have never seen Gurudev take a single penny from anyone."

He further shares a story about a Sikh man with a constant, unbearable headache: "Despite going to top-notch hospitals, he did not find any relief. Gurudev offered to help him but set two conditions: the man had to stop eating meat and drinking alcohol. Two weeks later, the Sikh gentleman returned, carrying a briefcase filled with one lakh rupees. The man had promised to give this money to whoever could cure him. But Gurudev, staying true to his beliefs, turned down the money. He also told

the man that accepting it would undo the healing that had given him complete relief."

Gurudev was a model of resourcefulness and simplicity. Instead of building elaborate temples or *ashrams*, he introduced the concept of sthans, or home-based spiritual centres for help and healing. These rooms, set up in the homes of disciples, became mini spiritual hubs, making it easy to engage in seva across various locations without straining finances.

Giri Lalwani ji elaborates on Gurudev's visionary approach: "He understood how hard it was for many people to get to Gurgaon. That is why he led the way in setting up sthans worldwide—from big cities to small villages. His intention was clear-cut: to make it as easy as possible for everyone to benefit from seva while reducing travel discomfort and costs."

In his pursuit to bring seva to all corners of the world, the mahaguru embodied the famous saying: if the mountain won't come to Muhammad, then Muhammad must go to the mountain.

My spiritual journey began alongside Suresh Prabhu ji. Gurudev had prophesied Suresh ji's ascendancy to political prominence, envisioning him as an influential figure whose voice would resonate globally. Both Suresh ji and I found this hard to fathom, especially since he did not even possess a passport at the time. But a decade later, it all made sense.

Suresh ji admits, "Gurudev's approach to seva, manifesting in various impactful forms, has always guided me. I have remained in the background, in line with his principle that true seva does not seek recognition. Gurudev, despite his vast contributions, would often redirect accolades, modestly stating, 'I am not the one; he *(pointing to a disciple doing seva)* is the guru.'"

"It is rare to find a spiritual mentor, or any mentor for that matter, who sidesteps recognition even for acts they have directly catalysed. In politics, many claim achievements they have not made," he chuckles. "Yet, Gurudev declined accolades even for deeds he rightfully owned."

Gurudev always emphasised the significance of seva while simultaneously teaching the virtue of humility and diminishing self-importance while doing it. Pradeep Sethi ji, a disciple, recounts a transformative moment: "One Bada Guruvar, I took a short afternoon nap. I had a vision that I was at the sthan doing seva. However, I was touching the feet of the visitors instead of them seeking my blessings. When I awoke, this vision resonated deeply, reminding me that I am, at heart, a devoted servant."

Gurudev once told Bittu ji, "The real gods are those who come to the sthan. A guru must serve them to be of value. True service is catering to those who visit your guru's sthan."

Echoing Gurudev's teachings, we should embrace gratitude towards those who bestow upon us the honour of serving them. Through them, we get a chance to introspect, improve our self-reflections, and progress spiritually. Their presence aids us in circumventing the 'snakes' of spirituality and ascending the ladders of our spiritual journey.

Suresh Kohli ji beautifully encapsulates seva's essence: "The purest reward of seva lies in the heartfelt blessings we receive. Such blessings are priceless and impossible to force or buy. They emanate from the soul, echoing '*Bhagwan tumhara bhala karein* (May the divine favour you)'. This sentiment, more than anything else, is the true fruit of seva. Furthermore, true seva is rooted in selflessness. It is not pursued out of desire for recognition or accolades but undertaken as a sacred duty."

Gurudev's life was a living example of this ideal, as he never claimed credit for the seva he rendered. Instead, he humbly

attributed his seva to Buddhe Baba just like his disciples attribute their seva to him. Inspired by his approach, we transitioned from an 'I do' mindset to 'It unfolds through me'. By letting go of ownership, we could liberate ourselves from past karma and minimise the accumulation of new karmic credits or debts. Recognising that we do not own our virtues also enabled us to relinquish ownership of our flaws. This remarkable shift accelerated our spiritual evolution.

Ravi ji reflects: "When individuals seek my guidance, the solutions I offer come from a state of deeper awareness. Strangely, mere moments later, I cannot recall the advice given, yet the issues invariably find resolution. These insights flash briefly, channelling through me. In such instances, I merely function as a vessel, with Gurudev being the guiding force. He uses me to relay messages to the person before me. In these instances, I merely exist as a vessel through whom the guru's grace manifests."

Suresh Sharma ji from Kotla, Himachal Pradesh, echoes Ravi ji's point of view: "When I claim, 'I will heal you', the healing does not manifest. Yet, when I channel the blessings of Gurudev by invoking him, miraculous healings happen."

Dhruv Bhalla ji and his wife Kanika ji have dedicated themselves to selflessly serving people in Kolkata, West Bengal. Their work includes performing healing seva and operating a free clinic for pain management.

Dhruv ji shares an insightful story: "A young girl with severe neurological issues had been in our care since she was three years old. Her legs were bent from the hips down, and while she could sit, standing was an impossibility. We diligently worked on healing her for over three years but saw little improvement.

It was a situation that left us all feeling helpless. Despite the absence of progress, her father's unwavering faith in the sthan was particularly moving."

"Then, something extraordinary happened," he explains. "During one of our healing sessions, I heard an inner voice that confidently declared, 'This girl will stand. It will happen.' I hadn't planned to speak those words out loud but I did. The room fell silent, and everyone looked at me as if I had lost touch with reality. That day, the father and daughter left filled with renewed hope, while I was overwhelmed with trepidation."

He shares a pivotal moment: "In the middle of the week, I listened to a segment from Gurudev's audio biography on a podcast, where a story of Gurudev healing someone with a similar problem was featured. The following Saturday, I mimicked Gurudev's method: I positioned my feet near the girl's toes and carefully lifted her by the armpits. Normally, during healing sessions, I would chant a specific mantra, but I intuitively switched to a different one on this occasion. As I held her in that position for a few minutes, I witnessed something extraordinary—her legs began to straighten, and she could stand. She can now stand with assistance. This experience reaffirmed my belief that my role as a healer is to act as a channel for the sthan's energy and fully embrace its guiding flow."

Through such experiences, many of us have discerned a powerful and significant lesson: when at seva, we are merely instruments of a greater force, not actors of our limited individuality. This underlines a vital learning: our belief in ourselves often mirrors our faith in a guiding force or spiritual mentor. By attributing actions to this higher power, it is as if we are metaphysically inviting its benevolent intervention.

During my early years in spiritualism, Gurudev asked me to be present at the Gurgaon sthan on every Bada Guruvar to perform seva. My name was always on the duty chart, but each time I arrived, the person assigned before me would ask to continue through my shift. It wasn't easy to deny such a request, so I would reluctantly agree. This was particularly frustrating because I travelled from Mumbai to Gurgaon, investing in costly airfare, only to discover I was not needed for the assigned tasks.

A few months into this routine, Gurudev called me into his room to discuss my experiences with seva. Initially hesitant, I eventually shared my frustration. To my surprise, he listened with an amused smile and then offered a puzzling insight: "Son, what I need from you is not tied to specific tasks. I need you to be available so when the time comes, I can channel your energy into my work."

Initially, his words were cryptic, yet their significant implications emerged upon thoughtful consideration. Gurudev frequently shared that he would meditate on us during patient treatments, channelling our collective energies to assist others. In time, I realised that the true value of our contribution extends beyond mere physical deeds—it rests in the preparedness and openness of our spirits to integrate with the sthan's broader purpose.

The phrase 'Service before self' may seem overused to some, but it was the bedrock of Gurudev's philosophy. He often said, "Serve my purpose, and I will fulfil yours", a guiding principle that has influenced my life and the lives of many of my gurubhais.

Pradeep ji faced a moral quandary when his daughter, Pragya, sustained a severe head injury from a fall, leaving her semi-conscious. He had previously committed to visiting a young cancer patient that very day—a commitment made all the more poignant because the boy's father had dreamt of Pradeep ji healing his son.

Faced with the agonising choice of either rushing his daughter to Gurudev for immediate healing or honouring his promise to the cancer patient's father, Pradeep ji prioritised his spiritual duty over personal urgency and first visited the young cancer patient.

Subsequently, Pradeep ji and his daughter travelled to Gurgaon to seek Gurudev's intervention. Upon their arrival, Gurudev greeted them with a knowing smile. He blessed Pragya and began her path to recovery.

"Gurudev had a natural tendency to care for others. For him, it was not about seeking praise or self-gratification; it was an inner calling that drove him to offer unconditional support and care," Bittu ji recalls. "He understood what people were going through, whether they were happy, sad, or facing problems. He had a knack for making everyone feel valued. As a result, people were willing to wait in line for hours to talk to him, each feeling a unique, personal connection as if Gurudev was focused solely on them."

From dawn to the wee hours of the following day, Gurudev's unwavering dedication to seva was evident in the rhythm of his daily life. Pappu ji, who spent considerable time in close proximity to Gurudev, noted that for the mahaguru, ordinary needs like sleep or food were mere footnotes: "The focal point of his existence was the betterment of others. He was not just dabbling in acts of kindness; seva was his lifeblood, his reason for being."

While others slept, Gurudev's dedication remained undiminished. His day would typically close around 2 am or 3 am. Yet, by 5 am, he would rise again, ready to pour himself into another day of sculpting a life dedicated to enriching others. The tireless seva he exemplified left an indelible mark on those around him. In observing his unparalleled commitment, many found a spark, a motivation to serve, even if in fragments of his magnitude.

Giri ji marvels at Gurudev's endless reservoir of energy, saying, "He always seemed fresh, no matter the time of day or night. I never saw him tired nor did I see him sleep". When questioned about his extraordinary stamina, Gurudev responded, "If the guru sleeps, everything comes to a standstill. So, how can I afford to sleep?"

For Gurudev, sleep transcended the mere act of resting the body. He viewed it as an ethereal journey where his spirit would voyage beyond the physical realm, leaving his body temporarily inactive. A significant part of his seva took place on the astral plane. During these periods, he would engage in *paath*, entering a state of deep meditation that enabled his consciousness to partially detach from his physical form. This facilitated astral travel, allowing him to extend aid and healing across the global network of sthans he had established.

"We would often be with him past midnight, only to find him up and about at dawn. Such patterns left us perplexed," Giri ji adds. "But with time, we grasped that his need for rest was minimal, and he had mastered a unique form of sleep that few could fathom". Remarkably, he had the unique ability to let one-half of his body rest in sleep while keeping the other half awake and alert.

While Gurudev never expressly mentioned it, his commitment to seva, from India to far-off places like Chicago and Toronto, required his unwavering attention. No matter where they were in the world, his disciples felt his presence whenever they were involved in seva and with Gurudev as their guiding light, blessings and healing appeared to emanate effortlessly.

The mahaguru perceived every being as an extension of himself. This way of living is the ultimate expression of the philosophy of *Aham Brahmasmi*,[1] which upholds the idea that all life forms

1 A tenet of Advaita Vedanta philosophy, which teaches the fundamental unity of the *Aatma* and *Brahman*, emphasising the oneness of all existence

are manifestations of a single universal consciousness worthy of respect and compassion.

Gautam Bhushan ji shares a remarkable experience that illustrates this universal connection: "During meditation, I experienced an incredible expansion of my being as if dispersing across vast spaces. I first became a blade of grass, deeply sensing its simple existence, marked by limited cognition but abundant feeling. I then morphed into a leaf of a lotus-like plant, a tree trunk, and a smooth stone with a distinct crack. In each state, I felt an intimate connection with these elements."

The journey toward recognising ourselves as the *param-aatma*, rather than merely an individual *jivaatma*, involves shedding the restrictive labels and boundaries imposed by the material world. We must envision our essence as permeating every atom of the universe. Only by seeing our existence reflected in the existence of others, do we truly grasp the meaning of seva.

"Gurudev's compassion was not limited to humans. I have witnessed his tender care for animals first-hand," Virender ji shares. "Whether milking cows on the farm, feeding them personally, or looking after many dogs, his care was evident. On a return visit to his farm, recalling the ticks on the dogs from my last trip, I arrived prepared with a remedial medicine. Gurudev approached as I was attending to the animals. With a gentle pat on my back, he declared, '*Tu mera putt hai* (You are my son)'. In those words, I felt an overwhelming deluge of love and belonging.'"

In his approach to seva, Gurudev dissolved the distinctions between humans and animals, inspiring me to regard even the smallest insects with respect instead of dismissively labelling them 'creepy crawlies'.

Pehalwanji, responsible for caring for Gurudev's Khandsa farm, was a model of devotion. His simple lifestyle belied a loyalty that never wavered. He shares a story about Bajrang, a monkey who lived on the farm. Gurudev had even found a mate for him. When their young one passed, Gurudev retreated into *paath*. Afterwards, Ram Nivas, who worked at the farm, asked if Gurudev had been praying for the monkey. Gurudev responded, "Yes. I hope to grant Bajrang's dead offspring a future life as a human to repay him for the joy he brought us."

The idea of bestowing a monkey with a human incarnation involves transcending multiple cycles of existence, known as *yonis*.[1] The concept of reincarnating animals as humans might challenge our conventional understanding of nature, but in the realm of saints, nature herself bends to their rules.

Nitin Gadekar ji reveals, "For twenty-five years, I have pursued seva with steadfast commitment. Gurudev assigned me various responsibilities at the sthan. Through the years, my seva ranged from managing visitors' footwear to washing dishes to healing seva. In my eyes, every act of seva was equally important."

His observation resonates with profundity. I, too, have observed a fascinating trend: while some at the sthan offered their healing touch seated on the *gaddi*,[2] others selflessly served in the kitchen, managed footwear, or catered to visitors with refreshments. Intriguingly, their spiritual progress moved in harmony, irrespective of the nature of their seva. Many women dedicated to kitchen seva discovered OMs and other symbols on their hands. The sthan treated everyone at par.

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1 Species or life forms; according to Hindu scriptures, a spirit has to pass through 8.4 million (84 lakh) different forms of life, or *yonis*, before achieving a human birth. These *yonis* include a vast array of biological entities, such as various species of animals, plants, humans, aquatic beings, and even microscopic organisms
2 Seat of the guru's power

Gurudev saw seva as more than a practice; it was the cornerstone of his philosophy. He infused this ethos into every aspect of his life, from his thoughts to his actions. He tirelessly championed its transformative power, urging others to prioritise giving over receiving. To disregard his teachings would be to miss a life-altering opportunity—one that could shape not only this life but future lifetimes as well.

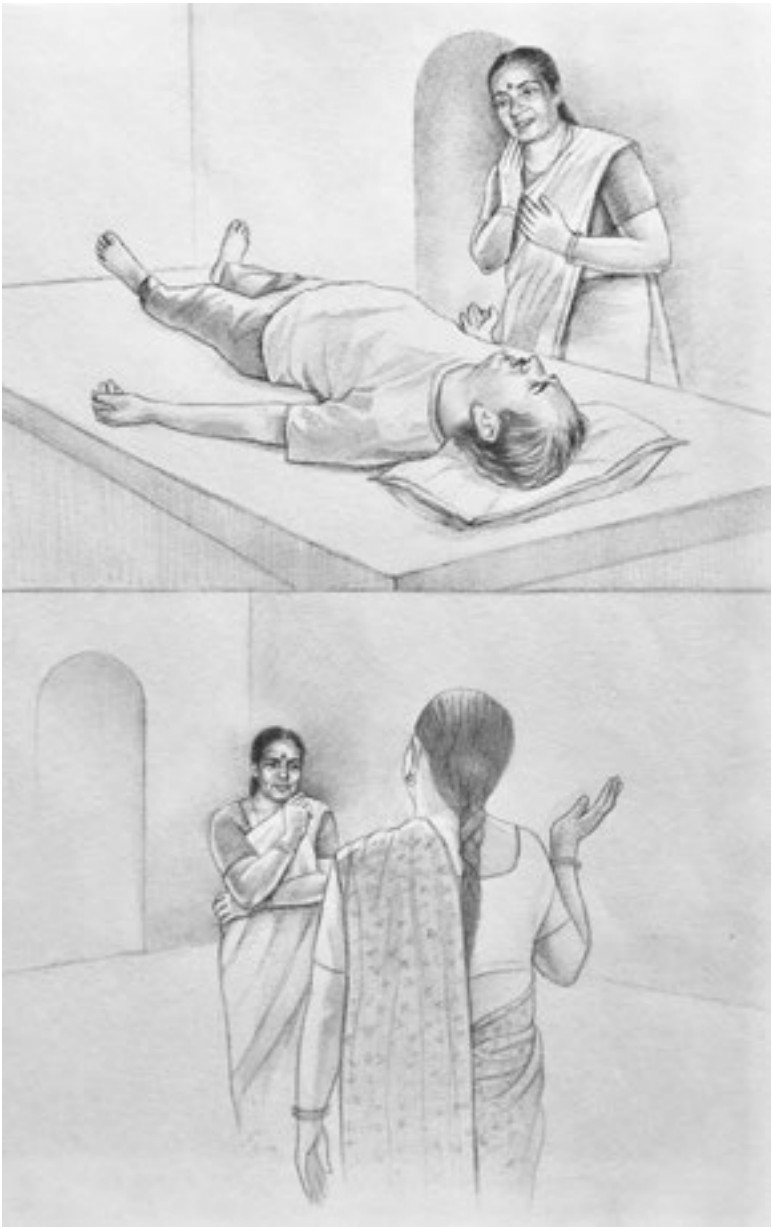
Chapter 6

Roots To Wings

Gurudev embraced the concept of the *grihasth ashram*,[1] which holds that spiritual seekers can lead a family life. One of his key sayings, or *ek vakhyas*,[2] "*Grihastha mein bhi vairagya hai* (Detachment is possible as a householder)," perfectly captured his philosophy of balancing detachment with the responsibilities of being a family man.

Shortly after his marriage, Gurudev left his wife under the care of her parents, to embark on an intense journey of meditation and spiritual practices, temporarily setting aside his worldly duties. A few years later, while meditating near the Santoksar Lake in Amritsar, he heard an *akashvani*[3] conveying that his spiritual quest could only reach completion if he returned to his wife and embraced the life of a householder. This enigmatic message, possibly orchestrated by his then future guru, Buddhe Baba, played a significant role in reshaping his spiritual path in the years that followed. Heeding this advice, the soon-to-be-mahaguru decided to reunite with his wife and fulfil his responsibilities as a family man.

1 The second stage in the four traditional stages of a Hindu's life where they focus on the duties of a householder. In this stage, individuals engage in marriage, family life, and societal responsibilities
2 Short sentences encapsulating the mahaguru's philosophy
3 Celestial voice that is heard from the heavens, often foretelling significant events or offering guidance



Newly-wed Mataji panics after finding Gurudev motionless on the bed

Gurudev's wife Mataji was born into a well-respected family in Bilga, near Ludhiana in Punjab. Being the youngest of seven siblings, she grew up in their protective care after her father, a coal trader, passed away during her childhood. Within her family, her eldest brother earned recognition as a freedom fighter actively associated with the Indian National Congress. Another brother, Rudra ji, chose the path of education, committing himself to teaching others.

It was in the year 1960 that Rudra ji had his first encounter with his future brother-in-law. Reflecting on their initial meeting, he recalls, "From the first moment, his striking appearance was undeniable. Our conversation aimed to understand his thoughts, character, and sentiments, allowing me to form impressions of his views on life. In an era when letters bridged distances instead of telephones, I wrote to my family after our discussion. In that letter, I conveyed my impression of him as a kind-hearted individual and an ideal match for my sister."

The young lady from Bilga entered into a union that led her to marry not just a man but a truly extraordinary being. Little did she realise at the time of their wedding the unexpected path that lay ahead for her.

"I had no idea about his spiritual pursuits when we married," Mataji explains. "One day, I went to talk to him and found him lying motionless on the bed. He was not breathing. I frantically tried to wake him, shaking his hands, feet, and body, but there was no reaction. In a panic, I called my sister-in-law to see what had happened to him. She calmly explained, 'There's no need to be anxious; he is in *paath*'. Back then, I did not understand what *paath* meant."

She reveals, "I discovered later that he frequently meditated near water bodies in his teens. He would spend the entire day meditating, and when he got home, he meditated all night. He embraced a lifestyle marked by austerity and a notable degree of

self-reliance. He preferred preparing his meals and would resort to a simple diet like *roti*[1] with jaggery when vegetables were unavailable. He also visited many saints and shared his thoughts and ideas. That is how he expanded his knowledge."

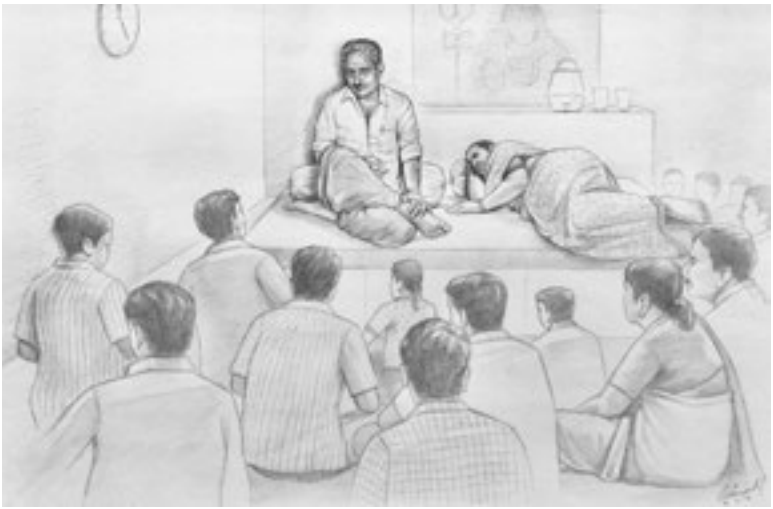
Mataji's spiritual journey, in contrast, was entirely self-directed with Gurudev never trying to steer her path. She immersed herself in various spiritual disciplines, notably mantra chanting. Reflecting on her experiences, she shares, "I felt a deep affinity for the Gayatri mantra. Upon sharing my experiences with Gurudev, he acknowledged the mantra's significance."

As Mataji's commitment to her spiritual path deepened, Gurudev shared the powerful Mahagayatri mantra with her. This gradual unveiling of knowledge indicated his thoughtful and measured approach to imparting spiritual wisdom.

"He referred to me as 'Master' because I worked as a schoolteacher," Mataji chuckles. "He once said, 'Master, wait and see what I become when I turn 35'. At the time, I assumed he was talking about a raise or promotion at his job. Little did I know that he would become a mahaguru at that age."

"He was incredibly grounded and humble," she adds. "He hardly ever shared stories of his encounters with divine beings. I never felt the urge to intervene in his prolonged sessions of *paath*; he seemed to be extending help to others through it, which I respected. But he also had a lively and playful side that balanced out his spiritual depth. He cracked a good joke, diligently met his work commitments, and enjoyed life's ordinary pleasures just like anyone else. We had our movie nights, explored new places together, and shared countless everyday joys, living a largely normal life". Mataji pauses, a ripple of laughter escaping her as

1 A traditional Indian flatbread made typically from whole wheat flour and cooked on a griddle



Mataji tries to rest while Gurudev converses with his disciples

she recalls, "He had this infectious sense of humour that never failed to light up my day."

Their middle daughter, Ila ji, shares a light-hearted anecdote highlighting her parents' playful banter. "One day, Daddy asked Mummy to cook something delicious, to which she humorously suggested that he try cooking himself as she was not sure he would find her cooking tasty enough. Surprisingly, Daddy accepted the challenge and prepared a delicious vegetable dish. He repeatedly asked each of us if we enjoyed eating it," she chuckles, "and Mummy had to remind him that it had to be tasty when he used a week's supply of tomatoes in one dish!"

Gurudev's warm and welcoming demeanour radiated comfort to those in his presence. However, this quality sometimes presented challenges for his wife. Many of us, not always considerate, would engage him in spiritual discussions that extended into the early morning hours, unintentionally subjecting Mataji to a noisy environment while she tried to rest. Occasionally, Gurudev would even wake her at odd hours to prepare tea. Despite her occasional light-hearted protests, she showed remarkable grace

and patience, ever ready to support both his endeavours and our endless quest for knowledge.

Gurudev frequently stated that his five children embodied the reincarnated spirits of his ancestors and spiritual connections. He ensured they received a proper upbringing and education, faithfully fulfilling his familial responsibilities and discharging his karmic debts.

Many are convinced that his youngest son, Nitu ji, is the reincarnation of Gurudev's father. Gurudev had confided in Mataji that his father would return as their son to participate in the wedding of Gurudev's younger brother, whom we affectionately called Chacha[1] ji. Astonishingly, Nitu ji was born just one week before the scheduled wedding festivities. Gurudev addressed Nitu ji as 'Pandit ji', the same way his father had been addressed in the past.

Renu ji, believed to have a spiritual connection from the past, reflects, "In my childhood, I hardly grasped the essence of spiritualism. Daddy was like a magnet, drawing large crowds. I knew he had this unique ability to heal and read minds. My siblings and I followed his practice of chanting mantras. I remember we used to chant the Gayatri mantra before sleep. Daddy never imposed strict rituals on us; there was no insistence on offering *prasad*[2] at the sthan or performing *aarti*.[3] Everything we embraced in our spiritual practices later in life was out of choice, not obligation."

1 A term used to refer specifically to the father's younger brother, serving both as a familial title and a sign of respect
2 A sacred offering made to a deity that is later shared among devotees. It may consist of food, flowers, or other items and is viewed as a means of receiving the deity's blessings
3 A Hindu ritual used in worship where light, typically from wicks soaked in *ghee*, is offered to one or more deities. This ritual may also include the singing of hymns in praise of the deity

"We came from a family where both parents worked," Renu ji continues. "We went to regular schools. Daddy's job as a soil surveyor required a lot of travel, and Mummy managed everything independently. Shivpuri, where we stayed, was a bleak, forested place. Daddy usually came home during winter, but only for a few weeks, so he did not have much time for us. Mummy was the parent with whom we interacted. We feared Daddy because he was strict. We were always afraid that if we bothered Mummy, she would complain to him. When we were old enough, we realised it was an act he put on because it was the need of the hour. He knew Mummy was alone most of the time, and by putting on the mask of strictness, he kept us from going astray. He was, in fact, a simple and uncomplicated man with no preconceived notions about anything."

She elaborates, "During our childhood, formal education began directly with the first grade as kindergartens were uncommon. I distinctly recall my hesitation to start school, which worried Mummy. When Daddy noticed my reluctance after returning from an official tour, he questioned Mummy's insistence on sending me to school despite my unwillingness. While she emphasised the necessity of education, Daddy advocated for my readiness and willingness to attend school."

"I began joining Mummy at her school, where she taught early grades. This informal setting allowed me to naturally absorb nursery rhymes, alphabets, and numbers. On one of Daddy's returns from a tour, I excitedly showed him what I had learnt, reciting rhymes enthusiastically. He saw my newfound interest and asked if I was ready for school. I responded with eagerness."

"Daddy's patience and adaptability were remarkable," she notes. "He believed in guiding us, not forcing us, respecting our inclinations and readiness."

It was a significant challenge for Gurudev to balance his roles as a family man, working professional and mahaguru. This multifaceted life meant that his family often received less of his time than they desired.

As the crowd seeking his help and blessings swelled outside their home, young Renu ji experienced a growing sense of distance from her father. Their moments together grew increasingly scarce due to the influx of visitors. There were stretches, sometimes 10 to 15 days or even an entire month, when they barely exchanged words or shared time. This situation weighed heavily on her, especially when she heard her classmates happily sharing stories about spending quality time with their fathers.

"I mustered the courage one day to tell him that he did not have time for us and that Mummy was everything to us," she admits. "I told him we could not survive without her. He locked his stare on me for two minutes. I expected him to be annoyed with me. Instead, he said, 'I do not know how to convey affection like your mother. One day you will realise, and then you will understand what true love is.'"

Explaining the meaning of true love to a young child can be like describing a colour they have never seen. Love is more than an emotion. It is like radiation permeating everything, unrestricted by boundaries. It should envelop everyone like a fragrance, not just a select few. Reflecting on this, Renu ji admits, "It was only in the aftermath of his passing that I began to grasp the depth of his concept of love. Perhaps, had I realised it while he was in his physical form, I would not have felt like I do now. I now understand what guru *kripa*[1] is, how the guru imparts his wisdom, and how his influence encompasses all."

1 Grace of a guru

"When Daddy was in a good mood, he would ask us, 'Where shall we travel next?'" Renu ji reveals. "His words were meant to delight us. Yet, the truth was that his time was so limited. Those trips often did not materialise."

Despite his earnest attempts to uplift the spirits of his children with talks of vacations, the reality of his limited availability was inescapable. As the eldest child, Renu ji felt a deeper sense of this absence, a sentiment perhaps not as acutely shared by her younger siblings. Being in his shoes today, I understand how they must have pinched as I continue to juggle responsibilities just as he once did.

Alka ji shares an anecdote that illustrates her father's humorous side: "Renu *didi*[1] was always our spokesperson, petitioning Daddy on our behalf. She would nudge him, saying, 'You really should take your kids on a trip'. On one occasion, she half-jokingly, half-seriously confronted him, 'You only recall our nicknames, not our given names!' Daddy assured her, 'Of course, I know your given names'. Sceptical, Renu *didi* challenged him, 'Alright then, what are they?' To our surprise, Daddy effortlessly recited our given names and classes. That managed to appease Renu *didi*, at least for a while."

Amidst sibling laughter, Ila ji adds: "Daddy never forgot the names of the farm animals, though. He would take us to Khandsa for a picnic, lead us to the shed and introduce us to the resident cows and buffaloes. He would point to each animal and call them by name, 'Kali. Ganga. Jamuna'. Renu *didi* would say, 'Daddy, you are just making up those names!' But Daddy assured her that he was not making anything up. To our amazement, he directed his attention to a jet-black buffalo standing in the corner and addressed her by name. In response, the buffalo rumbled as

1 A term of endearment to address an older sister or older woman

if acknowledging him. He continued to call out to other farm animals nearby, and each responded with distinctive sounds. Despite forgetting our given names sometimes, he knew the names of every farm animal in the shed!"

"When our parents travelled to America, communication wasn't as easy as it is now," she continues. "Without a phone at home, we would journey a fair distance at a fixed time every weekend just to talk to them. Chacha ji, our paternal uncle, always accompanied us. After Daddy had inquired about our well-being, Chacha ji would update him on the status of each farm animal, especially the cows and buffaloes. Their conversations sometimes lasted an hour, making us quite impatient. In those days, making a long-distance call was expensive, and their long discussions about animal welfare meant we had to wait even longer for our turn to speak with Mummy. It got frustrating at times. So, we told Chacha ji that he would not get the receiver until we spoke to Daddy and Mummy!" she recalls with a grin. "But on a serious note, Daddy genuinely loved animals. He cared for their well-being even when he was miles away."

During their summer holidays, the family would travel with Gurudev for a few weeks, accompanying him on his tours. To keep them entertained, Gurudev would make elaborate arrangements. One of their cherished activities was enjoying movies together on videotape during the evenings.

Nitu ji recalls, "One incident during our visit to Daddy's camp in Himachal Pradesh stands out in my memory. While playing near the road, I accidentally brushed against something with my hand as I made way for a herd of passing donkeys. Little did I know then that it was a plant called *Bichoo Booti*.[1] The brush against this shrub brought intense redness, pain, and swelling

1 Poison Ivy

to my hand. Unaware of the plant's effects, I rubbed my hand in distress, only worsening the pain. Seeking comfort, I ran to Daddy's room.

"Concerned, Daddy inquired, 'What happened to you, Pandit ji?' I explained the incident through tears, not understanding why he kept asking questions instead of offering immediate healing. But Daddy remained composed, asking for more details and investigating the incident thoroughly. Finally, he suggested, 'Let us go to where this happened.'

"I led Daddy to the spot, hoping for relief from the unbearable pain. He identified the *Bichoo Booti* as the culprit and pointed to its roots as the cure. He gently applied the plant's roots to my hand, and I felt immediate relief. 'Son, nature has a cure for everything,' he said, 'all you have to know is where to look for it.'"

"He used very few words to explain things," Alka ji notes, "but those words had a deeper meaning. I used to get sick quite often as a kid. When I went to Daddy, he would bless cardamoms and cloves and give them to me. I also took medicines prescribed by the local doctor. 'Learn to heal yourself,' he remarked one day. I had no idea what he meant. Years later, after Daddy had moved on, I was experiencing severe pain in my arm, and his words began to ring in my ears. I focused on my arm for a minute or two while chanting my mantras. Though the pain subsided, I assumed it was temporary relief and that the pain would return. However, when the pain did not return for another 15 days, I was confident that I was completely healed. I realised what Daddy meant—if we have self-belief, we can heal ourselves."

Food was the backdrop for some valuable lessons for Gurudev's children. "He liked to feed people. Whenever someone came to the sthan, he made them feel welcome and at ease," Alka ji recalls.

"I remember watching him generously add heaps of white butter to the *parathas*[1] served to visitors so they could relish their meal."

Ila ji chimes in on how her father masterfully turned every situation into an opportunity to serve: "During his travels for various tours, he usually needed a cook to accompany him. Yet, instead of opting for a professional, he selected someone who needed financial help, giving them a chance to earn some money. Sometimes, even Daddy or his disciples rolled up their sleeves to take on the kitchen duties, preparing meals for everyone at the camps. He tried to help others however he could."

Reflecting further on his values around food, Renu ji explains, "He treated food with a lot of respect. Our house had an unwritten rule that no one would leave food on our plates unfinished. Like most kids, we were fussy eaters, so Mummy had to eat our leftovers. Once, disciples from Himachal Pradesh and Kanpur and their families stayed with us. Someone left a plate with a half-eaten *paratha* in the sink. Indu *didi*, in charge of kitchen seva, failed to notice who it was. As Daddy walked into the kitchen, he saw the plate with wasted food. 'Indu, who has left the food?' he inquired. She admitted she did not know but offered to eat it anyway. Daddy picked up the plate and ate the leftovers before she could react. 'Learn to respect food,' he later told us all. 'This is *barkat*[2]—those who have it, waste it. Ask someone less fortunate what a square meal is worth. We must be grateful for what we have'. His words made me realise that I must value the *barkat* of being able to consume a full meal regularly."

The story of how Gurudev's values shaped his family's living space offers a glimpse into his practical and selfless nature.

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1 Indian flatbread made from unleavened wheat dough, typically layered with *ghee* or oil and cooked on a griddle. It can be plain or stuffed with various fillings like potatoes, cottage cheese, or vegetables
2 Abundance; the luck of making your buck last longer

"When we were growing up, Renu *didi* expressed to Daddy her desire to expand our home with a drawing and dining room, citing the need for more space," Alka ji shares. "Initially, Daddy was hesitant. 'What difference does it make? You can make do with the space you have,' he remarked. Despite his reluctance, she was resolute in her request."

In time, Gurudev agreed to the idea, allowing for the addition of one more floor to their modest house. Alka ji continues, "Once the room was completed, he looked around and commented, 'It is perfect, and about 20 to 25 people can sleep here comfortably'. This surprised Renu *didi*. She had imagined the drawing room as a private space for family and house guests, but Daddy saw it as a communal space."

"We are *fakirs*," he gently reminded Renu ji, emphasising the irrelevance of luxury in their lives. Alka ji adds, "Renu *didi* then understood that Daddy always prioritised the needs of the public over personal comforts and quietly accepted his decision."

Gurudev believed and often stated that women are manifestations of Shakti[1]—a powerful and transformative force. He held women in the highest regard, always treating them with great respect. Alka ji observes, "There was no differentiation between sons and daughters in our family. While Renu *didi*, being the eldest, had a special bond with Daddy, I never sensed any discrimination in his love."

"He always encouraged us," Ila ji adds. "If we accomplished something noteworthy, he appreciated our efforts. His affection manifested in subtle, caring actions rather than grand gestures."

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1 Represents the divine feminine energy or cosmic power that is the driving force behind creation, sustenance, and transformation. It is often personified as a goddess, such as Parvati, Durga, or Kali, and is considered the dynamic force that empowers all living beings

Families crave indulgence, and children may naturally exhibit a sense of entitlement. In this case, Gurudev's children had to accept that they would have to share their father's time and attention with countless others.

Despite his best efforts, he faced considerable time constraints that limited his ability to dedicate himself to his family. He was on a mission with a lot to do in a brief time. It was no easy task, and being a divisible dad proved challenging to pull off successfully. Fortunately, he found a dependable partner in Mataji, who was crucial in supporting and helping him navigate difficult situations. Her contribution was invaluable as they worked together to realise a shared vision of seva.

Uma Prabhu ji pays her a fitting tribute: "More than Gurudev, who was very driven, Mataji must have had a difficult life," she observes. "Her quiet simplicity and spirituality strongly anchored his spiritual drive. That is why the concept of Shiv and Shakti is appropriate in their situation. Mataji's resilience, grit, and simplicity resulted in the spirituality that oozed from her, which is why she did not need to give any blessing. Her presence and the aura she had was enough to bring comfort."

Mataji was much taller than she measured physically. She would manage the backend operations at their home-cum-sthan. Every detail mattered, and ensuring the purity of the *ghee*[1] used at the sthan temple was a task Gurudev was incredibly particular about. So, each morning, without fail, she engaged in the laborious task of separating butter from curd, using a *madhani*.[2]

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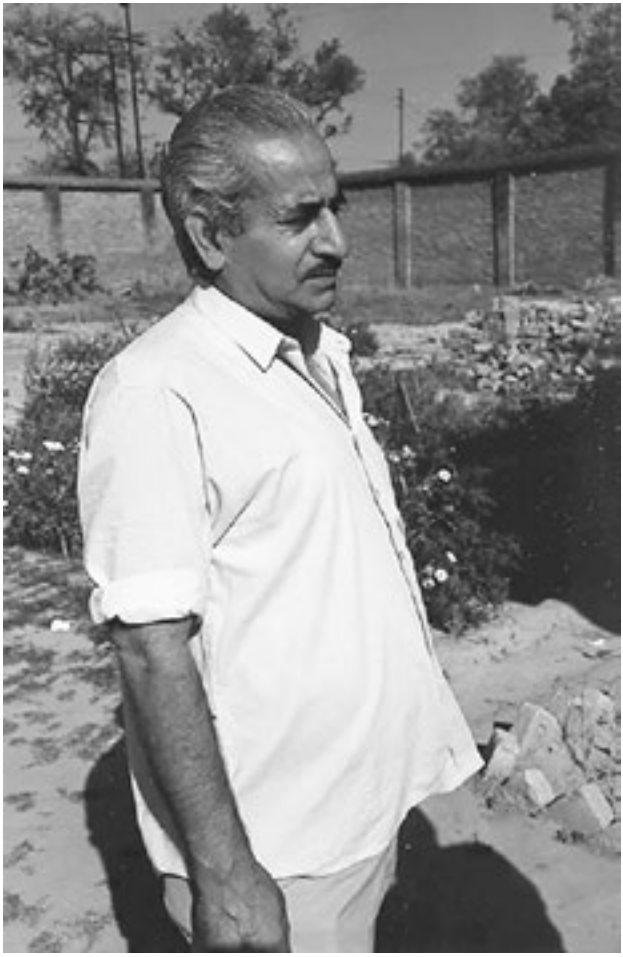
1 Clarified butter

2 A traditional Indian tool used primarily for churning milk to extract clarified butter. It consists of a long wooden handle attached to a larger, round wooden end that is submerged in milk or cream. By moving the handle back and forth, the milk is agitated, separating the butterfat from the liquid, which eventually forms butter

Mataji makes ghee using a madhani

I bravely offered to assist with the churning one day, but I nearly passed out halfway through! Mataji had to complete the task, and I was left embarrassed.

After completing the morning chores, she went to school to teach, and when she returned home many hours later, a massive pile of work awaited her. Many people work hard, no doubt, but she was the Queen of Queens!



A file photo of Gurudev at the Khandsa farm

Chapter 7

Deception Of Perception

Human sensory perception is fundamentally flawed. For example, we only detect a tiny slice—about 0.00000000000035%—of the electromagnetic spectrum, leaving us blind to infrared and ultraviolet light. Sounds at frequencies used in dog whistles are inaudible to us, and even the solid objects we touch consist primarily of empty space at an atomic level. The scent molecules that dogs can detect easily escape our notice, and our taste buds cannot discern the complexity of flavours that some animals can.

Despite these limitations, our senses form the foundation of our perceptions, which then mould our beliefs, thoughts, and actions. Consequently, our limited perceptions often make us mistake our narrow slice of experience for the entire scope of reality, a concept referred to as Maya in Eastern philosophy.

Maya spins an illusory yet convincing narrative that feels real and persuasive. We become trapped in its complex web, mistaking these illusions for the ultimate truth. These misconceptions bind us within self-imposed boundaries that curtail our true potential. However, there exists a realm of expansive possibilities beyond these sensory constraints. To access this realm, we must challenge our perceptions, question the accuracy of what our senses reveal, and strive to transcend our sensory limitations.

From childhood, when he relished Indian dishes like *chole bhature*[1] and *pinnis*,[2] Gurudev grew into a spiritualist who saw beyond the seduction of flavours. Whether the food was new or leftover, he accepted it. Bittu ji notes, "To him, the type of dish or its freshness was not a priority. He often picked food from the previous day, even with fresh options". This habit was not a demonstration of austerity but a showcase of the mahaguru's triumph over the sense of taste.

Puran ji, who spent many years in Gurudev's company, observes, "Gurudev readily accepted any vegetarian food cooked for him, no matter how simple. He never demanded particular dishes. His spiritual path had overshadowed his physical needs."

Alka ji explains the principle behind Gurudev's food choices: "For Daddy, the significance of food lay not in its taste or flavour, but in the intention and thoughtfulness behind its preparation."

Gurudev often said that one should not feel compelled to consume food financed by others to avoid incurring a karmic debt or select food solely based on its flavour. To him, food was not merely sustenance; it carried spiritual significance, reflecting our emotions and intentions.

Indian philosophy suggests that a dish prepared by two different individuals will carry distinct energies, affecting those who consume it. This belief hinges on the idea that a cook's emotions and intentions are transferred into their cooking. Given the importance of this principle, temple cooks are meticulously selected to ensure that the food they prepare is charged with positive energy.

My experiences at the sthan in Gurgaon, where I spent several years, reinforced this belief. Meals prepared by Mataji there

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1 Spicy white chickpeas served with deep-fried bread
2 A north Indian sweetmeat made from clarified butter, wheat flour, jaggery and almonds

carried a distinctive essence—a difference those attuned to sensing such energies felt.

Reflecting further on another personal observation: Sitaram, a domestic helper at my parents' house, frequently used colourful language. When I ate meals he prepared, my own manner of speaking began to reflect his distinctive style. This realisation deepened my understanding of how the energy of the person preparing food can impact those who consume it.

Food can also be affected by the subtle energies in its environment, with light-coloured foods like white dishes being particularly receptive to these energies. This characteristic of being able to absorb energies also makes food a potential medium for more nefarious practices, such as black magic.

Before my life-changing experience with Gurudev, I fell victim to such negative influences. Someone used white *pedas*[1] to channel harmful energy towards me. These innocent-looking sweetmeats were charged with negativity through specific rituals and reverse mantras, contributing to my development of severe arthritis. For this reason, it is advisable to add spices such as turmeric or black pepper to white or light-coloured foods to change their colour and pre-empt the impact of any potential negative energy that may be present in one's environment.

The mahaguru often refrained from eating as a gesture of empathy for the less fortunate. I believe he used such actions to practically teach us the value of self-control.

Interestingly, early tales from Gaggu ji paint a different picture of young Gurudev enjoying flavourful Indian meals. But between the 1970s and 1980s, there was a clear shift. He started exercising

1 A traditional Indian sweet typically made from *khoa* (thickened milk), sugar, and flavoured with cardamom, saffron, or pistachios

more self-discipline, not as a shift from pleasure to aversion, but to achieve mastery over his senses.

Raji Sharma ji shares, "Gurudev was easy-going about food. Whether it was *parathas*, a slice of bread, or even *mathi*[1] with tea, he gracefully accepted everything. While he had a soft spot for certain snacks such as *gol-gappas*,[2] he was not driven by cravings."

Gurudev would go days with just tea and no food. This self-restraint was an inherent trait for him, seamlessly integrated into his minimalistic lifestyle, yet it often left those around him puzzled. Among them was Bittu ji, who observes, "Gurudev saw food as sacred and worthy of respect. He would sometimes bring food to his mouth but then decide against eating. One day, noticing Gurudev's reluctance to eat, I could not help but question him."

Their conversation follows:

Bittu ji: "You have always emphasised the importance of respecting food. Today, you are not adhering to that principle."

Gurudev: "When I am on the verge of eating, are my eyes shut or open?"

Bittu ji: "They are shut."

Gurudev: "Before I take a bite, I shut my eyes and scan to ensure that all my spiritual children have been fed. If even one remains hungry, I find it hard to eat. Their hunger weighs on me."

For him, abstaining from food was not symbolic; it was a heartfelt act of offering his own share to those in greater need. This conviction is admirable, yet difficult to embody. Only someone

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1 A flaky Indian biscuit seasoned with carom seeds, cumin, or other spices
2 A snack consisting of a hollow, crispy-fried puffed ball that is filled with potato, chickpeas, onions, spices, and flavoured water

with immense will can resist physical temptations in pursuit of a higher purpose.

Renu ji shares a touching memory about Indu Sharma ji, a central figure in the Gurgaon kitchen who was as devoted as a daughter to Gurudev: "One day, when Indu *didi* noticed that Daddy had not had his dinner the previous night, she expressed concern and emphasised that he should have a hearty lunch. With a kind smile, Daddy responded, '*Jennu khellaan che mazaa aa gaya na, khaane da mazaa nahin rehnda*'". In English, this translates to when one experiences the joy of feeding others, the pleasure of feeding oneself pales in comparison.

This sentiment captures the essence of Gurudev's beliefs. Beyond mere thoughts on food, it unveils the heart of his philosophy. For the mahaguru, caring for others always took precedence over personal gratification.

Water, often described as the planet's lifeblood, reflects the emotions and intentions of those interacting with it. Despite retaining its chemical composition, water's molecular structure can change, manifesting its dual potential to heal and harm.

A disturbing instance is the case of a young girl named Kamlesh from Gurgaon, who unknowingly drank sherbet mixed with a harmful *taweez*.[1] The consequences could have been dire if the mahaguru had not intervened in a timely manner.

Water's transformative quality makes it a powerful tool in spiritual practices. At Gurudev's sthans, *jal* is used for healing. This water is infused with powerful mantras, making it a medium of his spiritual energy.

1 Amulet or locket worn around the neck or tied to the arm or body

Gurudev used water in unique ways. He would sometimes sip from a glass of water and then pass the rest to someone else. This act was a way of sharing his spiritual energy and qualities with the other person, sometimes to cure and sometimes to help them on their spiritual journey. For example, he often gave his disciples mantras by sharing his sipped water with them, saying, "I've transferred 10,000 recitations of this mantra to you". Such statements signified that he was imparting some of his extensive spiritual practices, such as mantra chanting, to bolster their spiritual development.

On special days such as Guru Purnima, a tradition involved disciples washing Gurudev's feet with water. The disciples would then drink this water infused with his spiritual energy. This was a way to receive the mahaguru's blessings, deepening their bond with him.

Virender ji shares insights about the mahaguru's self-discipline: "In Gurudev, I saw the finest self-control. He wasn't attracted by money or women or praise. Nothing affected him. I never saw any lust in him. That particular trait was alien to him."

The mahaguru's teachings illuminate the often-overlooked aspects of spiritual health. Gurudev emphasised that our eyes are not merely windows to our souls but can attract and emit energy. Excessive focus on the opposite gender, he cautioned, could adversely affect our spiritual well-being, draining our spiritual energy and weakening our aura. This insight encourages us to better understand how our visual focus influences the dynamics of our energy flow.

Many approached Gurudev, grappling with challenges about their perceptions of the opposite gender. In his wisdom, he

suggested perceiving a woman first as an elderly figure, or *budiya*,[1] followed by visualising her as a young child, or *gudiya*.[2] This technique aimed to transcend the immediate impulses or *vaasnas*[3] that surfaced. Inspired by his approach, I later crafted my own technique: visualising individuals as skeletons, which proved equally effective.

Gurudev viewed sensory experiences differently than most. I never saw him wear cologne. He felt that true spiritual growth meant not being swayed by life's dualities, including what we find pleasant or unpleasant. He believed one should not be overly drawn to beauty or repulsed by a lack of it. He often spoke of choices that await us in the afterlife. He talked about two paths: one that looks enticing and another that is simple and plain. Unlike what most believe, he advised us to choose the plain path. He said the simpler route led to the higher spiritual dimensions, while the attractive path could mislead us and keep us stuck in lower realms.

My journeys through three distinct realms—two higher and one lower—brought his words to life for me. The higher realms were bright yet sparsely inhabited, a stark contrast to the lower realm, which felt like a dark, seedy nightclub. Perhaps these experiences were designed to prepare me for my role as a reservation manager for the thinly populated higher realms!

When Gurudev was younger, he enjoyed music just like many of us. He would often whistle popular tunes or play them on a mouth organ. He especially loved the classic songs from the black-and-white era that were featured on the radio show *Binaca Geet Mala*. However, his relationship with auditory stimuli changed

1 An older woman
2 A girl child
3 Engrams or impressions that accumulate in the causal body over one's previous lives and current lifetime, influencing one's reactions and decisions unconsciously

as he progressed spiritually. From simply enjoying the sound, he used his sense of hearing as a spiritual tool. He would hear our thoughts and perceive spoken words from great distances. This remarkable ability revealed itself during a road trip I took with my father from Chandigarh to Gurgaon. The journey was fraught with tension, as we argued most of the way. Upon arriving in Gurgaon, Gurudev gently yet promptly admonished me for my behaviour, fully aware of the entire exchange. His vigilance was such that nothing went unnoticed.

The mahaguru exemplified remarkable control over his physical sensations. While we layered ourselves to stay warm in the cold winters of the hills, Gurudev's comfort in merely a sweater illustrated his mastery. He further demonstrated this control at his camp at Mungaoli, Madhya Pradesh. There, despite the cold, I initially wore only a T-shirt. However, upon Gurudev's return, apprehensive of his reaction, I quickly put on a sweater, only to find myself shivering uncontrollably. His simple question, "Why did you do that?" miraculously stopped my shivering, showcasing not just his control over his own physical sensations but also his influence on the physical sensations of those around him.

This experience taught me that our senses, though strong, can be influenced in ways we might not realise. My time with him also made me understand the importance of being genuine and the harsh pitfalls of pretence.

Chapter 8

Cosmic Collaborators

In comics, characters such as Superman are readily accepted for their exceptional powers because of the fictional landscape in which they exist. When rishis descend from the advanced *lokas*,[1] beyond *bhu-loka*,[2] their astounding capabilities might seem unbelievable to our logic-driven mind. Though many of us may have originated from these higher realms, the veil of forgetfulness confines our beliefs to what our senses can comprehend. The stories presented in this chapter might seem far-fetched, particularly to those who have yet to have similar experiences. However, I invite you to approach them with an open mind and consider possibilities that extend beyond the realm of the explainable.

Dhir Saheb, a longtime *sevadaar*, shares a poignant vision: "I saw myself escorting Gurudev, Jesus Christ, Sai Baba of Shirdi and Guru Nanak Dev to the sthan in Mumbai. They had arrived there to meet Guruji (Gurudev's disciple)."

Siddh gurus[3] innately understand the spirit of collaboration; it is embedded into their philosophy. Supporting and uplifting each other's spiritual families is a shared endeavour.

1 Refers to the various astral realms or planes of existence that are inhabited by different beings
2 Earthly realm
3 Spiritual masters who have attained self-realisation and possess extraordinary spiritual powers

It is essential to understand that most *devi-devtas*[1] do not originate from the most exalted *lokas*, so they respect and engage with beings higher in the cosmic order.

Giri Lalwani ji shares an insightful conversation: "Gurudev once explained the nature of his spiritual capacities. 'Imagine the prime minister coordinating various ministries—be it finance or defence—to advance the nation's prosperity,' he began. 'Similarly, when you or your sister longed for children, I contacted Brahma to give you children. I seek Vishnu or Laxmi's intervention for those facing economic hardships. When the life of someone like your mother-in-law needs an extension, I appeal to Shankar to grant additional years and, after that, ask Vishnu to ensure their well-being. For protection, I ask powers such as Chamunda or Mahakali to help. All these divine entities are in harmony with my intentions.'"

When Gurudev speaks of his spiritual connections, it may sound like boasting to the uninitiated. However, these assertions carry a different significance when expressed by someone who embodies the essence of Shiv.

"It is an honour," says Puran ji, "that Gurudev granted me visions of the Buddha, Jesus Christ, Lord Shankar, and even Sri Sharada Devi, the wife of Sri Ramakrishna Paramhansa."

His experience with Lord Shankar was particularly breathtaking. He recalls: "Shankar ji was a radiant young man in his mid-twenties with fair skin, and standing about 5 feet 10 inches tall."

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1 A term used to refer collectively to deities and divine beings, with *devi* representing a female deity and *devta* representing a male deity. These deities are revered and worshipped as manifestations of various aspects of the divine, embodying different virtues, powers, and roles

In another striking vision, Puran ji saw Jesus Christ, recognisable by his long hair and radiant complexion. In this vision, Jesus, speaking in imperfect Hindi, conveyed to Puran ji, "Your guru is truly magnificent."

Reflecting on his experiences, Puran ji observes, "Every saintly figure I have encountered has an ethereal glow. Their auras are incredibly powerful."

During one of his meditative sessions, Pradeep Sethi ji had a vision in which he saw the deity Dattatreya, enveloped in brilliant white light, standing beside a tree with his white dog and cow. He acknowledges, "Such visions are not uncommon on the spiritual journey, so I did not dwell much on it at the time."

Later, upon his return to Mumbai after a stint in Delhi, the idea of building a Shiv temple started to take root in his thoughts. In his quest for the perfect location, he chanced upon a site with an ancient Shivling atop a hill. An intuitive feeling assured him that this was the preordained spot. However, just as he agreed on a price with the land broker, the broker unexpectedly backed out, causing the deal to fall through.

A few months following the initial setbacks, Pradeep ji was pleasantly surprised by a call from Mrs Kapoor, a devotee from Delhi. He recalls, "She excitedly recounted a dream in which she saw me opening a temple on a hill and offering *jalebis*[1] to the crowd". A mere ten minutes after their conversation concluded, the broker called and agreed to proceed with the property transaction, marking an unexpected turn of events.

During a subsequent visit to the site with a contractor, Pradeep ji made a remarkable discovery. He found an Audumbar (Ficus

1 An Indian sweet made of a coil of batter fried and steeped in sugar syrup.

racemosa) tree on the premises, a tree sacred to Dattatreya and similar to the one he had seen in his vision. This reinforced his belief that a divine force was guiding his endeavour to establish the temple.

A defining moment in Gurudev's spiritual journey took place during his camp at Renuka in Himachal Pradesh, where he cultivated an enduring spiritual alliance with the legendary Parshuram ji. This momentous partnership was not just a matter of chance; it necessitated a perfect blend of tact, diplomacy, and spiritual synergy.

Ravi ji explains, "Renuka is the spiritual domain of Parshuram ji, the son of Devi Renuka. Such is the sanctity of the region that no spiritual entity can venture there without Parshuram ji's consent. On Gurudev's first visit to Renuka, he saw Parshuram ji in a colossal 27-foot form. However, Parshuram ji's height changed as he recognised Gurudev's spiritual depth. In their subsequent meetings, Parshuram ji appeared in diminishing sizes, from 18 feet to his regular stature of nine feet. While Parshuram ji granted Gurudev the opportunity to reside in Renuka, Gurudev's disciples could only visit the place after the duo achieved a spiritual working relationship."

The alliance that Gurudev and Parshuram ji formed in 1980 led to the establishment of a sthan at Bayri, close to Renuka, which has since become a source of solace for countless beings. It is widely held that Parshuram ji's guiding hand still graces the sthan, aiding their shared mission of *nisvarth* seva.

Chandramani Vashisht ji, who had the privilege of becoming Gurudev's first disciple in Renuka, was deeply devoted to

Parshuram ji. His contributions to the restoration and expansion of temples at Renuka were noteworthy. Naturally, he emerged as the unanimous choice to oversee the operations of the sthan.

Chandramani ji's disciple and the current custodian of the Bayri sthan, Dinesh ji, and his wife are convinced that the immortal Parshuram ji often visits the sthan incognito, keenly observing its proceedings. A tale that resonates with their conviction revolves around the time of the sthan's renovation. A panther mysteriously appeared and began to guard the site each night, posing no threat to anyone. It vanished once the renovations were over, never to be seen again.

Here is an anecdote from my personal experiences that is fascinating and, frankly, a bit embarrassing. Gurudev had sent Subhash Sabbharwal ji and me to Renuka. Despite my awareness of our spiritual link with Parshuram ji, I acted impulsively, which led to a spiritual reprimand from the immortal deity. Relief came after I appealed to his benevolent mother, Devi Renuka. Upon reflection, it was clear that Gurudev's connection with Parshuram ji mitigated my punishment to a spiritual rebuke rather than something more severe.

In stark contrast, Pradeep ji approached the revered deity respectfully and had an awe-inspiring vision. He recalls, "In the early morning, maybe around 4 am, I saw a clear lake where I could see every little stone and fish. From its centre, a figure emerged, standing on *khadaus*,[1] towering at around nine feet, with hands folded together in a gesture of prayer, gazing upwards. What caught my eye were his strong, bright red eyes. This was when I realised I was seeing Parshuram ji for the first time."

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1 Traditional wooden sandals used in India, often associated with spiritual practices and worn by saints, sages, and ascetics. These simple, unadorned sandals typically consist of a flat wooden sole with a knob or peg that fits between the toes

Our sensory perceptions limit our understanding of reality. However, the experiences my spiritual peers and I have had challenge these boundaries. For instance, Raji Sharma ji was blessed by Lord Shankar through Gurudev's intervention. My own spiritual encounter involved a vision of Ram, Laxman, and Sita. Similarly, Darius Moos was graced with a glimpse of Jesus. Recurring appearances of Sai Baba of Shirdi in our journeys have prompted us to reconsider and even discard traditional beliefs about what is deemed impossible or implausible.

Punchoo ji joined the mahaguru's flock as a young girl. Born to a disciple, Rajpal ji, she later married another disciple, Pradeep ji, making her part of an intricate web of relationships within Gurudev's spiritual family. Her experiences, like many within the group, often blur the lines between the tangible and the mystical.

She shares a vivid dream: "I found myself perched high above, in a place untouched by clouds. Beneath me were interlacing red pipes hovering in the air. Beside me, defying gravity, stood Gurudev, oddly casual in jeans and a T-shirt, nonchalantly twirling car keys. My gaze shifted to three radiant women approaching. The first, clad in a red *sari*,[1] had fair skin and traditional gold jewellery, accentuating her plain appearance. Trailing behind her was a striking beauty, dressed in an elegant black *sari* adorned with golden paisley motifs, her long, silky black hair flowing behind her. The third followed them in a delicate peach *sari* with a golden design. Their movement was graceful and fluid, more of a glide than a walk. As they neared, they paid their respects, hinting to Gurudev that he should have summoned them. Gurudev smiled, mentioning he had brought me along especially to introduce me to them. Deep down, I recognised them as the trinity of *devis*: Laxmi ji, Parvati ji, and Saraswati ji."

1 A garment consisting of a length of cotton or silk elaborately draped around the body, traditionally worn by women from South Asia

Gurudev introduces Punchoo ji to Laxmi ji, Parvati ji, and Saraswati ji

FC Sharma ji was a man of deep understanding, unswayed by the unexpected. He remembers, "In the early days, Gurudev would instruct Malhotra ji on the spiritual rituals to undertake at night. By dawn, Malhotra ji would relay his experiences and insights from the previous night to Gurudev. It became clear over time that Gurudev was mentoring him, imparting powerful mantras, and leading him to divine encounters with deities like Hanuman ji. Gurudev aimed to elevate Malhotra ji's spiritual stature to the level of Hanuman ji himself."

Though I have not directly experienced Lord Hanuman's bond with Gurudev, I have been positively impacted by the influence of Planet Mars, or Mangal, which is closely associated with him. I once had a unique experience where a mysterious force gave me a mantra related to Mangal in a vision and explained its application. In another memorable vision, during a visit to a mountain renowned for its connection to the energy of Mars, my gurubhai, Nitin Gadekar, and I were gifted two handkerchiefs, seemingly materialising from thin air. While some might think these are just fantasies, I believe these visions were influenced by the mahaguru's strong alliance with this powerful entity.

Pradeep ji spots a congregation of ancient sages at Gurudev's chautha ceremony

Narinder ji recounts a conversation in which the mahaguru revealed the profound connection he shares with Sai Baba of Shirdi. He remembers Gurudev saying, "When I travel astrally from Gurgaon to Mumbai, I always pause at two places—Ajmer Sharif and Shirdi. My bond with Shirdi Sai runs deep."

Pradeep ji witnessed an extraordinary sight during Gurudev's *chautha*[1] ceremony that affirms this alliance. He shares, "It was late afternoon. The place was teeming with mourners. Among them, I spotted a congregation of hundreds of ancient sages sitting before me. And there, in their centre, was Sai Baba of Shirdi. I saw this sight with my eyes wide open!"

This experience left Pradeep ji deeply reflective. "I wondered what the scene meant. Six months later, clarity came through a dream. Gurudev came to me and said, 'When a doctor dies, don't

1 Rituals observed on the fourth day after someone's death

other doctors gather to remember him? If a tradesperson passes, don't his peers show up to say goodbye? Likewise, when spiritual beings leave the earthly realm, those connected to them on the spiritual path come to pay their respects.'"

Pradeep ji continues, "Another event unfolded shortly after Gurudev's passing. Around seven to eight months into my seva at my building in Mumbai, between 15 to 20 neighbours voiced their displeasure. They found the weekly Thursday gatherings at the sthan disruptive and called for their discontinuation. In the past, I would always turn to Gurudev for guidance during challenging times. However, without him by my side, I felt adrift. After finishing my seva, I withdrew to my room. I questioned why others would be offended when all my actions stemmed from devotion to my guru. To my astonishment, as I looked up, the vision of Sai Baba of Shirdi appeared before me. Draped in a green headscarf, he asked if I was afraid. He revealed that he had been pelted with stones during his time. After a moment's pause, he comforted me, saying, 'From this day forward, no one shall bother you during seva'. Three decades have rolled by, and, staying true to his words, my seva remains undisturbed."

Ravan, the antagonist from *Ramayana*,[1] has a rich and complex legacy. While some celebrate him as a learned scholar, a mighty king, and a devoted disciple of Shiv, he is also remembered as the embodiment of arrogance and destruction. Despite these contradictions, I affectionately refer to him as *Chacha ji*, a title inspired by a story shared by Rajpal ji.

Rajpal ji recalls an incident around Dussehra[2] when Ravan's effigies are typically burned: "The night before Dussehra,

1 An ancient Indian epic written by Rishi Valmiki that narrates Lord Ram's quest to rescue his wife Sita from the Lankan king Ravan. A foundational Hindu text, it explores themes of duty, righteousness, and devotion, and is divided into seven books detailing Ram's exile, Sita's abduction, and the final battle against Ravan

2 A Hindu festival that marks the victory of Lord Ram over Ravan. It is celebrated with various rituals, performances of the *Ramleela*, and the burning of Ravan effigies across India. It also coincides with the end of the Navaratri festival

Gurudev announced his wish to sleep on the floor instead of his bed. Surprised, I asked him the reason. Gurudev explained that it was the day his brother had passed away, and he wanted to show respect by sleeping on the floor."

Digging deeper, Rajpal ji learnt from Gurudev that this 'brother' was, in fact, Ravan. Shedding light on their relationship, Gurudev stated, "Both Ravan and I are disciples of Shiv, which spiritually binds us as gurubhais."

In the context of this spiritual kinship, the mahaguru had his distinct ways of commemorating important occasions. During Kartik Purnima, which marks the birth anniversary of Guru Nanak Dev, he would engage in deep introspection and dedicate himself to his *paath*, minimising contact with the outside world. Similarly, on Janmashtami, the day honouring Krishna's birth, he would spend time with only a few chosen individuals, delegating them to distribute *prasad*. Following this, he would withdraw to his room to meditate.

To Gurudev, the various spiritual paths were like the fingers of a single hand—each unique, yet all integral to the whole. He recognised the harmony among these different traditions and shared alliances with many of the saints who established them.

In a testament of oneness, Surinder Kaushal ji, a disciple from Chicago, shares, "Our sthan in Chicago is visited by a diverse congregation—Gujaratis, Punjabis, Americans, and even Muslims of Pakistani descent. Once, a young Muslim girl plagued by troubles approached the sthan, wondering if she could perform *namaaz*[1] there. Without hesitation, I assured her she could. A remarkable experience followed some days later. On the eve of Mahashivratri, I had a vision of Gurudev doing *namaaz* in my kitchen. Startled, I asked him about this practice, to which he replied that many souls connect with him

1 Ritual prayers prescribed by Islam to be observed five times a day

Surinder Kaushal ji has a vision of Gurudev performing namaaz

in this very manner. Noticing my curiosity about him facing north during the prayer—contrary to the common practice of facing the Kaaba—he gently explained that the essence of prayer transcends the direction in which one bows."

Before meeting Gurudev, Surinder ji had a dream featuring Guru Gobind Singh. In his vision, Guru Gobind Singh was seated on a tiger skin, his long hair spread out, with a *kamandal*[1] and a *rudraksh mala*[2], facing west. Gurudev interpreted this vision: "Guru Gobind Singh embodies the essence of Shiv."

Gurudev maintained a distinctive spiritual practice of sending some disciples and devotees to temples and other sacred sites for spiritual outreach and alliance-building. Gaggu ji remembers one such occasion: "We were in Kashmir when Gurudev directed

1 An oblong water pot made of a dry gourd or coconut shell, used by Hindu ascetics and monks
2 String of beads made from the seeds of the Rudraksha tree. These *malas* or beaded necklaces are often used for chanting mantras, with each bead representing a repetition of the sacred text

us to visit the Hazratbal shrine and the Shankaracharya temple. He instructed us to go inside and pay our respects on both occasions, while he chose to remain outside. I never saw him entering these places of worship."

Once, Gurudev invited me to join him at his camp in Srinagar, Uttarakhand. From there, we embarked on a journey to the famous Badrinath temple. Upon our arrival, he gave me an unexpected instruction: "Go inside, embrace the deity, and say, 'Dear brother, I am here to hug you.'"

I was perplexed. How could I, a mere mortal, address such a revered deity as my brother? Filled with self-doubt yet trusting Gurudev's guidance, I entered the temple and softly uttered those words. It was the moment the mahaguru gently ushered me into the concept of aatmic equality. It did not lead to an immediate transformation; more than a decade passed before clarity replaced my confusion. I am now convinced that, at our very core, none of us is inherently superior or inferior to another. This insight has led me to consider myself a spiritual communist, perhaps the first of my kind!

Gurudev kept many secrets close to his chest, one of which was the being known as Augarh.

"There is a mention of Augarh in the *Shiv Puran*,"[1] FC Sharma ji explains. "Once, when Lord Shankar lost his divine energies, he transformed into Augarh and lived in graveyards to regain his powers. To my understanding, Augarh lives and performs his rituals on cremation grounds, surviving on whatever he finds there. He is a manifestation of Shiv."

1 One of the 18 *Mahapuranas*, it primarily focuses on Shiv, detailing the myths, legends, cosmology, and religious practices of his manifestations like Lord Shankar

Believed to be the leader of the Aghori[1] sect, Augarh once roamed the areas around Haridwar in human form before departing the earthly realm years ago. FC Sharma ji recalls, "We once inquired why Gurudev had not introduced us to Augarh. He replied, 'When we are in Haridwar, I will introduce you'. Gurudev would frequently vanish for hours on these trips. Upon returning, when pressed about where he had been, he would explain, 'I went to meet Augarh'. We would protest, 'But we did not see or meet him'. Gurudev would answer, 'What would you see? Augarh is six and a half feet tall, has red eyes, and mostly remains in the cremation ground.'"

The Augarh aspect of Shiv presents a fascinating and enigmatic concept. Imagery depicting this form shows him with a beard, an intense expression, clutching a trishul in his left hand, contrasting to the *Grihasth* Shiv, who holds it in his right. Devotees of Augarh, particularly advanced and enlightened Aghoris, strive to embody his attributes. However, it is crucial to note that while Augarh is a disciple of Gurudev, not all Aghoris are followers of the mahaguru.

Direct encounters with Augarh are rare, yet a few individuals—among them Gurudev's wife, daughter, sister, and some of his disciples—have had such experiences. Renu ji recounts one of these moments: "I knew Augarh protected the sthan when Daddy was away, but I had never seen him. Then, one morning, I did. He was incredibly tall—so tall that I could not see his face. His presence was overwhelming and terrifying. When Daddy returned from his trip, I told him what I had witnessed, and he confirmed that it was Augarh."

I have encountered Augarh several times, with the most recent meeting at Asthal. Responding to a mental invitation I had sent,

1 Shaiva *sadhus* known for their unconventional and often controversial spiritual practices. Rooted in the Tantric tradition, Aghoris believe in transcending the dualities of life, such as purity and impurity, by embracing the material world in all its forms, including those considered taboo by society

Geeta Nagpal ji's sketch of Augarh ji

Augarh entered the temple grounds in the garb of a villager with a noticeable swagger resembling a drunken gait. I was engaged in seva at the sthan at that moment. As he paused outside, our eyes met, rendering any formal introductions redundant.

FC Sharma ji notes, "Gurudev introduced Augarh to us as his disciple, positioning him as our gurubhai."

Gurudev also assured me that Augarh was like a brother to me, someone I could call upon whenever needed—and I have. He even guided me in brewing the perfect kettle of tea! Since then, I have encouraged many of my disciples to deepen their connection with this powerful and gracious energy. Interestingly, some have experienced remarkable encounters with this mysterious force.

Geeta Nagpal ji, a *sevadaar* at the Mumbai sthan, shares: "I once had a vision of what I believed was a thin-faced, bearded form of Lord Shankar holding a trishul in his left hand," she begins. "After I sketched it and presented it to Guruji (Gurudev's disciple), he identified the form as Augarh. He suggested I frame the drawing and hang it in my room for protection. He also advised that I could seek Augarh's assistance whenever needed."

Geeta ji started conversing daily with this framed image, referring to it affectionately as 'Augarh *Bhaiya*'.[1] "During terrible asthma attacks at night, I would look at his picture and plead, 'Augarh *Bhaiya*, please help me'. Miraculously, I would start feeling better within minutes of requesting him," she explains.

"During this time, my husband, Deepak, and I regularly visited a Hanuman temple where we would pour oil over a statue of Shani[2]

1 Term of endearment for an older brother or older male

2 Shani, associated with the planet Saturn, is a significant deity in Hindu astrology. He is typically depicted as a dark, stern figure riding a crow or buffalo, often holding a staff or sword. Though a great teacher, astrologically, Shani is considered a malefic planet, believed to bring challenges, delays, and hardships, especially during periods such as *Shani Sade Sati* and *Shani Mahadasha*. However, this negative influence is thought to be mitigated through specific rituals, such as pouring oil over a Shani statue

every Saturday. One particular Saturday morning, I awoke with intense pain in my left leg, doubtful I could even stand in the queue at the temple. Before departing, I turned to Augarh *Bhaiya* and said, 'Please handle this problem. I am leaving for the temple.'

"When we arrived at the temple, we encountered a thin man with long, unkempt hair sitting on the pavement, wildly gesturing and shouting, 'Come, come!' The only route into the temple required passing by him. As I walked past, he abruptly seized my left leg and pressed a spot on my calf muscle just below the knee. It all occurred in mere seconds; I was stunned into silence but managed to continue into the temple grounds.

"After completing the ritual at the Shani statue, Deepak and I handed out *vada pav*[1] and tea to the needy outside the temple. When Deepak offered a *vada pav* to the unkempt man, he unexpectedly threw it onto the street, startling us both."

Later, when Geeta ji arrived home, she realised the pain in her leg had vanished entirely. She adds, "I recounted the entire episode to Guruji the next morning, who revealed, 'That was Augarh'. Since that mysterious encounter, the pain has never come back."

Augarh was a guardian, always ready to protect and shield the mahaguru's spiritual family. He possessed remarkable abilities: he could change his form, read thoughts, present spiritual challenges, and relay insights back to Gurudev.

"Augarh kept an eye on us and reported our actions to Gurudev, who would often say, 'Augarh tells me everything'," FC Sharma ji recalls with a chuckle. This led to a mix of reverence and apprehension among the disciples, especially when the

1 Popular Indian street food from Mumbai, consisting of a deep-fried potato fritter (*vada*) placed inside a bread bun (*pav*)

mahaguru, acting on Augarh's reports, would confront them about their actions.

Bagga ji encountered this peculiar aspect of Augarh first-hand at his electronics store in Hamirpur, Himachal Pradesh. An elderly villager continuously interrupted him during a conversation with a female customer, straining his patience. Agitated, Bagga ji rebuked the older man, inadvertently sending Augarh away, who was in one of his many disguises. Later, during a Mahashivratri gathering in Gurgaon, Gurudev entertained the assembly by humorously narrating this incident, shedding light on Bagga ji's 'test' and subsequent 'failure'.

I am convinced Augarh was Gurudev's personal test-o-meter, and let us be honest—most of the mahaguru's disciples didn't even come close to passing! But how can one not love him? His divine naughtiness is off the charts!

Augarh continues to test the third and fourth generation of the mahaguru's disciples in his unique, shape-shifting ways.

Humsa ji shares a compelling experience: "I was at a shop outside Gurudev's *samadhi* in Najagarh, arranging for flowers and organising food distribution for visitors and passersby. While directing the shopkeeper, a beggar approached from behind. He had a wheatish complexion, curly hair, and piercing brown eyes. Despite his modest height, his presence was striking. He demanded assertively, '*Khaana de* (Give me food).' His voice resonated with authority. When I offered him a packet of wafers, he rejected it decisively, saying, '*Ye nahin chahiye* (I don't want this)'. He insisted again, '*Khaana de*.'

"My instincts signalled there was something extraordinary about him. The shopkeeper suggested fetching *chole kulche*[1] from the

1 Street food dish consisting of *chole* (spiced chickpea curry) and *kulche* (soft, leavened flatbread)

food stalls outside the nearby Shirdi Sai temple. I consented and requested him to fetch two servings of *chole kulche* for the man. The beggar seemed satisfied upon hearing this, but as I turned towards the *samadhi* with the flowers, he spoke again, '*Ab mujhe aage le chal* (Now take me ahead)'. I looked at him and replied, 'Please take the food and let me proceed to the *samadhi*'. After paying my respects and leaving the *samadhi*, I asked the shopkeeper if the beggar was a regular sight around there. He responded, 'I have never seen him before.'"

Later, Humsa ji discussed this encounter with her guru, who laughed and revealed, "That was Augarh testing you". Anxious, she asked, "Did I fail or pass?" Her guru responded reassuringly, "You passed the test."

Humsa ji recounts another encounter she believes was her second meeting with Gurudev's enigmatic disciple, Augarh. She shares, "As I stepped out of the Mumbai sthan after seva on a Saturday, accompanied by two other *sevadaars*, Roshini ji and Srimohi ji, I noticed a beggar approaching us. He was dragging a pristine white sack, and his unbuttoned shirt was remarkably clean for someone scavenging the streets. As he smiled at me, he extended his hand, offering a fresh banana. There was something electric about him. Though I cannot be entirely certain, my instinct told me that the figure standing before me was none other than Augarh ji."

The man exuded an energy that was impossible to ignore. Roshini ji recalls, "Though he appeared as a beggar, there was something about him—a peculiar energy that I felt almost immediately. It was so intense that I instinctively began chanting the Mahagayatri mantra, unable to comprehend what I was experiencing fully. Only later, when we discussed the encounter, did I realise that both Humsa ji and Srimohi ji had also felt the same palpable energy."

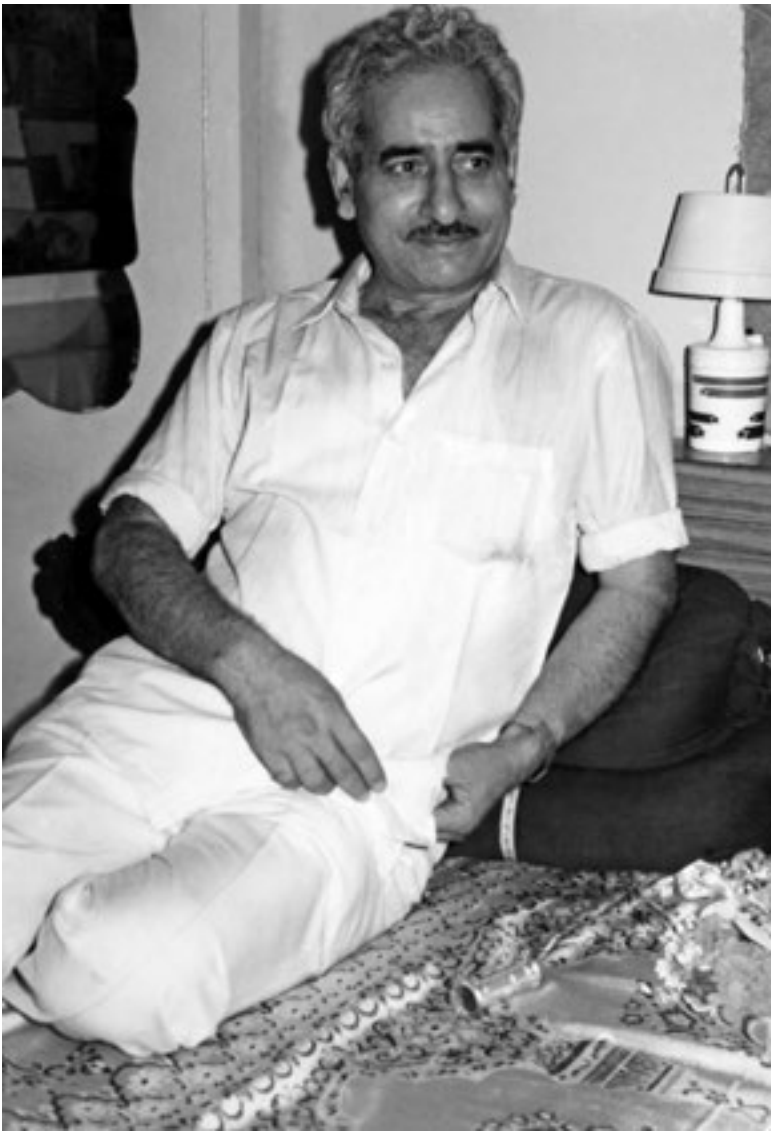
Humsa ji continues, "I felt compelled to give him something to eat, so I turned towards the sthan to fetch some biscuits. But

after a few steps, I realised that no biscuit packets were left in the kitchen. Then I remembered an unopened box of biscuits in my bag and decided to offer it to him. As he stood there, still holding the banana out to me, I held out the box of biscuits, creating a momentary stalemate between us."

Roshini ji adds, "Faced with the impasse, I took the biscuits from Humsa ji's hands and requested him to accept it and go his way. He took the box with a smirk, juggled it for a moment, and then slowly walked away."

When Humsa ji later shared the encounter with her guru, he remarked that according to the *Brighu Samhita*, bananas would be served to visitors at Gurudev's sthans. Humsa ji reflects, "Since that incident, bananas are offered as *prasad* to those who visit the Mumbai sthan."

In spirituality, ordinary bonds of family and friendship often evolve into powerful spiritual connections. Spirits, having traversed many lifetimes, return as mentors and guides to their relatives and spiritual followers. They offer guidance and support, particularly to those who seek and respect them. Gurudev's experiences, including his astral interactions with other spiritually advanced beings, shed light on the practical aspects of these spiritual partnerships. These alliances are not grounded in typical emotions or societal norms but rather focus on a shared goal: to uplift and enlighten all beings collaboratively.



A file photo of Gurudev at the sthan in Gurgaon

Chapter 9

Sage Of Solace

My first encounter with the mahaguru was fuelled by my desperate search for relief from severe arthritis. I was motivated by the remarkable healing of a fellow Mumbaikar, Yash Sethi—a recovery that utterly astonished the medical community.

Pradeep ji recounts his uncle Yash's miraculous story: "My uncle was grappling with a severe case of dermatomyositis, a muscle-weakening disease. The doctors had given up hope, telling us that his days were numbered.

"My father spent endless hours praying in our home temple, seeking divine intervention. Our home became a sanctuary, visited by numerous saints and healers, but to no avail. My uncle's health continued to deteriorate."

Hope arrived from an unexpected source. "My father received a call from his other brother who lived in Nagpur, who spoke of a man camped there, who worked with the Government of India and healed people with blessed water. Desperate for a cure, my father implored him to visit this healer."

"When my uncle visited the camp, Gurudev initially refused to meet him and made him wait. However, the next day, Gurudev revealed that he already knew my uncle's purpose: seeking help for his ailing brother in Mumbai. Despite initially hesitating, he eventually agreed to come to Mumbai."

Pradeep ji provides further insight, revealing, "I discovered later that Gurudev had already informed his colleagues a week in

advance about their trip to Mumbai. He was possibly testing my uncle's resolve.

"We welcomed Gurudev at the airport, and while I took an immediate liking to him, I remained sceptical about his healing powers," he admits. "Gurudev stayed with us for a week, during which he assured us of my uncle's recovery. He gave my uncle *jal* to drink and encouraged him to chant mantras as often as possible. Initially unable to move, my uncle began to show gradual improvement. Within six months, there was a significant improvement in his health."

I recall visiting the Sethi residence to meet a healer treating Yash for his condition. I was seeking relief from arthritis, but the healer's efforts were fruitless. I saw Yash, completely paralysed and fading rapidly, his condition seemingly terminal. However, when I returned to their home a year later, I was met by a vibrant Yash, who had remarkably recovered from his dire state, though he walked with a slight limp. Stunned, I asked, "How are you okay?" His response was matter-of-fact: "*Gurudev ne theek kiya hai* (Gurudev has healed me)."

Gurudev initiated seva in Mumbai at the Sethi residence, appointing Pradeep ji's father, Veer ji, as the sthan *sanchalak.*[1] It was there that I first met him, seeking a healing miracle for myself. The mahaguru slipped a *kada* onto my wrist, looked at me and declared, "Give him 75% relief". Unwilling to settle, I requested, "Why not 100%?" Amused by my negotiation, he responded, "Fine, we will give you 95% relief from your problem."

Leaving the sthan, I felt significantly better. Previously, I had been undergoing homoeopathic therapy with Mr Marshal, a spiritualist who used a planchette and pendulum in choosing treatments, claiming guidance from his late guru. After my encounter with Gurudev, during a follow-up visit, Mr Marshal's pendulum

1 Individual responsible for managing and overseeing the activities at a sthan

swung erratically. Bewildered, he exclaimed, "I don't believe this! How can this be? You are already 95% healed!" The figure was precisely what Gurudev had promised, yet my scepticism held firm. Ignoring the mahaguru's recommendations, I skipped visits to the sthan and indulged in alcohol on Thursdays, something he had advised me against. Consequently, a year later, my arthritis returned more fiercely than before.

Four years later, after experiencing a series of transformative events that deepened my faith, I returned to Gurudev, seeking not healing but his grace. His simple advice to me was, "Son, start doing seva". Despite enduring severe pain, I followed his counsel. While serving food to visitors at the Gurgaon sthan one day, I noticed him watching me intently from a distance for a few seconds before he turned and walked away. Incredibly, in that brief exchange, he completely healed my arthritis!

My swift recovery was not an isolated incident; numerous others have reported equally rapid healings through his intervention.

"I had kidney stones and was in a miserable situation," Nitin Gadekar ji admits. "My aunt called a doctor, who injected me with a pain reliever. But the thought of the pain recurring was like the fear of death. That fear drove me to pick up the phone and call Gurudev. I explained that I was not feeling well, and the X-ray had revealed three kidney stones. He assured me that everything would be fine and hung up. Shortly after our conversation, the pain vanished, never to return!"

Healing goes beyond the mere desire to help—it demands immense usage of energy. Gurudev channelled a significant portion of his spiritual powers towards healing man, beast, and spirit. To maintain his level of seva, he consistently replenished his spiritual reserves through seva and mantra chanting, ensuring a continuous stream of grace. This process was further enhanced

by the cooperation of his spiritual allies, allowing him to extend his spiritual influence far and wide.

Pappu ji was part of a group I fondly call the 'Four Musketeers', which included Nikku ji, Gaggu ji, and Bittu ji. Together, they were indispensable to the mahaguru, attending to his daily needs and handling the administrative duties at the sthan. Pappu ji shares a personal story of healing: "I was operating a power press machine when, suddenly, part of my finger was severed. At that moment, I felt nothing; I wasn't even aware my finger had been cut. It was only when I looked down and saw the severed part on the floor that I realised my hand was bleeding profusely. Since I was near Gurudev's sthan in Gurgaon, I went straight to him."

Upon reaching the sthan, Pappu ji describes how the mahaguru tended to him: "Gurudev quietly examined my injured finger, held it in his hands for about half a minute, and simply told me to go home". Astonishingly, this brief encounter led to the complete regeneration of his finger. "Not only did my finger regenerate in some time, but its functioning and mobility are entirely normal."

He reflects on the mahaguru's humble approach: "Gurudev was always understated about his abilities. Often, those he helped didn't realise the extent of his intervention until much later, only connecting the dots after they had healed."

Given the large number of individuals Gurudev helped, it is astounding how he managed his time and remembered each case. With brief moments devoted to each person's story, how did he bring about their healing?

When Das Saheb, a follower from Chandigarh, questioned how the mahaguru managed to remember the intricate details of the

Gurudev accesses an ethereal screen while meeting visitors, which is visible to him alone

tens of thousands of people he met daily, Gurudev revealed, "There is an ethereal screen before me, visible only to my eyes. Every detail about everyone in the queue—their past, present and future, problems, faith, devotion, and even their casual curiosity—all manifest on that screen. I know the help they seek within moments and can determine the appropriate guidance."

This revelation was not exclusive to Das Saheb. Gurudev once told me, "After seva, simply remember the first and last person you met, and all those in between will naturally settle in your thoughts". He explained that the entire spectrum comes alive by focusing on the two ends, guiding the healer to reflect on each person during meditation.

Giri ji's journey from scepticism to deep faith is a compelling story of healing and grace.

He recounts his initial encounter with Gurudev alongside fellow Mumbaikars Shyam Dhumutkar ji and Shrikrishna Deolekar

ji: "Upon meeting Gurudev for the first time, I refrained from the traditional gestures of respect, such as touching his feet. Nevertheless, he greeted me with warmth. He extended his hand to show me the natural markings on his palm. Symbols such as OM, the trishul, Ganpati, and Shivling adorned it". While this sight visibly moved Shyam ji and Shrikrishna ji, Giri ji remained unimpressed, brushing it off as mere "*haath ki safaai*."[1]

His scepticism, however, was set to undergo a dramatic change during a visit to Gurgaon for Mahashivratri in March 1983. He details that moment vividly: "Our group arrived at the sthan at 9.30 pm, but it was at 3 am that we had our turn to meet Gurudev. To my disbelief, he immediately brought up my comment about his '*haath ki safaai*' from our first meeting. Initially, I suspected that my friends had tipped him off. But the following day, Gurudev clarified my unspoken thought by mentioning that he had received no information from anyone."

During this visit, Gurudev showcased his extraordinary insight by mentioning Giri ji's health problems and advising against his current treatment regimen. "Instead, he handed me a few blessed cloves and cardamoms, assuring me of recovery within six months. This time, I decided to trust him and started feeling better once I returned home to Mumbai."

The shift from scepticism to belief had a tangible impact on Giri ji's life. Heeding Gurudev's guidance, he sought a medical evaluation six months later. The X-ray reflected his flawless health. When he showed his previous medical records for comparison, the doctor exclaimed, "These records cannot possibly be yours!"

Gurudev consistently highlighted that the essence of healing lay not in his interventions but in the deep faith of the individuals

1 Sleight of hand

seeking his aid. This principle was illustrated through various examples of steadfast belief, notably in the extraordinary recovery of Guddan ji.

Her brother, Surender ji, reflects sombrely on her extended ordeal: "Guddan endured 14 excruciating years of severe, deformative arthritis. Her hands, feet, and joints were severely swollen, and her right foot visibly contorted. The pain was so acute that even the lightest touch of a soft cloth caused her to scream in agony. Despite countless medical treatments, there was no relief in sight."

The turning point came with their encounter with Gurudev: "We had heard of Gurudev's miraculous healing abilities and decided to meet him. Guddan even discontinued her medications, confident that the guru she was about to meet would heal her.

"Our initial interaction with him at the sthan in his home in Shivpuri was brief. Guddan lay on the floor while he sat on a divan. Without uttering a word, he gazed deeply into her eyes. He then instructed her to stand, gently touching her misaligned joint and realigning her leg. 'How do you feel? Do you still feel pain?' he inquired gently. Her response was brief but miraculous, 'No'. And just like that, she began to walk on her own. We knew we had witnessed a miracle," he reflects, with gratitude.

Eventually, Gurudev established his first sthan outside Gurgaon at the home of Guddan ji and Surender ji in Kanpur, Uttar Pradesh. For many like them, the quest for healing—whether for themselves or their loved ones—became the catalyst that awakened their latent healing powers.

Gurudev's office was not just a professional space but a crucial setting where his spiritual practices blossomed. It became a sanctuary where many like Dr Shankarnarayan ji, initially drawn

in search of healing, found themselves embarking on a spiritual journey, eventually becoming his disciples.

Shankarnarayan ji was Gurudev's senior who embraced the paradox of leading professionally while following spiritually. He shares, "I was unaware of Gurudev's spiritual powers until the miraculous healing of my colleague Mr Datta's father was brought to my attention."

Amidst a tumultuous period marked by various familial challenges, the health of Shankarnarayan ji's daughter, Vaishali, emerged as a focal point of concern. She suffered from persistent fits and fever, conditions that defied conventional medical solutions. He recalls a heartfelt discussion about her condition with the mahaguru: "Gurudev offered nothing but a smile, a silent gesture that, paradoxically, conveyed volumes". Though devoid of words, that moment instilled unwavering faith within Shankarnarayan ji. He reflects, "My unshakeable faith in Gurudev was the catalyst for Vaishali's miraculous recovery."

Gurudev once explained the intrinsic link between faith and healing, emphasising, "Though a doctor can prescribe a course of treatment, it is ultimately the patient's belief in the doctor's proficiency that significantly enhances the treatment's efficacy."

In 1991, amidst the setting of the sthan in Punjabi Bagh, a notable event unfolded that would leave an indelible mark on the lives of Giri ji and his mother. It was here, in Gurudev's company, that Giri ji received distressing news through an unexpected phone call. His mother, back in Mumbai, had been diagnosed with uterine cancer, and her doctors recommended the surgical removal of her uterus.

The news cast a shadow of grave concern over Giri ji, but Gurudev's response was both immediate and reassuring.

"Do not be troubled, my son," the mahaguru said calmly and compassionately, "Your mother has borne my disciple and I am indebted to her. I assure you that her uterus will not be removed."

Following the mahaguru's guidance, Giri ji left for Mumbai to care for his ailing mother. Gurudev's instructions were precise: a jar of tea was to be placed in their home temple every morning at 5.30, and after making the *bhog*,[1] Giri ji would give his mother a cup of this blessed tea to drink.

"A few days later, my mother expressed a desire to speak to Gurudev," he continues. "She greeted him over the phone and, following a brief conversation, engaged in a ritual where she took nine sips of water while Gurudev was on the line. This process was repeated for three days."

On the fourth day, following Gurudev's guidance, Giri ji and his mother went to the doctor for pre-surgery tests. The results were astonishing. The doctor announced, "It appears there was a mistake on our end. The current tests show no signs of cancer in your mother's uterus. It's likely there was an error in the initial test results, resulting in a misdiagnosis. We deeply apologise for the unnecessary stress this has caused."

Giri ji's mother, who was once on the brink of undergoing major surgery, lived an additional 30 years completely free of cancer.

Gurudev had the unique ability to heal not only physical and mental ailments but also address disturbances from the spirit world. His expertise extended to freeing individuals from the grip of spirit possession and attacks while also guiding these spirits towards their salvation.

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1 Food offering made to a deity or spiritual power as part of a ritual or prayer. After the food is offered and the deity or power is believed to have partaken in it, the remaining food is consumed and/or distributed as *prasad*

Virender ji recounts an episode involving his wife, who suffered from a severe gynaecological problem. Her condition had deteriorated significantly, rendering her unable to stand, leading doctors to recommend urgent surgery. It was at this juncture that a neighbour advised seeking Gurudev's help.

Reflecting on their first attempt to meet Gurudev in Gurgaon during the Mahashivratri celebrations of 1984, he shares, "The throngs of devotees were daunting, and I hesitated to approach him. Thankfully, with the assistance of Inspector Bhajanlal Bishnoi, we managed a private audience with him a few weeks later. Upon meeting him, I felt an immediate sense of recognition. He welcomed me warmly, saying '*Aa gaya putt'* as if he had been anticipating my visit. I poured out the saga of my wife's ailment, seeking his help."

Despite their repeated visits to Gurudev, Virender ji's wife's suffering continued unabated. He remembers, "Once, frustrated on seeing her endure endless pain, I found myself pleading with Gurudev for a resolution—to either heal her completely or let her die. Upon hearing this, Gurudev called upon his disciple RP Sharma ji to 'remove her pain'. He disclosed that her torment was the work of a malevolent spirit but assured us, 'She will suffer no more'. Gurudev then encouraged her to stand, and as I watched, she not only stood up but also began to run. The once debilitating pain vanished, leading to her full recovery!"

Throughout human history, how rare is it to encounter beings to whom spirits themselves come, pleading for help?

Nikku ji, Mataji's nephew, shares a remarkable encounter: "One day, after Gurudev had returned early from work and completed his *paath*, we were sitting, awaiting tea. Mid-conversation, his attention was caught by a man walking past the window. He turned to me with purpose and said, 'Call that man inside. I have

something to show you'. My curiosity was instantly piqued.

"The man entered the sthan and bowed before Gurudev. Gurudev then gave a simple and enigmatic command, 'Okay, call him!' Following Gurudev's directions, the man carefully removed his jewellery and laid it next to Gurudev's bed. With a subtle flick of his fingers and a gentle turn of his head, a spirit within the man emerged. 'What is your name?' Gurudev inquired. The response, 'Hari Ram', left me in awe, for I realised this was not the man's name but that of the spirit."

Nikku ji recounts the intense dialogue between Gurudev and Hari Ram, "Gurudev asked, 'Where did you take hold of him?' The spirit admitted, 'One evening at Nigambhod Ghat when he was urinating under a tree'. Gurudev often advised against urinating under the trees or when facing the sun, warning of the spiritual risks involved. When Gurudev commanded the spirit to leave, it hesitated, seeking Gurudev's gaze before making a request, 'I will depart from this man, but only if you promise me rebirth'. With a knowing smile, Gurudev responded, 'We will see'. At those words, the spirit relinquished its hold, leaving the man to collect his belongings, receive Gurudev's blessings, and take his leave."

Healing is a deep science involving multiple levels of a healer's consciousness. This intricate interplay is evident in a story shared by a devotee, Sahani ji, about a young man from London who needed frequent bone marrow transplants.

"The young man's mother and uncle came to me, hoping I could seek Gurudev's intervention on their behalf," he recalls. "I showed Gurudev the young man's photo and explained his situation, highlighting his responsibilities as a father to two young children. Gurudev gave a hopeful assurance."

When Gurudev met the young man's uncle, he inquired whether the young man would be open to taking blessed cloves, cardamoms, and *jal*. The uncle responded that he would consult with his nephew on this matter. Meanwhile, Gurudev placed the young man's photograph under his bed mattress, a gesture intended to alleviate the difficulties faced by the person in the image. Sahani ji elaborates, "Photos placed under Gurudev's mattress were said to grant individuals either healing or an extension of life. Remarkably, the photographs of approximately 8,000 to 10,000 individuals lay beneath that mattress, all seeking Gurudev's intervention for their unique challenges."

"However, a week later, upon discovering that the young man was hesitant to take *jal*, Gurudev expressed his disappointment. He then instructed Puran ji and me to remove the young man's photo from under the mattress. But despite our best efforts, we could not find it. And surprisingly, the young man's health improved significantly."

This story reveals a complex insight: on the one hand, Gurudev's guru form offered hope and promised healing. On the other hand, his physical form displayed irritability when the young man did not follow his instructions. While Gurudev's physical form reacted to the young man's non-compliance, his guru form, operating on a higher plane, offered unconditional healing regardless of whether his advice was heeded.

Gurudev's teachings went beyond the mundane, emphasising empowerment and the importance of paying it forward. Punchoo ji and Giri ji's sister's experiences serve as prime examples, showcasing his holistic approach.

"I was no stranger to the throbbing pain of migraines," Punchoo ji explains. "One day, my maternal uncle approached Gurudev on my behalf. Rather than directly curing me, Gurudev suggested,

'Help a hundred people find relief from their headache, and your migraines will go away'. Taking his advice to heart, I began practising the technique he had taught me.

"During a school trip to Jaipur, a classmate struggled with a headache. I gently pressed her forehead with my thumb and forefinger like Gurudev had shown me. To her and my amazement, her pain vanished instantly! Word spread, and soon, others lined up for their turn. It became a light-hearted joke—any headache sufferer knew where to get relief. It felt as though there was magic in my fingers!"

The magic in Punchoo ji's fingers was more than just a remedy; it symbolised the mahaguru's ability to transform individuals into channels of his healing grace.

Giri ji shares, "Fate dealt my sister a cruel hand. A severe skin condition caused her hands and feet to swell with pus and shed skin. The stench became so unbearable that no one could enter her room. Simple tasks like eating, walking, and bathing became impossible for her."

He contacted Gurudev to detail his sister's plight. "Bring her to Gurgaon," the mahaguru instructed. "At Gurgaon, Gurudev's remedy was simple," Giri ji explains. "He asked her to do the *langar*[1] seva for 11 days, advising her to apply *ghee* on the *rotis* she helped prepare. Remarkably, by the end of the 11-day seva, the debilitating disease vanished as mysteriously as it had appeared!"

Gurudev's healing powers transcend his physical form. From Nadaun, Randhir ji, whose father Santosh ji is a disciple of Gurudev, shares an incident about his sister: "Ruchi was

1 A communal meal that is open to all visitors, regardless of religion, caste, gender, economic status, or ethnicity. The practice embodies the principle of seva. Meals are typically vegetarian to accommodate the dietary restrictions of all participants

grappling with an unusual dental issue where a tooth remained embedded within her gums, a situation doctors deemed only resolvable through surgery. This was not just any procedure but one requiring a complex lateral incision that many surgeons were reluctant to undertake. Amid this uncertainty, my elder sister turned to Gurudev's photo at our sthan seeking help. After praying earnestly, she applied ash from the *dhoop* to the troubled area on Ruchi's gum. And in mere moments, the troublesome tooth vanished without a trace!"

Remanika Tandon, a young devotee from the sthan in Baroda, Gujarat, recounts an episode of spiritual healing through a dream. "After spending four days in Haridwar with my mother's best friend's family, I returned home only to fall ill," she explains. "I was suffering from high-grade fever, body aches, cold, throat pain—symptoms that suggested a viral infection. Medication had no effect, which led me to seek help at the sthan. To my amazement, the fever and body ache vanished almost immediately, though the headache, cold, and cough lingered."

Her mother, Bhavna ji, a *sevadaar* at the Baroda sthan, noted additional concerns about her daughter's condition. "The most troubling aspect was Remanika's behaviour; it was not normal," she shares. "She felt something crawling up her legs, harboured aggressive thoughts, and withdrew from communication entirely; she even stopped responding to her close friends. Devraj Khare ji, a *sevadaar* who does healing seva, advised that she spend a night at the sthan. She was surprisingly hesitant to stay overnight, a stark contrast to her usual comfort with the place," she adds.

After some initial resistance, Remanika was persuaded to enter the sthan. "It took some effort to get her through the gate. Once inside, she slowly began to find her peace, though she was not entirely herself," Bhavna ji recounts. "About an hour later, she fell into a deep sleep despite heavy breathing and a lingering headache."

That night, a significant dream offered Remanika relief. "At around 3 am, I dreamt of Gurudev entering the room and walking

twice around my bed, visible only by his feet," she shares. "He then seated himself on the *gaddi* at the sthan. Moments later, my mother entered the room, and Gurudev disappeared, leaving behind a gift on the *gaddi*. My mother picked up a copper *kada* with a golden sheen, decorated with a peacock feather and a black pearl, and presented it to me, telling me it was from Gurudev. The moment I wore the *kada*, I awoke, realising it was all a dream."

Bhavna ji continues, her voice filled with gratitude, "All her troubling physical symptoms had disappeared—her aches and pains were gone, her breathing stabilised, and her mind became clear. Completely healed, she returned to sleep, feeling well."

Pooja Seth ji has dedicated years to seva, accruing significant spiritual depth. She shares a touching experience, illustrating the mahaguru's enduring impact on both his disciples and those they serve.

She begins, "A few days before Guru Purnima, I had a dream of Gurudev in which he gave me a coconut that had a flower inside. He imparted a clear instruction: the flower would be given to a woman who could not conceive a child.

"On Guru Purnima, it is a practice for disciples to get coconuts blessed by their guru—a ritual that symbolises the surrender of one's ego. When I shared my dream with Guruji (Gurudev's disciple), he advised me to reserve the blessed coconut for someone in need. I placed it in my home temple, and to my amazement, a flower miraculously bloomed under the cloth covering the coconut. After discussing this development with Guruji, he pointed me towards a woman who had been visiting the sthan, struggling for years to conceive. I gifted her the flower. It was not long before joyful news reached me—she was pregnant. Her journey of motherhood began with this child, and she had three or four more children in the years that followed."

Pooja ji reveals the lasting impact of this experience, "For several years following this event, I discovered fresh flowers sprouting from the coconuts that Guruji had blessed for me each Guru Purnima. Since then, we have made it a practice to offer these white coconut flowers to women who visit the sthan with infertility issues."

In spiritual traditions, imparting spiritual power to disciples is extraordinary and infrequent. Gurudev, however, stands out not just for achieving this feat but for doing so on an unprecedented scale. The number of individuals he empowered is unparalleled, distinguishing him as a unique figure in spiritual mentorship. Those disciples, now imbued with his spiritual energy, have become capable vessels, continuing the legacy of the healing power he epitomises.

"An elderly couple from the United States of America once came to me," Ravi ji recalls. "The wife, in her mid-sixties, had been battling an aggressive brain tumour. Despite two gruelling years of treatment, her condition had not improved. Doctors gave her a mere three to four months to live. Wanting to spend her final moments in her homeland, she returned to India and found her way to my doorstep."

Ravi ji gave her blessed areca nuts, cloves, cardamoms, and *jal*, and requested that she return in 40 days. She was initially sceptical, questioning her likelihood of surviving the next few weeks. Yet, as Ravi ji had anticipated, she returned, detailing a significant decline in her chronic headaches. With each following visit, her health improved.

"Gurudev's grace guided her recovery," Ravi ji emphasises. "Seven months after arriving in India, she returned to the United States. In a turn of events that left many stunned, her medical reports soon declared her entirely cancer-free!"

The remarkable healing stories that Ravi ji and countless others have shared are not isolated incidents. They are frequently echoed by many of Gurudev's disciples. Nonetheless, it is essential to acknowledge that only some who seek the sthan's help experience such miracles. Roughly 70 to 80% of visitors find either complete or partial relief. The healing is immediate for some, while it unfolds over time for others. The power decides the pace of healing. Our intention to heal is usually acknowledged and respected by the power. That is the grace bestowed upon us.

Rishabh Manaktala ji, a dedicated *sevadaar* from Mumbai, recounts a transformative experience from the early days of seva at the sthan in Gopiganj, a village near Benaras.

"A young man came to Guruji (Gurudev's disciple) with a concerning loss of vision," Rishabh ji begins. "Guruji said, 'Let's see what we can do for you today'. After the initial healing session, the young man noted some improvement, but his vision was still blurred. Guruji's response was gentle yet realistic, 'This is the best we can do for you today.'"

Rishabh ji then captures a moment of pure acceptance: "With a heartfelt smile, the man said, 'That is okay. At least I will have another chance to see you'. His contentment and positive outlook inspired Guruji to extend the healing process."

The story culminates in a remarkable turnaround: "By the end of the day, the man had regained most of his vision. This outcome resulted from the sthan's energy, the guru's grace, and the young man's genuine gratitude and acceptance. His willingness to embrace whatever grace was bestowed, without demanding a complete cure, was pivotal."

Rishabh ji watches as Gurudev's disciple heals a young man of vision loss

Gajendra Kadam ji, a *sevadaar* deeply committed to the seva of healing, has been a familiar presence at the Lonavala sthan since his youth. He cherishes a remarkable incident from 1997: "When Guruji (Gurudev's disciple) established the Lonavala sthan, he declared that the first 108 patients who sought treatment would receive complete healing. I can still vividly remember an incident from the early days when a tribal woman from Neral, completely paralysed, was brought in on a stretcher, carried by four men. Guruji blessed her, and to our astonishment, she not only raised herself from the stretcher but also walked back to the van in which she had arrived. The healing was instantaneous."

Nevertheless, a week later, during seva, Gajendra ji found himself shocked as he witnessed the same woman, once again on a stretcher, being transported to the sthan. He disclosed, "Upon inquiry, we uncovered that she was the twin of the woman who had undergone the miraculous healing just a week earlier. Both sisters suffered from the same affliction. Just like her sister, she, too, experienced a remarkable recovery. These occurrences are

indelibly etched in my memory, serving as irrefutable evidence of Gurudev's enduring healing powers."

Kanika Bhalla ji's connection to the sthan emerged from a personal ordeal that became a testimony of spiritual grace.

"Just days after the birth of my first child, I was struck with an intense headache," she recalls. "Confused and in pain, I asked my husband, Dhruv, for a cold bottle of water, which I quickly drank. Moments later, everything went dark. I woke up to find myself in the ICU. I later learnt that I had suffered an epileptic seizure the previous night. Numerous tests revealed that a clot, likely from my caesarean section, had travelled to my occipital lobe, affecting my vision. The doctors warned that even with medication, I could face paralysis or lasting vision issues, with the worst-case scenario being blindness in one eye". The situation was dire, and everyone was deeply concerned.

"Dhruv consulted Guruji (Gurudev's disciple). After looking at my photo, Guruji asked him to go home to rest and return the next morning. Despite his reservations about leaving me, Dhruv followed Guruji's advice. By the time he returned the next morning, the unimaginable had occurred. The medical team was astonished—I had awakened without complications, and the clot had completely vanished!"

The experience bolstered Kanika ji's faith and reshaped her spiritual journey: "Over a decade has passed since that life-changing event. About ten days after I found out what had happened, I called Guruji to tell him that I wanted to wear a *kada* as I sought refuge under the umbrella of his grace."

Devraj Khare ji's deep-rooted belief in the sthan can be traced back to his childhood. By the age of six, he was struggling with

Gurudev's disciple presents Devraj ji's mother with a gut-wrenching choice

severe asthma. Around the same time, his mother was diagnosed with leukaemia. In search of healing, both were drawn to the sthan in Mumbai, where they met a disciple of Gurudev.

"Many years later, my mother revealed something to me that I will never forget", Devraj ji shares. "During her first meeting with Guruji, she was presented with a heart-wrenching choice: Guruji could heal only one of us. Without hesitation, she chose me."

"After we had visited the sthan, my health started improving. Yet the true miracle was in my mother's sacrifice," he continues. "Her selfless choice unleashed a flow of blessings. She had leukaemia but lived for almost 18 more years without needing specific treatment for the disease. She had always warned me that her health might worsen, but that day never came. Her haematologist assured her she would not die from cancer. I firmly believe this was due to her selflessness and Guruji's grace."

Gurudev initiated the practice of remote healing to assist those unable to visit sthans due to distance or severe illness. This innovative approach, replicated by his disciples and their downlines, has yielded positive results. Today, numerous *sevadaars* conduct these remote healing sessions under the guidance of a lead coordinator, extending the reach of healing to people in far-flung areas and engaging more *sevadaars* in the seva of healing.

Deepak Nagpal ji, one of the coordinators, sheds light on the methodology: "Our remote healing techniques are diverse. They range from video conferencing or telephonic conversations to focusing on a patient's photograph. Visualising patients we have previously met while chanting mantras during the healing process proves beneficial. We regularly check on the patient's condition. Noticing a 30 to 40% improvement is a sign that our efforts are working, and it encourages us to continue the healing process until we observe further progress."

Aditya Manaktala ji, a *sevadaar*, shares some insights into the spiritual dynamics at work during remote healing sessions. He notes that many *sevadaars* receive direct guidance from the sthan through vivid visions or dreams or intuitive thoughts during these sessions. Illustrating this, he shares, "In one instance, while on a Zoom call with a wheelchair-bound woman suffering from muscular weakness, a *sevadaar* experienced a vision where a distinct command was given: 'Rectify the anomalies in her aura.'"

He also recalls another striking experience: "Another *sevadaar* received a detailed illustration of a brain—its folds and grooves—during a dream. The instruction was clear: visualise these exact folds and grooves in the brain of a young child we were treating."

He reflects on these experiences with humility: "We are merely vessels. It is the sthan that is guiding all our healing endeavours."

Vipan Seth ji from Mumbai narrates an instance of healing someone in mere minutes over a phone call: "On Bada Guruvar, a couple sought my help. Their daughter had sustained a severe spinal injury and was in the hospital. The medical team had warned them to expect a long recovery period. Relying on Guruji's guidance and invoking blessings from the sthan, I spoke with the young woman and conducted a healing session over the phone. Within a few minutes, she reported a 90% reduction in pain. She recovered so quickly that she was well enough to leave the hospital in just a few days."

Dr Mahesh Vacchani, a *sevadaar* at the Mumbai sthan, opines that sometimes illnesses are hard to understand or treat with conventional medicine because they may be caused by what we cannot see, like spirits or negative energy. Though a firm believer in modern medicine, Dr Vacchani remarks, "A significant proportion of problems are psychosomatic. I once believed spirits were folklore, but the sthan has clarified my understanding."

He has integrated conventional treatments with spiritual healing in his practice, demonstrating openness to concepts beyond traditional medical approaches.

He adds, "One day, I got a call from a boy I had treated. He complained about his mother's erratic behaviour and unusual demands for alcohol. Assuming it was a psychological issue, I did everything medically possible, but to no avail. That is when I recommended a visit to the sthan. When I spoke to Guruji about her, he revealed multiple spirits haunted her. In due course, she recovered with the sthan's grace."

He also shares the story of a middle-aged man he had treated for a cardiac problem. Years after the initial treatment, the man started showing some bizarre symptoms. Dr Vacchani recommended a specialised heart test called an angiogram. But during the test, the

man suddenly became unexplainably aggressive. After talking to him, Dr Vacchani felt as though someone—or something—else was communicating through the man. Says the good doctor, "This entity said it wanted to harm the patient but was deterred by my presence. I believe it was Gurudev's grace protecting this man and me."

In an exchange with Rajpal ji, the mahaguru delved into the philosophical depths of spiritual healing and the role of a guru in altering trends of destiny.

Gurudev said, "Many approach me, frustrated with ailments that persist despite numerous treatments. What do I do? I reconfigure their fate; I relieve their suffering, for I am their guru."

Curious, Rajpal ji inquired, "By altering the course set by the divine, don't you fear displeasing God?"

Gurudev answered confidently, "Quite the opposite—it delights God immensely."

Perplexed, Rajpal ji questioned further, "But if you are altering God's plan, wouldn't that upset him?"

With a gentle laugh, Gurudev explained, "Not at all, my son. By healing someone, I am soothing the divine presence within them. In this way, I am also alleviating God's own distress. This same divine force has given me the title of Guru and endowed me with the power to heal. God does not meddle in my work; I am in control here. Who will provide solace to those suffering if I do not step in?"

Gurudev's words often went beyond the grasp of conventional understanding. His insights into spiritual healing highlighted deep synergies between the healer's energies and those of the

person being healed. His approach involved focusing on healing the divine essence in beings and altering the trends of fate to bring them relief. In this holistic view, healing went beyond physical, mental, or emotional repair to become a restorative act that brought balance to the collective consciousness.

Chapter 10

Peerless Mentorship

As a young spiritualist, my quest for knowledge turned me into a living encyclopaedia of theoretical wisdom. I read books on healing, nature-based cures, and Ayurveda and kept a diary of herbal remedies shared by my gurubhais. Once, when a visitor to the sthan complained of a particular ailment, I rushed to my car to fetch the diary, eager to prescribe the perfect remedy. The herbs worked wonders once I blessed them and gave them to visitors. Oddly enough, there was a positive outcome even when my weak memory led me to suggest incorrect remedies sometimes!

One day, Gurudev summoned me and imparted an important lesson. He encouraged me to trust in myself more than the herbs and plants. He remarked, "*Tu kaagaz bhi maathe pe lagaa ke usko de degaa, toh woh theek ho jaayega* (Even if you bless a piece of paper and give it to a visitor, it will serve as a cure)". These 15 words became a lesson for life, leading me to realise the immense power of the human aura. When channelled through a focused mind, it can unleash capabilities beyond one's wildest imagination.

The mahaguru defied convention. Clad in his simple *lungi*, he would sit on his bed in his modest bedroom, engaging those around him with life lessons drawn directly from his

own experiences. Reflecting on this unique style, Mrs Jolly, a dedicated follower, notes the stark contrast between Gurudev's methods and those of some other spiritual leaders: "In other places, you were greeted with sermons and hymns. But at the sthan, those traditions were absent. Gurudev's teachings were purely experiential and personal."

"The nature of Gurudev's spiritual guidance was customised, where certain insights were relevant to one person but not necessarily to another," Pradeep ji notes. "This led to an unconventional approach where formal discourses or lectures were absent. The guiding philosophy was simple: every individual is an integral part of the *param-aatma*, and by offering solace to all life forms, one finds comfort in return."

Bindu ji beautifully encapsulates Gurudev's mentorship style with the word '*Sahaj*'.[1] She says, "*Bhakti*[2] with Gurudev was *sahaj*. It unfolded as a journey of incremental steps. It was less about renouncing the world or adopting asceticism and more about achieving equilibrium—engaging with familial and societal responsibilities while cultivating a spirit of detachment. 'Detachment within attachment' is what he preached."

Gurudev stressed the significance of being fully present in all facets of life—be it with family, in business endeavours, or spiritual devotion. For him, spiritual progress was a path marked by introspection, self-correction, and perpetual self-enhancement. Our only competition was with ourselves; it was our spirits that he was endeavouring to refine.

Uma Prabhu ji, a dedicated student of Gurudev's teachings, often reflects on his words. She shares, "He advised, 'Merely reciting mantras is not enough. It is crucial not only to chant but to actively

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1 Effortless, or spontaneous
2 Scriptures qualify it as intense love and devotion to a personal form of God. However, we qualify it as unemotional self-worship

transform your *gunas.*[1] There is immense value in introspecting and recognising your flaws, then diligently working to rectify them'. And I have been consistently striving to do just that."

The path laid out by the mahaguru was clear in direction yet challenging in its pursuit, a testament to the enduring discipline required to walk it.

"His path to spiritual evolution was lined with discipline," Bindu ji observes, "yet it was remarkably straightforward. It was as natural as a river's flow. You visited the sthan, paid your respects, did seva, and sometimes listened to his spiritual insights before returning home. Back then, I did not fully grasp his teachings, yet I always left with something meaningful. It was only decades later that the significance of his words dawned on me."

My experience mirrored Bindu ji's. Despite being much older, I enjoyed Gurudev's talks, yet their true essence eluded me. It seemed as though he addressed not the individual present before him, but rather the person they were destined to evolve into in the future.

His sayings were enigmatic and intense:
"Always walk with death by your side."
"If you want to conquer sorrow, first learn to conquer joy."

With time, these cryptic statements transformed into powerful catalysts for change. Today, his teachings, encapsulated in *ek vakhyas*, have taken on a new dimension. They invite deep contemplation, a journey that promises enlightenment to those willing to engage with the insights that emerge.

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1 In Hindu philosophy, *gunas* refer to the three fundamental qualities or attributes—Sattva, Rajas and Tamas—that constitute all of nature and influence human behaviour and thought. In spiritual practices, the aim is to cultivate Sattva while managing and transcending the influences of Rajas and Tamas

The mahaguru had a way of simplifying complex ideas, making them accessible to everyone, regardless of their initial capabilities. He challenged ordinary individuals to undertake extraordinary tasks, like healing others, without prior knowledge or skills. According to Surender ji from Kanpur, this was a mark of the mahaguru's spiritual stature: "Gurudev asked any random person, who had no idea how, to start curing people. How could they have possibly known how to heal? They obeyed what Gurudev told them, and people found relief. Only a very evolved being and exceptional mentor can help others reach the level to which he helped us evolve."

Like Surender ji, many of us found the self-evaluation process challenging. We often wondered why Gurudev chose to mentor us; perhaps, we reasoned, there was some inherent value in us that we could not yet recognise. Our inability to acknowledge and accept our worth became a stumbling block in our journey of self-discovery.

Kishanmohan ji, who does seva in Durgapur, West Bengal, shares a personal anecdote that illustrates this beautifully: "Gurudev once told me that anyone I touched would experience healing. Following Gurudev's guidance, I treated my maternal uncle, and he felt better. I could not comprehend how this healing occurred at the time—it was a mystery to me."

Like many of us, Kishanmohan ji was initially unaware of the latent abilities within him. We were like 'pre-cooked meals' awaiting microwaving. Gurudev pressed the right buttons to awaken our dormant capabilities linked to our past lives. This unique approach of reconnecting our past and present enabled us to make rapid strides in our spiritual and personal development under his guidance.

Kapill ji watches as Gurudev activates his gurubhai's fourth eye

Kapill Malhotra ji, who oversees a sthan in the serene hill station of Lonavala near Mumbai, recounts a remarkable experience that affirms the subtle and mysterious nature of spiritual guidance: "I once dreamt of accompanying Gurudev and Guruji (Gurudev's disciple) on a walk, along with one of my gurubhais. As we were walking, I observed Gurudev placing his right hand on the soft part of my gurubhai's head, a spot referred to as the *talvi*."[1]

When their eyes met, Gurudev smiled at Kapill ji and revealed, "*Maine iska kaam kar diya hai* (I have done his work)", which Kapill ji instinctively understood as Gurudev opening his gurubhai's fourth eye.

Unlike the third eye located on the forehead, the fourth eye is said to be at the back of the head. Its activation is likened to the gentle tearing of thin tissue paper, bestowing the unique ability to perceive from behind. Gurudev, interestingly, often opted to close the third eye of individuals, a measure intended

1 Soft part of the skull at the back of the head; the location of the crown or Sahasrara chakra

to protect them from the overwhelming distractions associated with glimpsing into the past, present or future. As a guide of unparalleled wisdom, he took measures to shield his disciples from the potential pitfalls of these abilities, ensuring their spiritual journey progressed smoothly and without impediments.

Santlal ji recalls, "Gurudev would assess our spiritual growth using his metrics. His goal was always to encourage our self-improvement and spiritual transformation. He used to say that our true accomplishment would be us surpassing his achievements." For someone as influential as Gurudev to encourage his followers to surpass him was not just ambitious but a testament to his humility. He believed in the equality of all yet acknowledged that some may rise faster on the spiritual ladder than others.

Santlal ji continues, his voice filled with deep admiration, "His generosity knew no bounds, and his eagerness to help was unparalleled. While it is likely that many gurus possess similar traits, I can confidently say I have never encountered anyone who both preached and practised these virtues to the extent he did. Meeting him was a turning point in my life; he taught me how to truly live. His unwavering commitment to alleviating people's sufferings, regardless of the effort required, was truly remarkable. Finding a guru who embodies Gurudev's qualities and characteristics is nearly impossible."

I asked Puran ji a direct question: "What do you think Gurudev expected from his disciples?"

His response was brief yet on point: "Total surrender."

The concept of surrender, encapsulated in just nine letters, proved 900 times more challenging to understand than we

initially thought. True surrender demands relinquishing ego, body, mind, and spirit. In this complete submission, a profound connection with the guru is established, making the disciple and guru inseparable. The disciple understands that they and the guru are manifestations of the same supreme consciousness but at different stages of their spiritual journey. Through total surrender, the disciple's mind ceases to exist at an individual level and begins to exist only in relation to the guru, functioning solely as an instrument of this elevated state.

Renu ji conveys a unique and seldom-heard philosophy imparted by her father, one that diverges from the common pursuit of recognition. He advised her, "As you advance in your spiritual journey, refrain from idolising me. Focus instead on transcending the act of worship."

This perspective is revolutionary. It is rare to encounter an individual who deliberately avoids seeking a place of importance in the lives of others. However, a person in complete alignment with their divine nature, as Gurudev was, has no necessity for external validation.

Dr Shankarnarayan ji once quoted Gurudev, saying, "You can become Shiv yourself". At the time, this statement seemed impressive but unattainable for many of us. But after years of practical experience and surrendering to Gurudev's teachings, we have come to understand that the potential to realise our divinity and share our realisations with others lies in each of us.

Reflecting on Gurudev's phenomenal impact, Uma ji and I discussed an important question. I asked, "How should we move forward after Gurudev's physical departure?"

Uma ji articulated a beautiful sentiment: "His vast ocean of wisdom remains for us to access, and more people must become aware of it. Life is a relay race, and we must pass on the baton to keep his legacy alive."

Gurudev's teachings are like a compass pointing towards the true north, providing guidance when we feel lost. They offer us opportunities to learn and, more importantly, unlearn. Our faith in our commitments might waver, but our belief in his teachings remains steadfast. In this unwavering faith, we find our path to success. It is our responsibility to follow his footsteps, utilise his wisdom, and share his insights with future travellers.

The journey must go on, and it will.

Chapter 11

Sacred Syllables

Among the spiritual tools Gurudev advocated, mantra *vidya* is a powerful medium for inner transformation. The mahaguru fully embraced its significance, highlighting its essential role with two other vital pillars—seva and the refinement of *gunas*—on the journey of self-realisation. His mantras were *siddh*, distinct from those found in traditional scriptures or online resources. He selflessly bestowed these powerful mantras upon his disciples, enabling them to achieve *siddhi*[1] in remarkably short durations.

Gurudev had a knack for showcasing the effectiveness of the mantras he imparted to his disciples using highly creative methods to demonstrate their power. This was particularly evident in an incident with his first disciple, RC Malhotra ji, where he showcased the efficacy of the **Chamunda mantra**.

In the early 1970s, in a remote camp setting, Gurudev led Malhotra ji on a journey through a dense forest. As they ventured deeper, Malhotra ji began to perceive ethereal beings emerging from the shadows, stirring a sense of fear within him. Eventually, he found himself alone in the forest as Gurudev had seemingly vanished. The mahaguru had hidden behind a tree to

1 Mastering a specific mantra through continuous recitation, often under the guidance of a guru. The practitioners aim to align their energy with the vibrational frequency of the mantra, which is believed to unlock spiritual powers or psychic abilities related to the mantra's intent. Achieving *siddhi* is considered a sign of the mantra becoming fully activated within the practitioners, allowing them to realise its full spiritual potential and benefits

watch his disciple's reaction. Faced with the advancing ethereal figures, Malhotra ji recalled Gurudev's teachings and began to mentally chant the Chamunda mantra with intense fervour. As the mantra's vibrations filled the air, the ghostly entities began to retreat before they disappeared from view. This experience, masterfully orchestrated by Gurudev, was an exhibition of the Chamunda mantra's extraordinary capability to ward off seen and unseen spiritual threats, solidifying its role as a powerful tool for spiritual protection.

The Chamunda mantra is a Shakti mantra dedicated to Goddess Chamunda, a wrathful form of Goddess Durga. She is usually portrayed with a fearsome appearance, bloodshot eyes, and a garland of skulls around her neck, slaying the demons Chanda and Munda, from whom she derives her name. She symbolises protection from and the destruction of negative energies.

The effectiveness of the Chamunda mantra transcends simple belief, a truth many stand by, including Darius Moos ji, a devoted *sevadaar* at the Mumbai sthan. With over three decades dedicated to mantra *vidya*, Darius ji offers valuable insights: "The Chamunda mantra can be used for defence and protection. When you are sent to someone's house to negotiate with a spirit that refuses to cooperate, you can use this mantra to either scare it away or as a protective tool."

Echoing this sentiment, Ridhim ji adds, "As part of our seva of offering spiritual relief, we often find ourselves visiting houses infested with spirits. These negative energies are sensed as intense pressure around the head. However, specific mantras, such as the Chamunda mantra, act as armour against these unsettling energies. As we start chanting the mantra internally, the heaviness begins to fade. This is tangible evidence of the mantra's capability to counter negative forces."

Rajeev Hazarat ji, an experienced practitioner and longtime *sevadaar*, adds: "At times, when facing hostile spirits, they can disguise themselves as revered entities like Shiv, attempting to provoke or challenge you. Sometimes, they may even use flattery as part of their cunning tactics. In these instances, the Chamunda mantra is especially powerful in countering their deceit."

Recalling a vivid dream, Darius ji speaks of a fierce encounter with a hostile entity: "I had a dream once where a very evil-looking spirit attacked me. When I started chanting the Chamunda mantra, I grew to around 20 feet in height, holding two weapons of blue light, and I chopped the spirit into pieces!"

The remarkable ability to transform and reach a height of 20 feet showcases the extraordinary capability of an advanced *suksham sharir*,[1] which Darius ji, given his longstanding commitment to seva and mantra *vidya*, evidently possesses.

Mantras serve as potent tools for healing both physical and mental maladies. Darius ji highlights the therapeutic advantages of the Chamunda mantra, stating, "Upon integrating it into patient care, we have discovered its remarkable efficacy in treating skeletal, muscular, and neurological pain. Moreover, it has shown significant potential in alleviating stress and tension."

At this stage, it is crucial to highlight another key aspect of the healing process—intention. The power of a mantra is greatly amplified when aligned with the healer's focused intention. This synergy explains how a single mantra can be effectively applied to achieve success across diverse spiritual endeavours.

1 Subtle or astral body, which has existed before, during, and will continue to exist after this life. Its goal is the attainment of spiritual energy, which can be used when it exists purely in its non-physical form

It is noteworthy that numerous individuals have been bestowed with mantras in their dreams. Kapill Malhotra ji recounts a fascinating experience: "I have come across some people who have been given mantras in their dreams. I, too, received a mantra during a dream, but the deity's identity was not revealed to me. However, upon waking, I found I had lost memory of the words. When I shared this experience with Guruji (Gurudev's disciple), he suggested that I keep a record of any similar revelations in my dreams in the future."

Echoing Kapill ji's experience, Rajeev ji recounts a similar encounter: "Years ago, I was given a mantra in a dream. Its rhythm resembled the mantric chants with which we are familiar. Unfortunately, upon waking, the precise words and the deity it invoked slipped from my memory."

These incidents offer a captivating perspective: dreams are not mere flights of fancy; they are channels for spiritual insight.

Ashish Khanna ji asserts, "Mantras, particularly those bestowed by a *siddh* guru, must be approached with utmost reverence."

He continues, "During an intense meditation session one evening, I felt a distinct negative energy encroaching upon my space. It was disconcerting. Without hesitation, I transitioned from the Mahagayatri mantra, which I was chanting, to the Chamunda mantra, seeking protection from this unwelcome force. The change in atmosphere was immediate. As the Chamunda mantra resonated within, a coolness and lightness surrounded me, contrasting sharply with the heat that the Mahagayatri mantra had radiated."

The **Mahagayatri mantra**, a sacred verse from the *Rig Veda*,[1] stands as one of the most powerful mantras in existence. Its composition follows the Gayatri metre, known for its distinctive arrangement: 24 syllables divided into three lines, each with eight syllables. This mantra is a potent call to the solar deity Savitur, seeking illumination of the intellect as one progresses towards self-realisation.

The mantra's discovery is attributed to Brahmarishi Vishwamitra, who, through intense and prolonged meditation, was bestowed with its divine revelation, making him both its originator and guardian—however, an intriguing turn of events led to Guru Vashisht fragmenting this mantra. Ravi Trehan ji explains the backstory: "The Mahagayatri mantra, found in the *Rig Veda*, was once chanted in its entirety by both deities and demons, granting immense spiritual power to both factions.

"While the deities utilised this mantra for noble purposes, the demons exploited it for their evil goals. This misuse by the demons, especially their acts of desecrating the sacred fire rituals of the deities with bones and flesh, prompted the divine beings to seek a resolution to curb their growing menace. Distressed by the threat to their spiritual progression, the deities sought Lord Brahma's intervention. Directed from him to Lord Vishnu, and subsequently to Lord Shankar, they were eventually advised to seek help from Guru Vashisht.

"Upon their arrival at Guru Vashisht's humble dwelling, a significant revelation awaited them. Guru Vashisht, engrossed in reading the *Vedas*,[2] instantly recognised the divine assembly's purpose, as foretold by the page he was reading: the arrival of the

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1 The first of the four *Vedas*, which are foundational scriptures in Hinduism. Composed in Sanskrit, it consists of 1,028 hymns (or *suktas*) dedicated to various deities, such as Agni, Indra, and Soma. These hymns are grouped into 10 books, or *mandalas*, and are primarily invocations and prayers meant for ritualistic use and guidance on spiritual, philosophical, and moral questions

2 A large body of texts originating in ancient India. Composed in Vedic Sanskrit, they form the oldest layer of Sanskrit literature and the oldest scriptures of Hinduism. There are four Vedas: the Rig *Veda*, Yajur *Veda*, Sama *Veda*, and Atharva *Veda*

deities alongside the accompanying trio of Brahma, Vishnu, and Shankar, signified the time to fragment the Mahagayatri mantra.

"Guru Vashisht revealed that starting with the following generation, only a *siddh* guru could impart the full and original Mahagayatri mantra to the disciple, and this transmission would occur in utmost secrecy," Ravi ji shares.

He concludes the tale by highlighting the outcome: "Thus, the mantra was divided, with the familiar Gayatri Mantra emerging as one part and the remaining eight words discreetly dispersed throughout the four *Vedas*, concealed from the world at large."

Regarding the mantra's deeper essence, Ravi ji recalls Gurudev's words: "Mahagayatri is more than just a mantra; it embodies the spirit of the four *Vedas*. Charged with energy, it grants tangible and spiritual rewards to those who chant it. One can break free from the endless loops of birth and death by invoking its power."

The Mahagayatri mantra serves as a potent conduit, bridging the tangible realm of our physical existence with the subtle expanses of spiritual dimensions. It plays a pivotal role in channelling energies from the lower chakras to the higher ones, facilitating spiritual ascent. Among its myriad benefits is purging one's *samskaras*, which are the imprints left by past births. This purification is a vital step toward achieving *mukti*, or liberation from the cycle of life and death, eventually paving the way for the ultimate spiritual goal: dissolution of identity or *moksha*.

The Mahagayatri mantra embodies a unique duality of elemental energies, as it ignites the fire element within practitioners and has a deep affinity with the water element.

I recall an episode from my early dalliances with the mantra. Engulfed by the mantra's fiery force, I lost control of my temper,

reacting harshly towards my housekeeper, Khemchand, who had sown seeds of discord within my family. I pushed him in thoughtless anger, watching as he stumbled backwards. That moment was a grounding reflection of my behaviour and a testament to the influencing power of the mantra vibrating within me. Regular hydration is advisable to mitigate the intense heat generated by this mantra, helping to prevent physical unease or mental agitation.

The Mahagayatri mantra's connection with the element of water is of deep spiritual significance. Upon seeing a vision of a woman dressed in jeans swimming effortlessly underwater, a scene I felt carried deeper significance, I consulted with Gurudev. He interpreted this vision as an indication that my practice of the Mahagayatri mantra had reached a state of *siddhi*. This insight aligns with the experiences of many practitioners of this mantra, who frequently report dreams and visions involving water bodies, suggesting a deep spiritual synergy between this mantra and the water element.

Pooja Seth ji reflects on her experiences: "Years into my practice of the Mahagayatri mantra, I began to experience clear water-themed visions. I saw myself walking on the water and noticed snakes under the water. Curious about this, I talked to Guruji (Gurudev's disciple), and he told me that these visions were due to the Mahagayatri mantra I was chanting."

"The essence of Gayatri is the life in water," Raji ji clarifies. "Perhaps this connection with water is why Gurudev consistently advised against eating fish or seafood."

Ashish ji shares a memorable event: "A troubled farmer came to the sthan in Gopiganj, deeply concerned about the aridness of his fields. I suggested exploring options such as hand pumps or advanced irrigation methods. Yet, the farmer explained that such

Water surfaces on arid land after Ashish ji scatters blessed mustard seeds

efforts were pointless because his land lacked underground water sources, rendering it barren and unable to yield crops."

Determined to help, Ashish ji made his way to the parched land. He began chanting the Mahagayatri mantra and scattered mustard seeds across the terrain. Astonishingly, on his third attempt, water began to surface. Further exploration revealed a hidden underground water source.

Feeling thankful, the farmer asked Ashish ji how he could express his gratitude. Ashish ji advised him to share the water they had discovered with the neighbouring farmers. Taking this counsel to heart, the farmer now shares the water, utilising it for his fields while also assisting his neighbours.

Mantras are perceived variably across cultures. While many regard them as tools for healing and spiritual growth, others have experienced their capabilities in accomplishing remarkable feats.

Kapill ji's story resonates with the Mahagayatri mantra's remarkable efficacy: "Sixteen years ago, my gurubhai and I went to the house of a family that visits the sthan and does seva. Guruji (Gurudev's disciple) had instructed us to clear the negative energies from their home. Unexpectedly, without prior discussion, we closed our eyes and began chanting the Mahagayatri mantra. A female figure emerged in our vision. As we continued chanting, she shrank in size, transitioning from a five-foot presence to a mere foot, before vanishing entirely."

What followed next was even more astonishing. "Ordinarily, we use the Chamunda mantra for such tasks," he acknowledges. "Yet, that day, guided seemingly by shared instinct and purpose, we found ourselves chanting the Mahagayatri mantra. Remarkably, upon reflecting on the event after we left the house, my gurubhai and I discovered we had both visualised the same spirit going through the same change at the same time!"

Kapil Mahtani ji, a *sevadaar* at the Mumbai sthan, recounts an insightful experience from a family trip to London in 2019, which affirms the protective power of mantras: "Upon our arrival at the hotel, we were initially accommodated in a rather cramped room. Dissatisfied, I requested a larger space, and the hotel staff obliged by relocating us. However, I was struck by an unsettling heaviness around my head when we stepped into the new room."

This discomfort escalated into a tangible force pressing down on him during the night, rendering him immobile. "I was filled with the realisation that I was facing a spiritual attack," he says. "Instinctively, I began to recite the Mahagayatri mantra mentally, and within moments, the oppressive weight lifted, freeing me from its hold. This experience was a lesson in the mantra's efficacy as a protection against unseen energies."

Kishanmohan ji has dedicated over three decades to the practice of mantras. His expertise is primarily used to address the unique and challenging issues faced by Durgapur's local community. Despite the town's modernity, it grapples with problems linked to witchcraft and black magic. He notes, "With Gurudev's guidance, we have harnessed the power of mantras to shield people from diverse problems, achieving a 75 to 80% success rate."

He elaborates on a particular concern: the local mines—notorious for their hazards, including frequent accidents, flooding, and deadly gas emissions. Gurudev theorised that the miners' constant battles against nature's caprices within these mines might inadvertently invite negative energies, escalating the risk of accidents and mishaps.

Recognising the seriousness of the situation and aware that many of his followers worked as miners, Kishanmohan ji took swift action. Heeding Gurudev's advice, he encircled the mines, scattering mustard seeds energised with the Mahagayatri mantra to ward off negative energies. Furthermore, he gave the miners cloves and cardamoms that had been blessed with the mantra. This unique approach—combining the power of mantra-charged mustard seeds and blessed spices—notably improved the safety of the miners in their underground activities.

Mantras, such as the Mahagayatri, are often used to create protective *keels*.[1] Nandlal, one of the first visitors to the sthan at Khar, once confided in me about disturbing energy at his shop, which appeared to discourage potential renters, impacting his financial well-being. Sensing the negativity during my visit, I mentally created a *keel* around the room to contain the spirit within a specific space. Days later, the trapped spirit, desperate

1 Energy boundaries to contain or neutralise negative energies within a given space. Additionally, they function as protective barriers, efficiently shielding areas, individuals, and objects from negative influences within a specified radius

Kapill ji uses the Mahagaytri mantra to create a keel

for release, revealed its identity as Nandlal's uncle. This uncle, who had reportedly battled mental health issues, had vanished years ago, possibly taking his own life. His lingering attachment to the place and desire to live there in solitude made him retaliate against any new occupants.

Kapill ji recounts a similar experience: "On one of our trips to Delhi, we stayed in a hotel that seemed low on occupancy despite its prime location. One night, as I slept, a menacing, towering figure loomed in my dream, threatening my gurubhai, sleeping nearby. The next morning, I confided in Guruji (Gurudev's disciple), who advised me to visualise the entity and trap it within a *keel* using the Mahagayatri mantra. This did the trick," he says with a smile. "I could never book a room in that hotel after that because its occupancy had touched the roof!"

He continues, "I recall another incident. Guruji (Gurudev's disciple) had left his energised handprint in a room in Dehradun. But one night, a gurubhai was attacked by an aggressive force while resting in that very room. Angered by this, Guruji summoned

me to secure the room with a *keel*, trapping the harmful spirit. Subsequently, when Guruji entered the room, the negativity was dispelled in mere minutes!"

The **Mahamrityunjay mantra**, a Shiv mantra commonly perceived as a shield against the inevitable clasp of death, embodies a depth much more significant than widely understood. According to Raji ji, this mantra "controls all that is destructible in the world. Its essence goes beyond safeguarding life; it prevents disintegration and ensures continuity."

Babloo ji, a disciple of Santosh ji from Nadaun, adds, "When we infuse cloves and cardamoms with the Mahamrityunjay mantra, they become charged with a powerful healing energy." This unique process of charging these spices with the mantra's power is said to have shown remarkable healing results, particularly in cases where the medical prognosis was uncertain or inclined towards a long-term or seemingly impossible recovery.

Raji ji explores the intricate layers of mantric traditions, offering a nuanced view of their importance. He illustrates that while the Mahagayatri (associated with Shakti) and Mahamrityunjay (linked to Shiv) mantras are highly revered, there exists a broader, more profound dimension within the mantric tradition that transcends the individual energies of Shakti and Shiv. He stresses, "The bond between a guru and their disciple is sanctified through each mantra, yet all mantras ultimately merge into a single, unified form". The exalted **Mahaguru mantra** epitomises this convergence.

He adds, "This union represents the harmonic synergy of every *naad* or sound within the universe. Therefore, the Mahaguru mantra is the final, infinite mantra."

Ravi Trehan ji explains, "The Mahaguru mantra is incredibly powerful. It combines three divine energies: Guru Brahma, Guru Vishnu, and Guru Maheshwara. Despite their distinct forms, they emerge from and represent the same divine essence. This mantra goes beyond these forms to recognise a supreme power, the *Par Brahm*. The mantra's words, '*Guru shakshat par brahm, tasmayee shri guruve namah'*, mean that the guru embodies the ultimate truth, surpassing all illusion."

He concludes with a recommendation: "Mantra *vidya* requires a disciplined and dedicated approach. The more effort you invest in it, the greater the benefits you will experience."

As a businessman, I believe three halves are better than one whole; I, therefore, advise people to do their mantras while performing daily tasks such as walking, cooking, driving, etc. Raji ji echoes this approach: "When I began my journey with mantras, Gurudev encouraged me to recite them continuously, regardless of what I was doing. He assured me that he would acknowledge each recitation. From that moment, every mantra Gurudev gave me seamlessly blended into my daily routine and, eventually, became my breath."

Mantra chanting transcends mere repetition. It serves as an anchor for the mind, steering it away from its tendency to drift, eventually becoming an integral part of one's essence—a phenomenon Raji ji eloquently refers to as 'becoming one's breath'. The consistent practice of chanting mantras has a transformative effect. The key to accessing these remarkable benefits is not in the pursuit of more, but in doing more.

Gurudev directs the creation of a water canal in Renuka

Chapter 12

Elemental Symphony

In the late 1980s, we encountered a significant hurdle at the Khandsa farm: the only available water was saline and unsuitable for agriculture. Recognising the critical need for a viable water source, Gurudev confidently guided us to a particular spot on the farm and instructed us to dig. To our astonishment, we unearthed an underground reservoir of water directly beneath that spot. As we dug further, freshwater surfaced, promising sustainable irrigation for the farm's future.

Years earlier, Gurudev had faced a similar predicament in an arid region of Renuka, where he and his team established a soil survey camp. Alongside Bittu ji and a labourer, he ascended a nearby mountain. On their descent, Gurudev instructed Bittu ji to trace the path he walked with a stick, outlining where a canal could be dug. He directed the labourer to follow this line with his digging. Miraculously, as the labourer dug, water began to surge forth, forming a canal that flowed directly to their campsite. This newly sourced water not only sustained them during their stay but also revitalised the dry terrain into a lush green sanctuary. However, once they vacated the camp, the water receded to its source, and the land reverted to its barren state.

Water was central to Gurudev's spiritual practices, serving as a key medium for sharing his spiritual energy. His mastery over

this element was vividly displayed when he initiated his first disciple, RC Malhotra ji, in Haridwar.

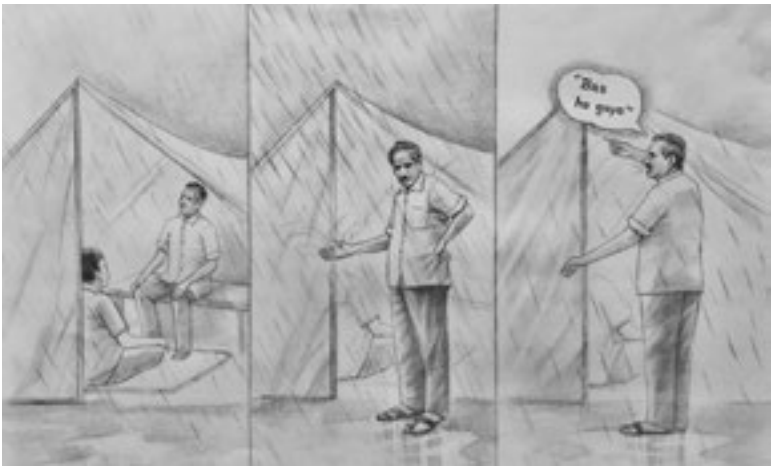
Ravi ji, narrating Malhotra ji's experience, describes the scene: "Standing in the Ganges, amidst a strong current, Gurudev instructed Malhotra ji to lie horizontally in the water, positioning his head at his feet in a gesture of complete surrender, a *dandvat pranaam*.[1] Malhotra ji initially hesitated, citing the fierce current and his inability to swim. Gurudev urged him to follow his instructions. To Malhotra ji's astonishment, the moment he complied, the raging waters of the Ganges became still!"

Overwhelmed by this experience, Malhotra ji later questioned Gurudev about the miraculous stilling of the river's waters. The mahaguru's response was understated: "The elements of nature are under my control."

Gupta ji from Parwanoo is another witness to nature bending to the mahaguru's will. He describes an incident in Odi, situated in the rugged beauty of Narkanda in Himachal Pradesh: "The heavens had opened up, unleashing a fierce torrent of rain and hail. As Gurudev stepped outside his camped tent, he spoke to the raging heavens with a commanding tone, declaring, 'Enough is enough'. As if directly responding to Gurudev's powerful command, the stormy skies immediately cleared!"

I had the privilege of witnessing something similar at a camp in Mungaoli. Gurudev and I were seated in a tent when a heavy downpour began. He stepped outside to look intently at the sky, then returned, yet the rain continued unabated. As I conversed with him, I noticed his focus seemingly divided. Suddenly, he rose, angrily pushed aside the tent flap, and with an authoritative

1 A traditional gesture of reverence, where one prostrates fully on the ground, face down, with arms outstretched. This form of bowing is often performed in front of gurus as a mark of surrender



Gurudev demonstrates his mastery over the rain in Mungaoli

voice directed towards the heavens, he commanded the rain to cease, and cease it did, almost instantly!

As a witness to this extraordinary spectacle, I found myself momentarily at a loss for words, captivated by the sheer magnitude of the moment.

Baljeet ji's pivotal role in constructing the sthans at Najafgarh and Sector-10 in Gurgaon highlights his deep-seated commitment to Gurudev's mission.

Recalling a significant moment from 1989, during the early stages of construction at the sthan at Sector-10, he shares, "It was an overcast day, and I was deeply concerned about possible delays due to the rain. Noticing my unrest, Gurudev approached me. I requested Gurudev for a brief pause in the rain so that our work could continue smoothly."

Gurudev's intervention was truly miraculous. "The rain stopped instantly and did not return for nine days," Baljeet ji says. "Even

on the tenth day, as we were installing the lintel, rain soaked the areas around, but our site stayed completely dry."

He reflects on Gurudev's words: "When I thanked him for his intervention, he said, 'Controlling the weather is a simple task for me.'"

In 1988, Snehalata ji endured the heartbreaking loss of her husband, who was Gurudev's younger brother. She recounts an event from that period of mourning: "At that time, Punjab was devastated by severe floods, and our hometown of Hariana was heavily affected. When Gurudev entered the temple grounds where my husband's body lay, something extraordinary occurred. The floodwaters, threateningly close to the temple's entrance, began to recede. It was as if the water showed respect, softly touching Gurudev's feet before withdrawing."

She reflects on that moment, noting, "Such miracles are rare, yet I was fortunate enough to witness one first-hand."

Santlal ji shares a compelling story of an incident at Juhu Beach, offering another instance where nature seemed to acknowledge Gurudev's spiritual eminence. He saw an isolated wave emerge, seemingly out of nowhere. It moved intently, softly caressing Gurudev's slippers before quietly receding into the ocean. This deliberate gesture by the sea, singling out Gurudev's slippers from everything else on the beach, served as a subtle, yet powerful, testament to the mahaguru's spiritual powers.

Giri ji and I also witnessed similar phenomena. The ocean's behaviour bore a striking resemblance to what Santlal ji had witnessed, leading us to affectionately coin the term 'same to same' to describe these shared experiences.

Giri ji reflects on the lessons imparted by the mahaguru about the respect owed to nature, saying, "Gurudev was a true embodiment of his teachings, demonstrating through his actions the significance of planting trees and engaging with agriculture."

He fondly remembers the times he accompanied Gurudev to Khandsa, where the mahaguru immersed himself in every aspect of the farm's workings. He would plough the fields on his tractor, hand-pick the vegetables, and milk the cows. During harvest season, he would also lend a hand in separating the chaff.

Gurudev always emphasised that our actions should align with the nature's rhythm. Devraj Khare ji's story highlights how nature can sometimes push back against human endeavours. He begins by setting the scene: "Periodically, we go to Lonavala, where we have a home with a garden and many trees. I took responsibility for the garden's upkeep, including tree maintenance."

He recalls a specific incident: "Some years ago, I noticed that one of the trees was attracting a lot of insects and required trimming. I instructed the local gardener to trim the tree, supervising the task myself. However, the following morning, I woke up with bed bug bites all over my body."

"A couple of weeks later, I approached the gardener once more, requesting him to prune the excessively grown creepers," he recalls. However, the next day, he was afflicted with bug bites again. This was particularly perplexing since he had already spent several nights in Lonavala without any untoward incident. It led him to speculate a possible link between these bites and the trimming of the trees.

On his third visit, Devraj ji decided to test his hypothesis: "I made it a point to ask the gardener to trim a particular tree. As the gardener did so, I felt a strange, tingling sensation on my

body. The following day, the bites reappeared. I then understood the correlation between my actions and bodily reactions."

In a moment of introspection, he approached the trimmed tree: "I folded my hands and asked for forgiveness, promising never to do it again". This realisation was further reinforced in a later incident involving palm trees. While walking in the evening, the gardener pointed out snakes camouflaging in them. Devraj ji's initial reaction was to suggest trimming the trees, but he immediately felt a sensation in his left hand. Realising the importance of not interfering with nature's course, he said, "Just let nature be."

During every Mahashivratri at Gurgaon, a remarkable event would unfold, mystifying those who witnessed it. As part of a ritual, Gurudev would bless the boiling lemon tea in a manner that seemed to defy the laws of nature. He would immerse his hands into the scalding liquid for a few seconds, yet surprisingly, his hands remained unscathed.

Gurudev's sister Rashmi ji recounts her initial scepticism and eventual astonishment at what she witnessed: "I had a hard time believing that Gurudev could place his hands in boiling tea without harming himself."

Her disbelief was challenged when she witnessed this extraordinary act in person. She marvels, "I saw with my own eyes how Gurudev fearlessly placed his hands into boiling tea, not just once but thrice. Each instance left me more amazed than the last. In fact, on the third occasion, he submerged his hands even deeper into the vessel. Yet, remarkably, his hands remained burn free."

This astonishing feat was more than a demonstration of the mahaguru's physical endurance. It spoke volumes about his alignment with all life forms, elements, and cosmic energies.

Gurudev submerges his hands in boiling lemon tea

Roshini ji shares a story demonstrating the mahaguru's remarkable influence over the elements, transcending his physical presence. "It was a typical Sunday seva at the Mumbai sthan, and I was serving tea to the visitors. While conversing with a visitor, I accidentally spilt hot tea on my hand, causing immediate pain and visible redness. My hand began to sting sharply and turned a deep red," she recalls.

Caught up in her duties, Roshini ji did not immediately attend to her burn, and the pain and redness worsened. It was after she managed to rinse her hand under cold water a few minutes later that a thought struck her. "I am Gurudev's daughter. He mastered control over fire, so my hand will be fine," she remembers thinking. Miraculously, within moments of this realisation, "The pain subsided, the redness disappeared, and there were no traces of the burn," she describes, amazed at the healing that followed her conviction.

Gautam Bhushan ji adds further evidence of these remarkable events with an anecdote of his own. "During a visit to a devotee's home, accompanied by another *sevadaar*, Akash Sharma ji, we departed without lighting any *jyot*," he recalls.

Unexpectedly, they later received a call from the homeowner inquiring if they had lit the *jyot* before leaving. "We had not done anything like that, yet the *jyot* had mysteriously ignited by itself, without any *ghee*," he reveals.

The vast expanse of space often set the stage for many of the mahaguru's spiritual journeys, with astral travel being a prominent foray. Gurudev's mastery of out-of-the-body experiences was akin to that of a legendary escape artist, effortlessly moving between the physical and ethereal realms. This practice, known to him as *paath*, was a vital part of his daily spiritual discipline.

During these ethereal voyages, he could visit the various sthans he had established across the globe and extend his guidance and support to those in need. His astral travels also facilitated meetings with spiritual luminaries such as Guru Nanak, Guru Angad, Shirdi Sai Baba, and deities such as Parshuram ji.

Mataji quotes Gurudev's revelations about his astral journeys: "No one will ever know where I go. But I watch over people and guide them."

She shares an anecdote of when Gurudev's friends, freshly initiated as disciples, inadvertently disturbed him during *paath*. Perturbed, he instructed them to seek Mataji's help to awaken him. "Sometimes, even a firm nudge would not stir him, perhaps because his spirit had travelled far across the cosmos, and his return was not instantaneous," she recalls. "He explained that re-entering the physical realm from his travels could take time, depending on the distance he had to cover to return, so patience was required."

Mataji learnt to navigate the complexities of bringing the mahaguru back from these ethereal journeys. Being married to a man who ventured beyond his physical form so regularly was no small task. She not only coped with these extraordinary aspects of their life but, over time, mastered the art of managing them with grace and efficacy.

Gurudev sometimes offered his disciples chances to accompany him on his astral voyages, though some unknowingly missed these opportunities.

Rajpal ji humorously details one such instance. He and other disciples—Sitaram Taki ji, Suresh Sharma ji, and RP Sharma ji—were deeply engrossed in conversation in Gurudev's home in Hariana. Following a late-night meal of *sarson da saag*,[1] they observed a sudden change in Gurudev. His hand fell, a spoon dropped with a clatter, and he showed no signs of life. In a panic, they began massaging his body with *ghee*, holding onto the hope that he might revive.

As stressful minutes ticked by, Sitaram ji recalled Gurudev's words about the time window between 2:15 am and 3:30 am, which the mahaguru described as the guru *paher*.[2] Respecting this, they waited in silence until the exact moment when Gurudev's watch would signal the end of this period. At 3:30 am sharp, Gurudev revived with the utterance of "OM" and left the room without a glance at his anxious disciples. He returned three hours later and gently chastised them: "What did you think—that your guru was dead? I have shown you all how to follow me. My legs were in your hands. If only you had pressed that point, you would have come with me."

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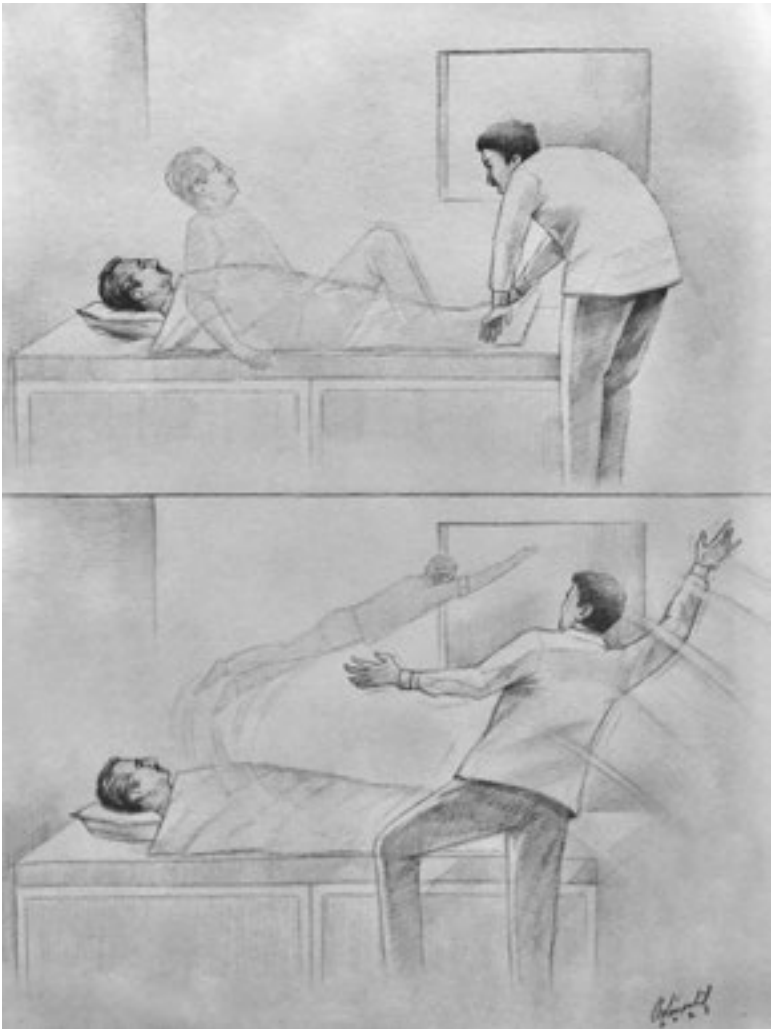
1 A traditional North Indian dish, primarily from the Punjab region, made from mustard greens (*sarson*) and spices

2 A specific time period between 2:15 am and 3:30 am that is considered especially conducive for spiritual practices, such as mantra recitation



Sitaram ji is stunned as he sees Gurudev's astral form leaving his body

Sitaram Taki ji was in for another shock when he accompanied Gurudev to Haridwar. Before beginning his *paath*, the mahaguru invited Sitaram ji to hold his legs and join him on an astral journey. As Gurudev entered a trance-like state, his ethereal double began to emerge from his body. Overwhelmed with fear at the sight, Sitaram ji inadvertently released his grip on Gurudev's legs and wet his pants. He remained frozen with fear till Gurudev's astral form returned and merged into his physical form, concluding this extraordinary experience.

My experience mirrored Sitaram ji's. Once, as Gurudev prepared for *paath* in Gurgaon, he beckoned me to hold his feet, promising a celestial tour of the planets. Yet, as he started to convulse, signalling the onset of his astral departure, my nerves betrayed me. I, too, let go, forfeiting the opportunity to journey the cosmos alongside the mahaguru.

Fortunately, some disciples did not falter. Surender Kaushal ji from Chicago was graced with a remarkable vision that bridged the divide between the astral and the astrological. "Gurudev took me on an astral journey through the Milky Way, where the planets were in such proximity that they were within reach," he recalls. "The highlight of this journey was when Gurudev made me touch the rings of the majestic Saturn!"

Santlal ji shares a remarkable tale of how, during a camp, the mahaguru empowered him and two of his gurubhais to leave their physical forms and embark on an astral journey back to their homes.

He recalls, "We locked our doors, lit a *dhoop*, lay down, and started doing our *paath*. We then travelled to our respective homes in spirit form. My task was to enter my home through the grills and perform *puja*,[1] strictly adhering to Gurudev's instructions not

1 A ritualistic form of worship practiced within Hinduism and some other South Asian religions, where devotees show reverence to one or more deities or to a spiritual entity

to interact with family members or drink water. I instinctively called out to my wife but then recalled Gurudev's words. Though I was curious about my children's well-being, I refrained from further contact, respecting his instructions.

"After our astral travels, Gurudev's grace skillfully guided Bakshi ji and me back to our physical forms. Without his divine intervention, how would we have known the way to exit and re-enter our bodies, particularly when encased by grills?"

However, the third astral voyager, Amichand ji, found himself adrift and did not return. Gurudev had to travel astrally to bring him back to his body.

The tales of Gurudev's astral voyages spark wonder and awe. If penned, the sheer volume and depth of these experiences would dwarf the expansive records of the *Encyclopaedia Britannica*.

Ravi Trehan ji's experiential testimony adds to this anthology: "I cannot assert it with absolute certainty, as I don't have complete proof, but the impression I received strongly suggested that I astrally travelled to Guru Lok[1] with Gurudev."

When asked about the experience, he elaborates, "In that state, I felt the presence of ancient mahagurus. Their appearances matched the ones we see in photographs—long-haired and bearded, dressed in traditional attire. It was like being in an assembly. I recall seeing beings such as Brahmrishi Vishwamitra and Guru Vashisth. It seemed as though all these esteemed sages were gathered there."

1 A spiritual realm or plane of existence in Hindu and Sikh traditions, believed to be inhabited by enlightened souls and spiritual masters, including mahagurus. It is considered a place of ultimate peace and divine wisdom, where souls reside in a state of bliss and are free from the cycle of birth and death

Ravi Trehan ji sees an assembly of mahagurus in Guru Lok

Not only could the mahaguru traverse the astral planes at will, but he also extended this extraordinary capability to his disciples, enabling them to experience realms beyond the physical.

These spiritual journeys revealed worlds unbound by earthly constraints. Yet, with the knowledge and experience came words of caution. He highlighted the risks associated with astral travel, cautioning against leaving the physical body unprotected. He explained that it could become vulnerable to takeover by powerful and malevolent entities.

Guddan ji shares the story of her mother's final days: "I was living with Gurudev and Mataji in Gurgaon for five months, away from my family in Kanpur where my mother was on her death bed. Gurudev had instructed me to live separately, the reasons for which he never disclosed, and I never dared to ask. He also advised me not to inquire about my mother's condition.

"Just a few days before her passing, I had an experience that is hard to define. Lying down, I saw myself flying to Kanpur to visit her. I

reached her but did not touch her, conscious of the need to return to Gurgaon within the time set by Gurudev. It felt so real. After my mother's demise, I lamented that I had not met her before she died. Gurudev surprised me by saying, 'Who told you that you did not meet your mother? You did visit her. I sent you'. He reminded me of the out-of-the-body voyage to meet her before her death."

Guddan ji's brother further substantiated this revelation. He recounts that their mother had sensed Guddan ji's presence and called her name, attesting to the credibility of her experience.

Gupta ji of Parwanoo witnessed an event that seemed to bend the laws of physics: "This incident unfolded in the Shilai region near Paonta Sahib in Himachal Pradesh. Gurudev had brought some *kheer*[1] and a box of *gulab jamuns*[2] from Gurgaon in the trunk of his car. He instructed us to distribute the sweetmeats to everyone present. Seeing the large crowd gathered, we were concerned that the *kheer* and *gulab jamuns* would not suffice for everyone. Yet, even after serving everyone generously, the supply of both sweetmeats never seemed to diminish. It was his *barkat* at work."

Pravesh Kapoor ji, who accompanied Gurudev on many trips across India, shares another intriguing tale of the mahaguru's mastery over the elements: "Once, the petrol in my car ran out completely. Gurudev looked at me and said, 'Son, open the petrol tank'. I did as he asked, and then he told me to close the lid."

"He then calmly instructed us to start the car," Parvesh ji continues. "We did, and to our amazement, the car started, and we drove on. We never stopped for petrol after that. We drove

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1 A traditional Indian dessert made by boiling milk, sugar, and rice, although it can also include other grains like wheat, millet, or vermicelli, depending on regional preferences

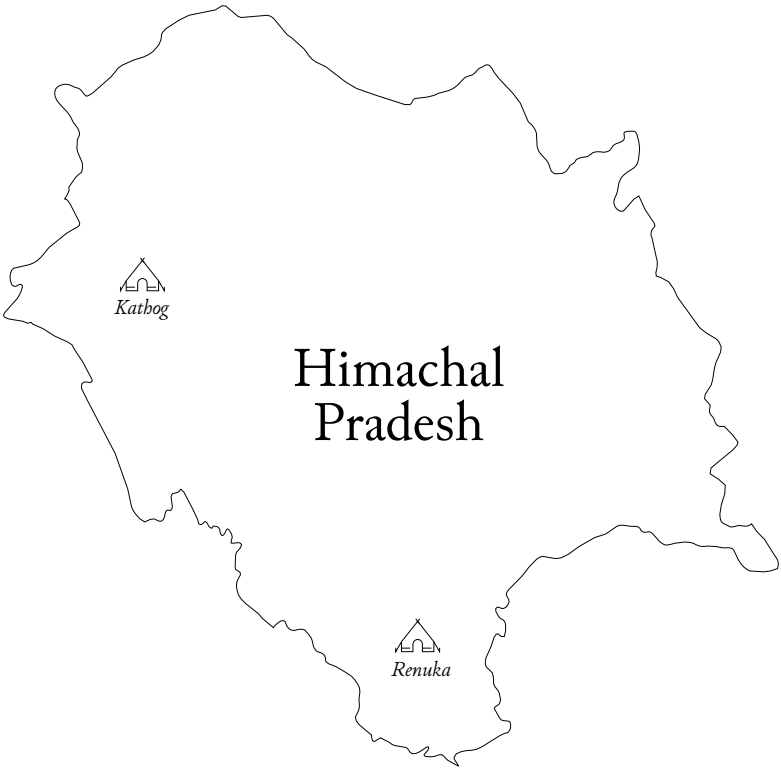
2 A popular dessert in South Asian cuisine, consisting of deep-fried dough balls made from milk solids, flour, and a leavening agent. These balls are then soaked in a sweet, fragrant syrup typically flavoured with rose water, cardamom, or saffron

back to Delhi, and only once we were there did we finally fill up the tank."

When asked how far they had travelled without any petrol, Parvesh ji replies, "At least 80 to 85 kilometres on an empty tank!"

Gurudev's connectivity to the highest realms of consciousness granted him extraordinary abilities to transform the nature of objects, alter the atomic structure of elements, and impact the smallest particles of the universe.

The narratives shared by the mahaguru's disciples and those fortunate enough to witness his extraordinary abilities transcend typical accounts of the miraculous. They emphasise the limitless potential that spiritual awareness can unlock.



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Chapter 13

Training Trails

In 1973, a routine soil survey camp in Guna, a small town in Madhya Pradesh, transformed into a remarkable scene of hope, faith, and healing. Initially just an observer, Nagpal ji found himself in the middle of an unexpected event as his colleague and friend revealed an extraordinary ability to heal large groups of people. He recalls, "The camp was flooded with people arriving in bullock carts, each carrying 15–20 individuals, all desperate to experience Gurudev's healing touch. The crowd was as diverse as their issues—some wrestling with personal turmoil while seemingly incurable physical conditions afflicted others. Gurudev tended to them all. Some of those who arrived struggling to walk found themselves able to return home with newfound strength in their steps!"

Nagpal ji was struck by the stark contrast between Gurudev's ordinary life and his extraordinary abilities as a spiritual healer. The events he witnessed compelled him to seek an explanation from the mahaguru regarding the nature of these healings. However, every attempt to unravel the enigma was met with Gurudev's hearty laughter, leaving Nagpal ji's curiosity piqued and the mystery unsolved.

Gurudev's healings in Guna at the age of 35 fulfilled the prophecy that he would become 'someone like Shiv' at that age.

A large crowd gathers at a remote cremation ground to meet Gurudev

During my time with Gurudev, his camps were like gateways to understanding how the physical and spiritual worlds intertwine. He embodied a deep commitment to guiding not only human beings but also wandering spirits. He sometimes chose sites close to cremation grounds or within dense forests—traditionally believed to be the haunts of such entities—for his camps. In search of solace and direction, these unseen beings found a guiding light in him. He was instrumental in either facilitating their rebirth or freeing them from their spiritual binds, playing a crucial role in their journey towards liberation.

Gaggu ji shares a particularly vivid memory from a camp near Bharatpur, Rajasthan: "Gurudev had chosen an unconventional location for his camp—right within a cremation ground, entrusting us with the duty of performing seva. Throughout the day, he attended to the needs of those seeking his assistance. In the evening, he summoned me, pointing towards the dense forest at the edge of the site. 'Do you see those flickering lights?' he asked. My gaze followed where a series of lights danced in the darkness, blinking on and off in a rhythmic pattern. Gurudev shared that these lights were the manifestations of the Syeds, entities without heads that communicated via these mysterious glowing signals. Despite the intrigue they presented, he counselled caution, explicitly advising against attempting to approach them."

Pravesh ji shares a story highlighting the mahaguru's enigmatic presence: "We went to a remote cremation ground with Gurudev. Considering how isolated it was, we were confused about why we were there and who would come to a place like that. Gurudev casually asked, 'Should I call a crowd?' I just said, 'As you think best'. Then, Gurudev meditated for thirty minutes. Amazingly, people started showing up looking for him. Soon, there were queues of people waiting for his help!"

Kathog in Himachal Pradesh bore witness to a pivotal chapter in the spiritual journey of Gurudev and his fledgling disciples from nearby regions. Here, a series of remarkable events unfolded at a soil survey camp in 1976, marking the inception of a transformative journey for those who crossed the mahaguru's path. Among the seekers who came there were Suresh Kohli ji, Santosh ji, and Shambhu ji.

Suresh Kohli ji, a school teacher who transferred to Kathog in March of the same year, recounts his first encounter with Gurudev. As he shares his story, he speaks of a local tantric named Thapa, who lived near the school. Thapa was the bearer of news about a man who had established camp across the school premises, bearing the sacred symbol of the OM on his hand and chest, along with a trishul. Suresh ji doubted Thapa's words, suspecting the claims were merely drunken ramblings. However, curiosity got the better of him, and he decided to visit the camp. There, at the gate, stood Gurudev—a man with a "commanding presence". Gurudev not only confirmed Thapa's assertions but also revealed the OM symbol embossed on his right hand.

Suresh ji recalls their conversation: "I asked Gurudev for a cure for tonsilitis and an opportunity to meet God. He advised me to meditate at night with my eyes open and a glass of water nearby. That night, I saw Gurudev's moving image in front of my almirah, which was filled with photographs of deities. I was stunned. I had just met him and had no prior devotion to him. Yet, there he was, appearing in my sacred space. I had so many questions!"

This extraordinary vision continued for seven nights. On the eighth night, however, the image did not appear. Suresh ji approached Gurudev the next day, asking, "What happened last night? I did not see you."

Gurudev replied, "If you see me that way again, you will have met God". Suresh ji remembers feeling excited, realising, "This is the God I was looking for. I have finally found him!"

Suresh Kohli ji sees a vision of Gurudev in front of his almirah

He elaborates on the impact of the mahaguru's presence on Kathog, noting, "Despite Kathog's small size, thousands and thousands flocked to meet Gurudev. The influx of people was so huge that we ran out of *kadas*, cloves, cardamoms, and peppercorns. Miracles were a common sight. However, our activities drew attention, and someone complained to the administration that the school was neglected because the teachers were busy doing seva.

"This led to an inspection by the deputy director of education, who was surprised to find no classes in session. When he confronted me, I introduced him to Gurudev. Gurudev helped him with some personal issues he faced. Afterwards, the deputy director reported that the school was functioning normally, and even he became a follower of Gurudev."

Santosh ji, a bodybuilder and physical education instructor from Nadaun—just 17 kilometres from Kathog—became captivated by the mahaguru almost instantly. "I met Gurudev in the summer of 1976 when my health was declining," he recalls. "In our first

meeting, he revealed the OM and trishul symbols on his hand. Three days later, he summoned me and said, 'Son, allow me to guide you on your path of evolution'. He then bestowed upon me a *kada* and mantra."

"A few weeks later, I visited the sthan at Shivpuri," he continues. "However, when I arrived, I found that Gurudev was not there. I entered the sthan room and lit a *dhoop*. It was then that I happened to glance at my hands. To my astonishment, I saw the symbol of the OM in my right hand, mirroring the one I had seen in Gurudev's hand. I also noticed the symbol of a trishul in my left hand. Though startled by the sight, I understood it was Gurudev's blessings manifesting."

Santosh ji shares a poignant episode involving Pradhan ji, a resident of Kathog who lived a few kilometres from the camp. In desperate need of transportation for his unwell brother, Pradhan ji approached Gurudev, hoping to borrow his jeep to reach PGI Hospital in Chandigarh. Gurudev inquired, "What if I could heal your brother right here?" Assuming Gurudev was joking, Pradhan ji retorted, "Why joke at a time like this?" To his astonishment, Gurudev offered Pradhan ji a glass of *jal*, executed a healing gesture on his stomach, and assured him of his brother's recovery. Returning home, Pradhan ji was greeted by his brother's markedly improved condition. This miraculous story echoed through the valleys, attracting more and more seekers to the mahaguru.

The residents of Kathog witnessed many extraordinary occurrences, including one that continues to astonish all who hear it. The event centres around an older man, bent with age and relying on two canes to support his frail form, who sought an audience with Gurudev. Despite his aged and frail appearance, Gurudev inquired, "*Baba*, what if I heal your back?" The elderly man, worn by the passage of time and perhaps sceptical of the

possibility of healing, replied matter-of-factly, "I'm too old to be healed". Unfazed by the response, Gurudev took a glass of *jal*, sprinkled a few drops on the older man, and gave him the remainder to drink. Then, he straightened the man's spine with a hand on his back and the other on his chest and asked him to take a few steps.

Initially, the older man was apprehensive, afraid of falling without the support of his canes. But Gurudev, with reassuring confidence, set the canes aside and assisted him in walking. Once the man had taken a few steps, Gurudev encouraged him further, saying, "*Baba*, take these canes on your shoulder and go home."

To the astonishment of those present, the man did what Gurudev instructed. He walked, carrying the canes on his shoulder, the stoop in his back noticeably diminished. The onlookers, including Santosh ji, were left amazed, looking at the transformed man as if they had seen a ghost.

Witnessing the wonders at Kathog with the innocence and curiosity of a child, Shambhu ji's eldest son, Pappu Pahadia, remembers, "My father was a teacher at the school next to Gurudev's camp. No one knew that Gurudev was a guru at the time. When we met him, we observed that his staff would call him 'Guruji'. We were all perplexed why this handsome, modern-looking man was being referred to as such. My father and a group of three to four teachers decided to investigate. Slowly, Gurudev began to perform miracles in Kathog. If someone came to him with a stomach problem, he would keep his hands on their stomach, and they would be healed. Seeing this, my father felt a strong bond with him, starting an important chapter of their spiritual relationship."

The healing wonders witnessed at Kathog led to faith blossoming and spiritual destinies unfolding. Shambhu ji, Suresh ji, and

Santosh ji found themselves converging on purpose. Entrusted by Gurudev with seva, they were armed with merely a glass of water he had sipped and a simple directive: touch where there is pain and trust in the unseen power of my guidance. Embracing their task amidst scepticism, they witnessed the miraculous—each person they touched was healed, a powerful testament to Gurudev's ability to make others the medium of his power.

In Himachal, aptly named *devobhoomi*,[1] the resonance of spirituality and the acceptance of miracles are as familiar as the breath of the wind. However, as devotion to Gurudev grew in Kathog and its neighbouring regions, it stirred undercurrents of tension within the confines of the mighty Jwalaji temple nearby, setting the stage for a story of spiritual recognition.

Raji ji recounts: "It is said that there was a pair of *khadaus*, belonging to a *siddh purush*,[2] kept in the basement of the Jwalaji temple. These *khadaus* were so powerful that only someone with immense spiritual strength could take even a single step in them. This became a way for the temple priests to differentiate an evolved spiritualist from a pretender.

"As Gurudev's reputation for miracles grew in Kathog, the priests at Jwalaji decided to put him to the test," he continues. "They led him to the basement, presented him with the *khadaus*, and asked him to walk in them. With his characteristic calmness, Gurudev put on the *khadaus* and not only took one step but three, unequivocally proving his spiritual stature."

1 Land of the Gods
2 A realised being who has transcended ordinary physical and mental boundaries through deep spiritual insight and mastery

Gurudev's spiritual powers are tested by priests at the Jwalaji temple

Gurudev embodied the essence of selfless service, ensuring that the focus remained on the mission and not the man. While he was unfolding miracles at Kathog, his family in Hariana remained blissfully unaware of his spiritual metamorphosis.

A conversation with a fellow student named Dilbaag, who hailed from Jwalaji, led to his sister's discovery of an 'Om Baba' performing miracles there. Upon Gurudev's return, his sister, fuelled by curiosity, inquired, "Who is this Om Baba who had visited Kathog?" Gurudev questioned how she came to know of him, to which she explained Dilbaag's revelations about a revered sage and the substantial crowd gathering to seek his help and blessings.

The veil lifted, and Gurudev confessed that he was indeed the 'Om Baba' to whom her friend had referred. This admission was a simple acknowledgement for him but a staggering surprise for his sister.

In 1979, the town of Renuka, nestled in the Simaur district of Himachal Pradesh, hosted Gurudev's largest mass healing camp.

Bittu ji recalls the early days spent there: "We established our camp on a piece of uncultivated land owned by Chandramani Vashisht ji. Within the camp's boundaries, we discovered a neglected Shivling. With Gurudev's approval, I restored, cleaned, and painted it. Every morning, as per his instructions, I would offer water and light a *dhoop* there."

Chandramani Vashisht ji has an interesting back story that Bittu ji shares: "Gurudev had left for Delhi on official business, and I was at the Renuka camp. Vashisht ji came to the Shivling to pray one morning. Afterwards, while drinking tea, he asked if 'Sharma ji' wore spectacles—he used to call Gurudev 'Sharma ji'—to which I replied that he did not. He left after hearing that. When Gurudev returned in the evening, I told him that Vashisht ji had come in the morning and asked that question. Gurudev burst out laughing but did not elaborate further. When Vashisht ji met Gurudev the following day, he inquired whether Gurudev wore spectacles. Gurudev replied, "No, I don't wear spectacles, but these boys have given me a pair of sunglasses I wear when I travel by jeep."

After about 15 minutes of conversation about spirituality, Gurudev said, 'Vashisht Saheb, I want to show you something.'"

When Gurudev showed the glowing OM symbol on his palm, Vashisht ji immediately knelt in deep respect. Vashisht ji then revealed that every time he meditated for 10 years, he saw a vision of someone who looked just like Gurudev, except for a pair of spectacles. Gurudev then shared, "Son, I was supposed to come here in 1969, but I only arrived in 1979," admitting to the decade of waiting that Vashisht ji had experienced. A few months after this encounter, in 1980, Gurudev established a sthan at Bayri in Renuka, appointing Vashisht ji as the sthan *sanchalak* and recognising Parshuram ji as its chief patron.

When Gurudev first arrived in Renuka, he instructed his disciples not to acknowledge him as their guru. He aimed to keep his identity hidden until he had established a significant spiritual alliance with Parshuram ji.

Many spiritual luminaries often test each other's spirituality before recognising each other formally. Bittu ji shares a story involving Renu ji, who was seriously ill in Gurgaon and wished to see her father, who was then in Renuka: "Mataji, along with Subbhash ji and Pal ji, brought her to Renuka to meet Gurudev. Upon their arrival, Gurudev was visibly displeased. Mataji explained, 'This wasn't solely my decision; your daughter, who is ill, wanted to see you.' Gurudev responded sternly, 'If it is her destiny to die, we must accept it.' He then immediately instructed them to return to Gurgaon."

As evening neared, Bittu courageously asked if they could spend the night at Bayri. Gurudev consented but imposed one condition: they had to leave before he woke up the following day. Later, Gurudev revealed that Parshuram ji was testing him to assess his emotional ties to his family. Gurudev demonstrated his detachment by meeting this challenge, earning Parshuram ji's approval. This event signified the beginning of a lasting partnership between him and the immortal one.

Gurudev utilised his camps to establish several spiritual alliances, not only with the venerable Parshuram ji and his mother, Renuka ji, but also with other *devi-devtas* and many other spiritual entities yet to be unveiled.

Let us turn back the clock to the events surrounding my first visit to Renuka. The graphic of an OM appeared whenever Vashisht ji poured water over the Shivling at the sthan. I, too, saw it while

visiting Bayri with a few others. But what my fellow travellers saw that I could not was an image of Gurudev on it. Feeling disappointed yet unwilling to accept something simply because others did, I left the scene in quiet disagreement.

We stopped for lunch a little later at the home of Karamchand ji, another disciple. We sat on the mud floor and were served lunch on leaf plates. I cleaned the floor before setting the plate down. When I picked up the plate after lunch, I saw a perfect graphic of the OM inlaid on the ground below it. Though I decided not to tell my host, I took it as a sign and ran back to the sthan to take another look at the Shivling. Vashisht ji had already left, so I jumped over the compound wall and asked the Shivling to show me what I had not seen before. What I saw next was nothing short of astonishing! Despite my complete disbelief, an outline of a face appeared instead of the OM and remained there. The Shivling did not need my faith to showcase its power, but this incident demonstrated how spiritually charged the place is.

After more than three decades, I recently guided groups of disciples and devotees to Renuka, inviting them to experience and honour the sacred energy of the place. Many witnessed the OM symbol appearing on the Shivling when incense was lit around it. It is also believed that Gurudev, along with some of his disciples, had meditated in the hills of Renuka in a previous life, and their past-life *samadhis* may be still present there.

Chapter 14

Master Of Moods

Gurudev had an extraordinary ability to rise above human emotions, a challenge that most of us grapple with.

FC Sharma ji talks about two eye-opening events. The first took place at a sthan in Himachal Pradesh. "While visiting Hamirpur, Gurudev decided to witness the seva at the sthan incognito. Transforming his appearance to that of an older man dressed in tattered clothes leaning on a walking stick, he joined the queue outside. When it was his turn, the sthan *sanchalak* dismissively told him to step aside and wait. Days later, after revealing his true identity, Gurudev confronted the sthan *sanchalak*, saying, 'You thought I was just an old man? It was me—your Guru! How can you perform seva properly if you judge people based solely on their appearance?' The sthan *sanchalak*, realising his error, humbly apologised for his misjudgment."

FC Sharma ji shares a profound insight, "Gurudev often said, 'If you serve a thousand but neglect even one, all your efforts amount to nothing'. In the practice of seva, there is no room for partiality. A guru must rise above personal feelings to serve everyone equally. Gurudev maintained that one swayed by emotions cannot make consistent and impartial decisions. In spirituality, emotions must not obscure the core objective of aiding those in need."

The second story dates to 1974, when Gurudev resided in Shivpuri. During that time, his ailing mother, who had difficulty

Gurudev asks his mother to join the queue alongside other visitors

walking, came to see him, hoping for some relief. But instead of attending to and treating her, he asked her to join the queue like everyone else. His message was clear: when her turn came, whichever disciple was on healing seva duty would treat her just like any other visitor to the sthan.

The lesson was unmistakable: one must prioritise spiritual duties over personal bonds. The mahaguru lived by this principle and expected his disciples to uphold it with the same fervour.

In the annals of Gurudev's legacy, tales of his unwavering emotional detachment are aplenty. Pappu ji reflects on the period following the death of Gurudev's younger brother, Chacha ji: "When Gurudev returned to Gurgaon, after concluding the final rites in Hariana, a visitor approached him with a box of *ladoos*,[1] a gesture often reserved for joyous occasions. Gurudev warmly

1 Round, sweet Indian confections made of gram flour, sugar, *ghee*, cardamoms and nuts

blessed the sweets and offered them to those nearby. Such grace amidst sorrow is not easy to achieve."

The mahaguru's level-headedness was not just for trying times; it extended into all his relationships. Puran ji, who spent over a decade in Gurudev's home and witnessed the intricacies of his daily life, offers a candid perspective on the mahaguru's relationship with his family. When asked about Gurudev's attachment to his kin, he states emphatically, "He was detached from everyone and everything". Given Puran ji's reputation for unfiltered honesty, his words carry the weight of authenticity.

Many find it challenging to differentiate parental feelings from the intricate weave of karmic bonds, but Gurudev did so with unparalleled clarity. He viewed his family as souls with whom he shared karmic connections from their past lives. While such rebirth narratives might overwhelm most with emotion or caution, Gurudev navigated them with a perfect balance of detachment and compassion.

Gurudev and Mataji shared an endearing and enduring bond. Despite his intense devotion to seva and its accompanying challenges, she stood steadfast as his life partner and spiritual companion. While she diligently managed her household and professional responsibilities as a teacher, their relationship was tinged with an ever-present sense of detachment, like a distant melody playing in the background.

Mataji remembers, "He was unwavering in his duties as a husband. Even with our children, he always ensured they felt his affection. On days when our home was crowded with disciples and followers, and the children craved his attention, he would gently remind them, 'People hug and show affection, but I would much rather spend time with you'. His parenting style was not conventional or demonstrative. His love was internal and deep-seated, not outwardly expressive."

In the eyes of the world, Gurudev was paradoxical. While he seemed to belong to everyone, he was bound to none. Every disciple felt a cherished bond, believing themselves to be his chosen one. The fact that an emotionally detached individual could foster such intense affection in countless people was a testament to his adeptness at role-play.

Unlike many, who reserve their deepest feelings for a select few, Gurudev's unemotional love had an expansive reach. He regarded himself as a part of all creation yet remained personally unattached. His distinct vibe, interpreted by many as love, embodied care, empathy, and connection while maintaining an undercurrent of detachment.

My chat with Raji ji, framed as a Q&A, dives into Gurudev's emotional makeup and his views on love.

Q: "Emotions are a significant handicap to spiritual progress. How do you feel about Gurudev's emotional quotient?"

Raji ji: "Gurudev may have shown emotions without feeling them or genuinely experienced them for some. But then, it raises the question: What differentiates love from other emotions?"

Q: "Love, to me, would be caring and feeling for another, being part of another person's being without being emotional. That love is limitless. To quote Shakespeare, 'Love is not love which alters it when alteration finds or bends with the remover to remove'. This type of love is simply infatuation or attraction. Like *moh*."[1]

Raji ji: "*Moh* is different. Attachment requires a deeper sense of emotion. I believe that love naturally flowed from Gurudev."

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1 Refers to emotional attachment in various Indian philosophical contexts. It is often considered a form of delusion or ignorance that binds the soul to the material world, hindering spiritual growth and liberation

Q: "Are you talking about emotional love or genuine, all-encompassing love?"

Raji ji: "Genuine, caring, universal love. It was palpable. Gurudev's body language, every pore on his body, communicated love."

Q: "Did you notice any other emotions in him, like anger?"

Raji ji: "Never anger. But he would say, '*Putt, gussa na rakhien, par phoonkar na chaddi*'. He meant one must maintain an appearance of being angry to deter others from taking advantage, but internally, one must not let the anger consume them."

Q: "Did you ever see him get attached to someone? When I saw his interaction with you, I thought he was attached to you. But I can sense now that it was more of fondness."

Raji ji: "Yes, it was fondness."

Numerous stories about Gurudev offer a glimpse into his complex character, but understanding his true nature requires hearing from those who know him well. Pappu ji and Nikku ji provide such a perspective. Despite their youth, they had the unique opportunity to observe Gurudev's daily life closely. Their memories and insights are an important link to his world, offering us a window into his teachings and way of life.

Nikku ji explains, "Gurudev had a remarkable ability to make everyone feel valued and important. People around him felt seen and loved, a rare quality not many possess, even towards their own children."

Pappu ji nods in agreement: "He treated everyone as an extension of his family. No one was left out; everyone was embraced."

When recounting his days under Gurudev's protective wings, Pappu Pahadia ji paints a vivid tableau of relationships: "While we looked up to him as our guru, the ways he showed love were diverse—it could be the gentle affection of a grandparent, the protective love of a parent, or the closeness of a friend. He got my teenage quirks and connected with me in ways that resonated deeply. As I matured, he evolved his approach, guiding me like a wise friend. It was not until 1982, after years of absorbing his teachings, that I genuinely understood the meaning of a 'guru'."

Gurudev's mastery over his emotions, in this life, was not achieved overnight or through some magical elixir. It was the fruit of relentless effort and introspection.

Taming his temper, just as it was with many revered saints before him, was a challenge. Yet, the latter part of his spiritual journey bore testimony to the significant strides he made, building upon the invaluable lessons from his earlier years.

Mataji, providing insight, explains an unconventional yet impactful exercise he deployed for anger management: "If someone provoked him, he chose not to rise to the bait. He had trained himself to subdue those angry impulses. Occasionally, he would deliberately use harsh language towards someone. He would respond with laughter when they responded angrily. Much of his effort to temper his anger and remain unruffled when provoked was practised at his workplace."

When I sought advice on overcoming sorrow, the mahaguru imparted a remarkable insight, "*Agar dukh par kaaboo paana hai, toh pehle sukh par kaaboo paana seekho* (If you want to conquer sorrow, first learn to conquer joy)". Years later, reflecting on this wisdom, I coined a term that encapsulates the essence of his *ek vakhya*—happylessness.

Commonly, happiness is associated with joy, yet this form of happiness is temporary and inherently carries the risk of leading to sorrow. Imagine happiness as a seesaw: pleasure sits on one end, and sorrow on the other. Bliss, however, signifies the centre balance point, a state of equilibrium where emotions are in balance and harmony prevails. This condition can be described as 'happylessness', surpassing the dualistic nature of happiness and sadness.

Many of Gurudev's devotees came from modest backgrounds, hailing from various villages and towns, each with unique professional and social experiences. Often, they would enthusiastically volunteer to serve at the events held at the sthan. Yet, like all humans, even the most well-intentioned among them faltered. And when they did, especially if it meant treating visitors at the sthan with anything less than utmost respect, Gurudev took notice. He had little tolerance for any neglect or arrogance shown towards guests. As a result, many *sevadaars* faced his gentle correction, which led them to be more cautious and considerate in their duties.

FC Sharma ji notes, "Gurudev's emotional outbursts were rare and reserved primarily for when someone erred during seva. Otherwise, he was a picture of calm. And if he did have to reprimand, he would always do it discreetly, away from the public eye."

I once confessed to FC Sharma ji that Gurudev often corrected me publicly, to which he responded, "There was always a purpose behind it. Perhaps he wanted to help you overcome certain karmic hurdles. He never acted out of emotions. He was detached from worldly gains and losses."

While Gurudev might have grappled with anger in his earlier years, arrogance never found room in his character.

He was aware of the pitfalls of ego and recognised how sentiments of 'Me, mine, and ours' have historically hindered seva, *bhakti*, and *gyan*. Over four decades, I have observed that disciples rooted in humility often surpass those who boast seniority, experience, or knowledge. Humility fosters self-acceptance and elevates one's sense of self-worth. It reminds us of our connection to the broader mosaic of life, prompting us to look inward and acknowledge our spiritual core beyond the limitations of the material world.

Gurudev's heightened awareness gave him a panoramic view of the past, present, and future. It was not just clairvoyance but a deep, interconnected bond with everyone and everything. His ability to foresee future events, particularly tragic ones, without the freedom to issue direct warnings, must have been deeply stifling, requiring an inner strength beyond comprehension.

While he had the unique capability to sense thoughts from afar, he often chose to veil this skill. But sometimes, traces of this knowledge would inadvertently emerge. He played a delicate balancing act, being omniscient on one hand and feigning ignorance on the other.

I remember a time he advised me against a scooter ride to Delhi. Only later did I understand that he had anticipated a potential accident. Thankfully, the accident that unfolded was less severe than what might have been.

Yet, this knowingness was not without its merits. With the capability to glimpse into the lives of disciples and followers, he could discern their spiritual trajectories. This innate understanding positioned him as an incomparable guide,

allowing him to pre-emptively counter his emotional responses. His acceptance and anticipation of unfolding events neutralised any emotional fluctuations. Nonetheless, this did not diminish his capacity for empathy in the roles he took on. Gurudev, ever mindful of the challenges he faced on his own spiritual journey, showed deep compassion for our struggles. Aware of our shortcomings, he patiently supported our growth, continually guiding and helping us to self-realisation.

Dr Shankarnarayan ji recounts an insightful experience: "One day, while leaving for work, I wished to pay my respects to Gurudev. At the time, Gurudev was in *paath*. After waiting a bit, I sought Mataji's permission to pay my respects at his feet before leaving. She agreed, and I left soon after. As I crossed a vast open field near their home en route to the bus stop, I heard children, including Gurudev's son, rushing towards me. They shouted, 'Doctor Uncle, Gurudev is calling you. Return immediately.'"

When Shankarnarayan ji returned, Gurudev said, "Your touch drew me back from an astral meeting. Had I not called you back, you might have been in an accident or killed on the way because the *ganns*[1] at the astral meeting were furious with you for the unexpected disruption."

When Shankarnarayan ji touched Gurudev's feet while the mahaguru was in *paath*, it instantly connected Gurudev's physical form and his astral form, which was then participating in an astral meeting with the *ganns*. This unexpected connection prompted the mahaguru to quickly return to his body, interrupting the astral meeting. The *ganns*, disturbed by this disruption, turned their anger towards Shankarnarayan ji. Nonetheless, Gurudev intervened just in time to protect him.

1 Attendants of Shiv

This experience is a reminder that even celestial beings, like the *ganns,* are not immune to anger. While not excusing the flaw, this realisation offers a beacon of hope. It shows that with unwavering dedication and persistent effort, we can make significant strides in managing, if not fully mastering, such emotions.

Chapter 15

Timeless Tuning

Many individuals move through life in a state of distraction, their attention scattered among various thoughts, desires, and emotions. This preoccupation often leads to a lack of mindfulness, causing them to miss their immediate environment's subtle energies and dynamics. On physical, spiritual, and mental planes, they remain absent-minded, failing to harness the potential of conscious living.

In stark contrast, Gurudev exemplified heightened alertness; his awareness spanned multiple dimensions of existence. He was like a cosmic commando, fully engaged and responsive to the intricate dynamics of the universe. His consciousness was not confined to the present; it spanned time, granting him insight into the past and foresight into the future. With this deep understanding of people, destiny, and events, his awareness was a double-edged sword. He bore the weight of precognition, including its darkest revelations, and shouldered the responsibility of shielding his devotees, offering them guidance and protection from the storms of misfortune.

Bittu ji recounts a remarkable instance of Gurudev's timeless tuning: "Mr Sud and his wife, who came from Mumbai with their ailing son, were staying at the sthan in Gurgaon. They were planning to head to Delhi one evening, and I asked Mrs Sud if they could drop me off at Sector 14, where I lived. However, Gurudev advised, 'No, wait a bit. Don't leave just yet.'

"As soon as the Suds left, Gurudev handed me his scooter keys and instructed me to follow them. I was only a few minutes behind their car when, near Sector 14, their vehicle—driven by their chauffeur Natwar—crashed into a parked truck and slid beneath it. It was around midnight. I quickly called for help, and with my brother's assistance, we pulled them out and rushed them to the hospital for first aid. Later that night, they were all safely brought back to the sthan."

Bittu ji was unaware of a crucial aspect of this incident, which I witnessed first-hand. Gurudev initially declined when the Sud family sought his permission to make a weekend trip to Delhi. The family then suggested sending their driver alone, but the mahaguru firmly refused, stating they must all travel together. He later revealed the reason behind his insistence: had the driver travelled alone, he would have perished in the crash.

Gurudev had foreseen the peril that night; his decision to send the group together was deliberate, ensuring that the driver, who would have faced certain death alone, survived with minor injuries amidst the group.

The mahaguru frequently addressed the inevitability of fate, once stating, "*Vidhi ke vidhaan ko koi badal nahi sakta, par main samay ka pabandh nahin, samay mera pabandh hai* (No one can alter the laws of destiny, but I am not bound by time; time is bound by me)". His reflections illuminate the dual aspects of his role as a guru: actively working to reduce mishaps' impact while simultaneously recognising destiny's unyielding nature.

At the tender age of eight, Bindu Lalwani had her first encounter with Gurudev outside his office in Connaught Place. "My parents nudged me to receive his blessings," she recalls. "It seemed like a simple gesture at the time, yet its impact lingered. Those brief moments spent with him remain etched in my memory. His

presence felt like that of a doting and approachable grandfather with whom conversations flowed effortlessly. We felt closer to him than we did to our parents. With Gurudev, our hearts bore no secrets, and he always seemed to possess an uncanny awareness of all that transpired in our lives."

Her father, Rajpal ji, recalls a memorable car ride with the mahaguru: "We were descending a mountain, and Gurudev was behind the wheel. To my surprise, he shifted the car into neutral. I remarked, 'Gurudev, we are going down a mountain. You should put the car in gear. If we drive the car in neutral while driving in the mountains, we can only rely on the brakes to stop the car. Isn't that risky?'" Gurudev replied with calm assurance, "Son, I would know if an accident is going to happen, wouldn't I?"

Rajpal ji explains the reason behind Gurudev's unconventional driving preference: "As a government employee, Gurudev was assigned a designated driver. When I asked him why he preferred driving in neutral, he replied, 'My son, the driver assigned by my office, gains from this method. Driving in gear increases fuel consumption. By switching to neutral, we save on fuel and cut costs. Additionally, the driver's salary is calculated on mileage, so this technique boosts his earnings during our extensive trips that last several months.'"

In the early 1970s, FC Sharma ji, who lived in Shahdara, had a habit of cycling to work every day, regardless of the weather. One day, Gurudev proposed, "Maybe you should think about taking the bus instead". However, FC Sharma ji was attached to his routine and responded, "I truly enjoy cycling and don't find it uncomfortable at all."

One morning, at his Shivpuri home, amidst his daily shaving routine, Gurudev suddenly slashed his left thigh with his razor, staining his trousers with blood. When questioned about this

startling act, he calmly revealed, "Sharma ji was fated to have a serious accident while cycling to work today, which would have severely injured his left thigh. I absorbed the impact to spare him from the pain and suffering."

Ashok Bhalla ji illuminates Gurudev's attunement to his disciples' journeys with another anecdote: "Gurudev initiated Malhotra ji's spiritual training by assigning him nightly tasks, which Malhotra ji reported would take about two and a half hours to complete. The next day, Malhotra ji would report to Gurudev in detail after completing these tasks. If Malhotra ji ever omitted any part of his experience, Gurudev would instantly detect the omission, precisely identifying the missing elements!"

Virender ji recounts a surreal experience from the late 1980s. This event unfolded when he was alone in Rohtak while his wife was in America. He begins, "One night, after my prayers, I noticed a peculiar glow on the room's bed-facing wall as I was settling down. The light intensified, gradually revealing an image of Lord Shankar, perfectly motionless, just as depicted in iconography."

The extraordinary incident took an even more remarkable turn when the stony apparition opened its eyes. Virender ji notes, "Lord Shankar's eyes looked intently at me, and slowly, the image faded away. I sat there, shocked, before eventually convincing myself to disregard the vision and rest."

A month passed, and during a visit to the Khandsa farm, Gurudev asked a question that pierced through Virender ji's silence: "Virender, weren't you frightened when he opened his eyes?" The accuracy of Gurudev's knowledge left Virender ji astonished, as he had confided in no one about the experience. He could not help but ask, "Was it you, Gurudev?" In response, Gurudev maintained silence, merely taking Virender ji's hand as they continued their walk.

Gurudev, endowed with an awareness that spanned time, once pledged to overturn a visa denial from the American Embassy.

Rajpal ji recalls the sequence that unfolded with the mahaguru's intervention. "Gurudev was preparing for a trip to North America and inquired about my visa status. Upon learning I didn't have one, he advised me to apply". Despite Rajpal ji's efforts, his application was rejected.

It seemed the matter was closed, yet Gurudev had other plans. A short time later, he directed Rajpal ji to revisit the embassy, assuring him the visa would be granted.

"At the embassy, the same official who had denied my application on my earlier visit rudely questioned my return," Rajpal ji recounts. However, this time, Rajpal ji found himself speaking with a newfound authority, challenging the denial, and questioning the insult to his integrity. This prompted the intervention of another officer, who, after a brief exchange with the official, facilitated a change in the decision. "How long will your stay be?" the official asked, to which Rajpal ji responded, "Three to four weeks." The embassy official promptly issued a four-week visa.

Reflecting on the situation, Rajpal ji states, "Gurudev confidently sent me to the embassy that morning, assuring me I would obtain the visa as if he had already granted it to me himself."

Trains and tickets set the stage for another showcase of Gurudev's uncanny foresight and razor-sharp awareness. He always seemed to be a hundred miles ahead, even when it came to the comings and goings of locomotives and the complexities of ticketing.

"I heard Gurudev was bound for Mumbai," Rajpal ji shares. "Curious, I asked him about it. He invited me to accompany him. When I questioned the availability of an extra Rajdhani train ticket, Gurudev calmly assured me, 'We'll get one at the station.'"

Rajpal ji was sceptical, knowing the intricacies of booking a ticket, and he voiced his concern: "But, Gurudev, you can't just get Rajdhani tickets at the station; they need to be booked at the railway office at Connaught Place". Gurudev's response was calm. "Don't worry about it," he said.

As they arrived at the station, Gurudev's quick stride through a collapsible gate left Rajpal ji momentarily stranded outside. Doubt crept in as he followed Gurudev onto the platform, the train's imminent departure fuelling his anxiety. "I don't have a ticket; how can I go to Mumbai?" he thought. Then, a tap on the shoulder snapped him back to reality. Rajpal ji turned to find a man inquiring, "Do you need a ticket to go to Mumbai?" His affirmative reply led the stranger to ask for 200 rupees and his name. "He pulled out a ticket, jotted down my name and seat number, then handed it to me."

With the ticket in hand, Rajpal ji dashed towards the train, barely catching it as it rolled away.

My encounter with Gurudev's omniscience unfolded at Bina station in Madhya Pradesh under circumstances that were as bewildering as they were illuminating. Gurudev's directive was straightforward yet puzzling: "Go buy two tickets for first-class travel". My confusion peaked when the ticket clerk announced that our intended train lacked a first-class compartment. After I returned with second-class tickets, Gurudev firmly urged me to go back to the counter and follow his initial instructions. Complying, I obtained two first-class tickets, leaving the clerk bemused. Yet, Gurudev seemed satisfied with the outcome.

The train pulled into the station a few minutes later. There, against all expectations, was a single first-class coach, an anomaly

for a service typically composed of second-class carriages only. Gurudev and I were the sole occupants of this luxurious and vacant first-class compartment, only later learning it had been added a few stops before, specifically for its journey to Delhi.

It was a moment of realisation, echoing the timeless words of Lord Tennyson: 'Theirs is not to make reply, theirs is not to reason why, theirs is but to do and die'. Chastising myself for doubting Gurudev, I understood the folly of questioning a mahaguru's vision with my limited perception. With his gaze set firmly on the unseen horizon, Gurudev had once again demonstrated the extent of his extraordinary vision.

"I learnt swiftly that deception was futile with Gurudev; he seemed attuned to the nuances of our lives," Nitin Gadekar ji remarks. He recounts a particular incident from the early 1980s, "After a heated exchange with my wife Urvashi in Mumbai, I boarded a train to Delhi. Upon reaching Gurgaon, Gurudev confronted me with unsettling precision, 'Have you lost your senses? Why would you raise your voice at my daughter?'"

He shares another telling episode: Gurudev specifically warned him to refrain from accepting meals without contributing to their cost, a principle that he unintentionally violated. He clarifies the situation, saying, "Due to an argument with my uncle the previous night, I felt compelled to eat at my cousin's home, aiming to maintain harmony". At his next meeting with Gurudev, he was immediately confronted with the question, "Why did you eat there when I had specifically advised against it?"

Gurudev's abilities mystically outpaced the technological advancements of his time, a truth that bewildered his followers. Long before the advent of artificial intelligence, he demonstrated

a knack for revealing truths in a manner that seemed to employ a form of advanced, enigmatic technology.

On one occasion, when a disciple fabricated a story about his whereabouts, Gurudev revealed a sealed audio cassette. To everyone's astonishment, when the tape was played, it contained the exact conversation the disciple had falsely denied. The idea of a divine recording device capable of imprinting audio onto an unopened tape was, and remains, far beyond the capabilities of any known technology.

Surender Taneja ji's deep bond with the mahaguru impacted everyone familiar with him. From our first encounter, the depth of Surender ji's spiritual presence was immediately apparent.

His wife, Shobha ji, recounts her husband's journey towards faith: "Gurudev and Mataji were regular visitors at our home due to my brother-in-law's devotion. One day, Gurudev instructed my mother-in-law, saying, 'Bring your son, Surender, to me,' but Surender ji was reluctant. Then, one day, Gurudev arrived and had a private conversation with my husband, discussing something only he knew of". This conversation marked a critical juncture for Surender ji, who admitted, "Gurudev's knowledge of my most private thoughts, which I had confided to no one, left me in awe. Then, I fully accepted him as my guru, laying my trust at his feet."

From that day forward, Surender ji's faith was unshakeable. He abandoned the grave mission he had once contemplated and embraced the mission of seva.

Baljeet ji, a key figure of the sthan, was chosen to oversee the construction of Gurudev's *samadhi* in Najafgarh. For the last

three decades, he has faithfully visited this hallowed spot every morning at the crack of dawn.

He recounts the remarkable way Gurudev determined the exact location of his future *samadhi*, meticulously ensuring it was crafted exactly as he envisioned. He shares, "Gurudev led me to an undistinguished parcel of land devoid of any markings. Amidst the chaos of a nearby pipe factory, he stepped onto one plot and declared, 'The sthan will be built here'. We marked that spot with a brick and commenced formal demarcation the following day. And then we realised that the plot's boundary matched where Gurudev had set his foot—a mere foot away, and the sthan would fall in the adjacent property!"

Gurudev's words to Baljeet ji were poignant and prophetic: "Construct the *fakir's* humble dwelling here; commence the brickwork immediately because time is fleeting". Baljeet ji interpreted this urgency as a push to complete the structure before Shivratri, not realising the full implication of what the mahaguru meant.

The initial phase of construction moved rapidly with the completion of two rooms within just 15 days. Following Gurudev's subsequent directives, four more walls were constructed. Gurudev's vision also encompassed the land's cultivation; he advised planting chari seeds, commonly used as cattle fodder. Remarkably, these seeds grew into plants reaching six feet tall in only a month.

At the time, Baljeet ji did not realise they were constructing what would become Gurudev's final resting place. Reflecting on Gurudev's directions, he recalls, "He placed his hand on my shoulder and guided me to the area where we kept the cows, instructing me to construct a platform there. I assumed he intended it as a spot to meet with his followers."

It was only after Gurudev's passing, as they built the *samadhi* on that very location, that Baljeet ji realised that the platform was not for earthly meetings but for Gurudev's eternal communion.

Baljeet ji narrates another incident related to the construction of the *samadhi*. He shares, "I was transporting tiles to the site at Najafgarh, accompanied by labourers who were to fix the tiles. Around 3 pm, our journey took an unexpected turn when my car collided with a rickshaw."

Though the labourers escaped unharmed, they quickly fled the scene, but the rickshaw puller sustained injuries. Baljeet ji acted swiftly: "I immediately took him for first-aid, had his leg bandaged, and gave him 400 rupees to help cover his medical expenses and compensate for the days he would need to rest."

When he arrived at the construction site, Gurudev confronted him with a surprising question: "How much money did you give to the rickshaw puller?"

Baljeet ji was taken aback by Gurudev's uncanny awareness of the incident and answered, "400 rupees". Gurudev then inquired, "Why so much, when you had already provided medical care?"

"I thought about how he might not be able to work for a few days, and the money could assist with his daily needs and additional medical costs," Baljeet ji explained. He also confessed his uncertainty about who was at fault for the accident.

Gurudev approached Baljeet ji, patted him on the back, and said, "*Tainu te main deyanga* (I will bless you with abundance)." His blessings indeed brought immense prosperity to Baljeet ji's life.

Reflecting on the lessons from that day, Baljeet ji shares, "Gurudev once explained to me, 'If you help a blind man cross the road, it

is noted by me. If you offer water to someone who is thirsty, it is acknowledged. If you feed a hungry person, that too is recorded.' His awareness of our actions was uncanny."

Most of the mahaguru's disciples have interacted with invisible forces. These might represent the divine guidance of spiritual saints sent to offer protection and support, or they could be a manifestation of our own spiritually advanced selves. There is another aspect to these encounters—sometimes, the energies we encounter are not benign.

I recall visiting a renowned church in Venice, a trip my wife was particularly keen on. An invisible force pushed me as I walked upon a raised platform, seemingly secure and elevated above the lower level. In that fleeting moment, something miraculous occurred—a protective energy cradled me, redirecting my fall so that I landed on my left shoulder, absolutely unscathed. This episode was a stark reminder of the importance of being constantly vigilant. Had I been in heightened awareness, I could have sensed the aggressive energy and mitigated its impact, transforming a potential confrontation into a mere encounter.

Nitin ji recounts a startling incident involving a woman who visited Veer Sethi ji's sthan in Mumbai. She exhibited signs of what appeared to be spirit possession, her behaviour teetering on the edge of madness. "She was usually disruptive while waiting her turn, but I had managed to soothe her in the past," he says. "However, on this day, her agitation escalated to outright hostility. The situation intensified when Punchoo entered the sthan."

The details blur, but the woman's fury became focused, and in a sudden surge, she lunged to strike Nitin ji and Punchoo ji. Yet, in a twist, defying explanation, an invisible but potent force

intervened, seizing, and retracting her raised hand. "It was a spectacle to behold," Nitin ji marvels. "The very air seemed to repel her assault! I am certain that a benevolent force was at play."

Gajendra Kadam ji shares a story from the Lonavala sthan, echoing an event similar to the one Nitin ji experienced. He narrates, "I vividly recall a day when Mataji was sitting on the *gaddi*, and a man walked into the sthan room. Immediately upon entering, he started imitating a snake, moving sinuously and lifting his arms to resemble a snake's hood. Mataji watched him calmly. Suddenly, he fixed his eyes on her, and he threateningly declared, 'I will bite you'. Instinctively, we stepped forward to protect her, but she gestured for us to stop. What happened next was astonishing. Each time the man made a hooded pose and seemed to lunge at her, he stumbled back. Despite repeated attempts, he could not move forward."

In reflecting on my past misadventures, I admit to a time when a rogue spiritualist instructed me on how to magnetise power from others. It is not a chapter of my life I look back on with pride, but I share this with you in the spirit of full disclosure and to illustrate an important lesson.

During a visit by KC Kapoor ji, a distinguished IPS officer, to Gurudev, I attempted to covertly draw power from his feet. I was mid-process when a palpable force intervened, jolting me back and nearly toppling me. The rebuke from the unseen was unmistakable.

Then, there was the time at Renuka in the early 1980s when my misguided attempt to extract energy from a temple summoned the wrath of the legendary Parshuram ji. I was hit with invisible forces, and only after requesting *Devi* Renuka for help did I find respite. She manifested within my mind's eye, her ethereal touch halting the onslaught.

My misguided attempt to draw energy from a temple has unexpected repercussions

Upon my return, Gurudev revealed his awareness of my error without waiting for my confession. He simply stated, "What you did was wrong and it irritated Parshuram ji". This experience was a lesson in the consequences of spiritual transgressions and the importance of seeking a virtuous path.

Pappu Pahadia ji vividly remembers an incident from his childhood. "Get ready," Gurudev said one day, "We're going to visit Sanglon-wale Baba."

Their journey was exciting; the children sprinted and played in front while Gurudev and the adults, including Pappu ji's parents, followed behind. Suddenly, their path was blocked by a giant snake coiled on a bridge, creating fear among the children. Hurrying back to the adults, they shared what they had seen.

Gurudev approached the snake with extraordinary calmness and said, "Your long vigil is over, and I am here to grant you release". The snake paid his respects almost reverently, bowing its hood,

and peacefully slithered away after sharing a meaningful look with those gathered.

Gurudev later revealed that the snake was Sanglon-wale Baba, a *mahatma*[1] who had been meditating in the form of a snake in the wild for over 150 years, awaiting liberation. The encounter with the mahaguru marked the end of his earthly journey.

In a captivating narrative, Shobha Taneja ji shares a tale of a yogi's rebirth and subsequent transformation into a businessman. She recalls, "Gurudev was camped in Bathri at a guesthouse of the Himachal Electricity Board while we were staying in a guesthouse in Dalhousie. We often travelled by van to visit him, as he did not permit us to stay in Bathri. On one such visit, while en route, I drifted off to sleep and had a dream. In it, an older man, leaning on a cane, appeared before me, voicing his wish to be born into my family. I resisted, pointing to the fact that my children were already grown. Yet, he persisted, arguing that his rebirth in my household was vital, and assured me that he would fulfil our needs before his birth.

"Despite his assurances, I remained unconvinced. When we arrived at the Gurudev's camp, I chose not to share my dream. Nonetheless, Gurudev asked me to stay the night and directed me to light the *jyot* at the sthan the next morning. Having done so, I made my way back home."

Shobha ji's subsequent discovery of being pregnant led her to Gurudev in Gurgaon. "Did you meet an older man in your dream?" he asked. Upon her affirmation, Gurudev said, "He is determined to join your household; you must welcome the child". Shobha ji's worries about societal judgment given her grown children were alleviated by Gurudev's assurance that her

1 A Sanskrit term meaning 'great soul'

pregnancy would go unnoticed. Indeed, as Shobha ji confirms, "No one could tell I was expecting."

Unknown to Shobha ji, the watchman of the guesthouse where Gurudev was camped was often visited by the yogi in dreams. He was intimidated by these spectral appearances and would heed the yogi's commands. He recounted eerie incidents where officers of the Electricity Board, having overindulged in alcohol, experienced nocturnal attacks by this unseen entity, leaving them gasping for air. These occurrences were frequent enough that the guesthouse gained notoriety for being haunted, leading many to seek refuge in a village guesthouse instead.

The watchman once confided that the yogi had been awaiting Gurudev's arrival for a century, yearning to be reborn into a home steeped in spirituality. This revelation arrived as I eavesdropped on Surender ji and Shobha ji's conversation one morning. Filled with curiosity, I later sought answers from Gurudev himself. He confirmed what was to unfold with a knowing air: he intended to facilitate the yogi's rebirth through Shobha ji. And so, some months later, Shobha ji and Surender ji's son, Abhay, was born on the day following Shivratri.

Gurudev operated on multiple planes of consciousness, possessing the remarkable ability to perceive the continuum of time and wield forces beyond the understanding of ordinary humans. To beings of higher evolution, what we deem supernatural is merely routine—a distinction of capability rather than a divergence of nature. It is not scepticism but faith that might serve us better, inspiring the belief that if one individual can transcend such limitations, then perhaps so can we all.

A file photo of Gurudev at the sthan in Gurgaon

Chapter 16

In His Shoes

The image that most held of Gurudev was shaped by stories exchanged in hushed tones and reverent whispers. When devotees approached him, they brought their problems and a plethora of spiritual expectations. They sought his aid in healing and transforming their circumstances by tapping into the reservoir of his spiritual powers—powers he had painstakingly cultivated not just over the years but lifetimes.

In the early stages of his journey as a healer, the ailments of those he healed often left a residual mark on his aura. He would find himself grappling with the very negativity he sought to alleviate from others. Moreover, brief encounters at public events posed another challenge: remembering the sea of faces that sought his guidance. Most times, he could not meet many devotees since they would frequent the sthans he established outside Gurgaon. To connect with them, he either relied on the insights of his disciples or embarked on astral journeys.

At the peak, Gurudev interacted with lakhs of people monthly. There were instances where he catered to nearly 50,000 individuals in a space as tiny as 600 square feet. The management of such large gatherings was a challenge due to organisational limitations. Furthermore, he had to navigate the complex interplay of forces, both benevolent and malevolent. On numerous occasions, he had to tactfully engage with other powers. The roadblocks came in many forms, from spirit attacks and black magic to disgruntled spiritual masters.

Acting as a spiritual advocate for those in need, he negotiated with their *aatma* and the planetary energies influencing them. He sometimes required them to exercise patience and visit his sthans multiple times to tip the scales in their favour, knowing that this effort served as *tapasya*.[1]

Countless beings placed their faith in the mahaguru, hoping he would answer their prayers. Though expressing these expectations in words is simple, the weight of such responsibility was enormous. In addition to his spiritual duties, Gurudev led an ordinary, middle-class life. He held a regular job, attended camps for half the year, and maintained a close bond with his family while appearing to lead an average life.

Those who recognised Gurudev's spiritual powers felt a deep connection with him. Being in his position is a unique privilege, yet I often wonder how challenging it must have been. Nitin Gadekar ji observes, "Gurudev's life exemplified his relentless commitment to seva. Catering to the varied and sometimes unreasonable demands of individuals required unparalleled patience. Some even approached him with trivial requests like choosing a television! Yet, he remained composed and attentive to everyone's needs." He continues with a smile, "His regular job was perhaps a respite, offering a break from these overwhelming spiritual responsibilities."

Gurudev's boundless generosity was evident in all aspects of his life. Despite his modest earnings, he gave freely, even when he knew that not all requests were genuine.

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1 The practice of deep meditation, self-discipline, and austerity pursued to achieve spiritual power and enlightenment. It is often linked to the notion of sacrifice, where practitioners endure hardships or give up worldly pleasures for the sake of spiritual gains

In the early years, his close companions, Dwarkanath ji and Nagpal ji, witnessed his selflessness first-hand. As his spiritual family grew, Gurudev generously supported and fed his disciples. He viewed seva as the highest form of goodwill, never a transaction or exchange, and therefore never accepted anything for himself. While he occasionally allowed his disciples to contribute towards seva, his family took on the responsibility of covering the personal expenses of many disciples who made his home their abode.

Gurudev's financial approach might seem imprudent to some, as he often spent more than he earned. Yet, somehow, he always managed to make ends meet. Mataji expresses her admiration for her husband's generosity: "He never hesitated to help those in need. Whether it was a small or large amount, he gave willingly and without reservation."

Gurudev viewed money not as a possession to be owned, but as a tool for improving the lives of others. He treated his wife's earnings with respect, and at work, he was open-handed with his salary. Even though it seemed unlikely they could afford to support a family and the activities of a sthan given their limited resources, they still found a way to get by. Even when faced with financial constraints, the mahaguru never faltered. His unwavering integrity ensured that he always found a way.

Mataji was adept at managing their finances with utmost caution and discernment. She bore the brunt of financial tightness with grace and wit. Gurudev's limitless generosity frequently led him to come home with an empty wallet on payday. Consequently, it was crucial to ensure that a portion of his monthly salary reached her, enabling her to manage the household expenses. His disciples recognised this dynamic and decided to streamline the process. They ensured a part of Gurudev's salary went directly to Mataji, allowing her to manage the house while he continued his philanthropic endeavours.

When Gurudev first settled in Shivpuri, he was neighbours with Naubatram ji. Reminiscing about those times, Naubatram ji shares, "Gurudev resided in a small, rented place. Despite the steady stream of visitors, he radiated warmth and contentment. Though money was scarce, his unwavering faith and cheerful demeanour never betrayed it. He was always in good humour."

Watching Gurudev, I learnt that humour can be a powerful shield against despair and self-doubt. Drawing inspiration from his attitude, I advise you to embrace laughter and positivity. He who smiles and laughs stands taller.

Most spiritualists are intensely tested and tempted by money. Some succumb and luxuriate, while some withhold and frugalise. Even a man of such power as Gurudev was put to the test in terms of grit and integrity.

Before becoming a mahaguru, his journey was riddled with many challenges. Pehelwanji recounts a poignant conversation with Gurudev, reflecting on the mahaguru's struggles and resilience: "Gurudev confided in me about the depths of his hardships. He shared, 'Son, there were times when my clothes were so torn, I had to sew the ripped edges together with 20 stitches'. Gurudev would meticulously sew up each hole. Once, he took his daughters to the market. Ila ji was in his arms while Renu ji clutched his finger. Renu ji spotted a sweet shop and longed for milk. After she drank two glasses, they returned home. That is when he asked Mataji, 'Doesn't she get milk at home?' Mataji's response was honest and matter-of-fact, 'How can I give them milk when we barely have enough to run our household?'"

Pehelwanji continues, "That night, he was so troubled that he could not sleep. He wrestled with the decision of whether to continue

on his spiritual path. After restless hours in thought, he resolved to walk the spiritual path regardless of his circumstances."

Though puzzling to many, Gurudev's choice to refuse monetary offerings and donations earned him deep respect. His story is a remarkable example of human grit and persistence through obstacles that could quickly derail one's chosen path. Each hurdle he faced in this journey was daunting, appearing nearly insurmountable. Surrounded by a unique circle of ethereal mentors, allies, deities, and watchful ordinary individuals, he navigated his path with remarkable resilience.

Initially, he began his seva in a humble manner, much like a wandering saint, offering seva in people's homes and at the tea and juice stall beneath his office. As time progressed, he ingeniously merged his seva with his professional life, doing seva wherever his work led him.

Gurudev's mission to foster faith added obstacles because he dressed and spoke like an ordinary person. Convincing others to trust someone who looked no different from anyone else in the crowd was inherently challenging. Nevertheless, after just a few interactions, many were captivated by his authenticity and were drawn towards him. His way of life and the palpable energy of his aura swayed their beliefs and led them to become his devotees.

Nikku ji shares an interesting observation: "Whether Gurudev went to bed at 2 am or 3 am, he was always up by 5 am. Typically, he would head out for work around 7.30 or 8 am, reaching his office by 9 or 9.30 am. Each morning, people would gather outside his home, eagerly awaiting a glimpse of him. To make it to his office on time, he would sometimes slip out by jumping over the back wall instead of using the main gate."

Eventually, a sliding door was installed at the back of the house to make his exit more convenient. "Gurudev would request that the

scooter be parked behind the house," Nikku ji adds. "He would then leave discreetly, ensuring he was punctual for work. If only a handful of people were outside, he would offer his blessings before proceeding. His office routine involved typical work tasks and meetings. He would return home anywhere between 2 pm to 4 pm. Sometimes, he would visit the Khandsa farm, taking pleasure in milking the cows and enjoying the serene environment. Despite his early mornings, Gurudev never slept before the wee hours of the next morning. He often met people or had spiritual discussions with his disciples well past midnight."

Vishwamitra ji, hailing from Mukerian, Punjab, is a man of few words. His perspective on the challenges faced by Gurudev is brief yet significant: "Gurudev was attentive to an endless stream of individuals, addressing and handling a wide range of concerns and remembering each person, even if they had crossed paths only once. His memory was impeccable. The tasks he undertook were Herculean. His days were filled with tireless dedication, and nights were often short-lived."

The mahaguru led a life of unconventional hours, yet his life is a testament to how he made every minute count.

"We confided in Gurudev about every aspect of our lives, from our happiest moments to our deepest regrets," Bittu ji recalls. "Even in his physical absence, we felt a connection. We would stand before the sthan, pouring our hearts out, and even though he was not there, we knew he was listening. He never shared our confessions with anyone. He could absorb so much."

Imagine carrying the weight of countless confidences and never letting one slip. Gurudev's ability to maintain the confidence of numerous souls seeking his guidance was commendable. His third eye could see future events in their lives and these were secrets they never knew but he did. Despite his deep-seated knowledge, exercising restraint and choosing not to reveal these

Gurudev points to a Devi's image and says, "Main aes tarah di sau banaiyaan"

insights was undoubtedly challenging. His actions were discreet, often so subtle that one hand was unaware of the other's doings. Yet, people watched him constantly, searching for a sign, a hint of his inauthenticity. Living under such scrutiny is challenging, but for Gurudev, it was his chosen path.

Throughout my decade-long association with Gurudev, his humility consistently stood out. He never flaunted his extraordinary abilities or sought to impress anyone with his profound knowledge.

When he assumed the role of mahaguru, his statements often left us astonished, yet for him, they were mere statements of fact. Once, when asked why he didn't pay respects to the female deity at Jwalaji, he replied matter-of-factly, "Why would one bow to one's own Shakti?" On another occasion, he pointed to a picture of a female deity on the wall and casually remarked in Punjabi, "*Main aes tarah di sau banaiyaan* (I have created hundreds of such deities)."

His remarks often left me grappling for comprehension. Yet, my unwavering faith in him always convinced me of the veracity of his words.

Dealing with a sea of followers was challenging, but managing the close-knit circle of disciples proved even more demanding. Gurudev gracefully embraced the role of a patient mentor, catering to his spiritual family's multiple needs and desires. Bindu ji concurs, "He was always available and accessible to all."

Years alongside Gurudev have left me in awe of his remarkable life, which seems almost surreal and undoubtedly challenging to mirror. A cornerstone of his mission was the elevation and mentorship of his disciples, especially those with heightened spiritual potential. This task was made complex by the fact that many disciples, such as Santlal ji, Choudhary Saheb, Krishanmohan ji, Captain Sharma, Uddhav ji, myself, and several others, were mavericks with little spiritual inclination at first. We jokingly referred to ourselves as members of the 'Monster's Club'. Even esteemed disciples like Malhotra ji and Bade Jain Saheb were not exempt from this characterisation. While Jesus might have been a carpenter in the literal sense, Gurudev was, metaphorically speaking. He meticulously reshaped, refined, and transformed us.

His mission extended to preparing us to guide the next generation, ensuring the perpetuation of his teachings. In the process, we often encroached upon his personal and family time.

In hindsight, I regret monopolising his time, not realising the strain it may have caused him. His magnetic presence stirred a fervour in us, making him the centre of our collective admiration. While most devote themselves to serving their guru, we inadvertently burdened him with overwhelming affection. Gratefully, Mataji was a beacon of support and patience. She

faced her own set of challenges, sharing her husband not just with his vast following, but also with the animals and spirits he cared for!

One can compare Gurudev's adaptability to a chameleon, shifting hues rapidly. People approached him bearing a myriad of emotions. When their prayers bore fruit, they would exude joy; yet, in trying times, they sought solace in sharing their sorrows with him. For Gurudev, seamlessly transitioning between these emotional extremes was a requisite, as challenging as it might have been.

Another facet of his duty stemmed from heightened expectations. Many, having heard stories of swift relief bestowed upon others, anticipated similar expediency for themselves. Yet, Gurudev, in his wisdom, often took a more measured approach, beckoning them to the sthan multiple times, facilitating healing at its natural pace. He employed various methods, such as leveraging their faith and patience, when negotiating with advanced deities on their behalf.

A journalist by profession, Uma Prabhu ji's insights are rooted in realism. She observes, "The path Gurudev walked was incredibly challenging. He was like a boundless ocean, effortlessly soaking up negativity. I cannot pretend to understand his viewpoint, but I suspect the journey would be incredibly challenging for me if I were in his position."

The weight of listening to the tribulations of countless beings, neutralising negative forces, and guiding numerous individuals on their spiritual odyssey underscores the truth in Uma ji's observation.

Scaling mountain peaks is a formidable challenge, demanding immense stamina. Each step reflects the climber's unyielding determination and resilience. Upon conquering the summit, the climber joins the ranks of an elite few who have triumphed over the same colossal heights. Though fraught with trials, this journey culminates in a sense of achievement: the recognition that every obstacle overcome was a necessary sacrifice for the majestic reward that lay in wait.

Those privileged to have known Gurudev concur that relentless trials marked his existence. Yet, despite facing daunting adversities, his legacy shines as a source of inspiration to many.

Chapter 17

Shiv

One of the most misunderstood concepts in Indian philosophy is 'Shiv'. Shiv is often humanised and envisioned as a physical entity residing in places such as Mount Kailash, Amarnath, or Kedarnath. However, this widely recognised depiction corresponds to Shankar, who embodies a form in which Shiv consciousness is fully realised. Fundamentally, Shiv signifies a collection of qualities, attributes, and capabilities that emerge at the pinnacle of spiritual consciousness. Individuals in whom these traits manifest are considered embodiments of Shiv, transcending the limitations of a mere physical form.

Guru Vashisht explains that Shiv is the infrastructure for the play of Shakti, where Shakti is the dynamic force driving creation. Shiv is a potent, static, formless energy that permeates everything but remains unnoticed by many. While everyone holds the potential to uncover this divine essence within themselves, only a select few achieve this realisation.

Accessing and connecting with Shiv consciousness demands profound spiritual development and awareness. To reach this state of being, one must elevate one's *kundalini*[1] beyond the Ajna chakra, located at the third eye on the forehead. Advancing the *kundalini* past this point allows individuals to tap into subtler levels of consciousness, a journey open to anyone, regardless of his or her religious beliefs.

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1 Represents the energy that lies coiled at the base of one's spine. Yogic *asanas*, breathing techniques, meditation, seva, and adopting evolved attitudes and practices awaken the *kundalini* and channel it upward through the seven chakras. When channelled, this energy unblocks each chakra and allows the practitioner to experience deeper levels of realisation

The mahaguru's entire being was a storehouse of spiritual energies, showcasing his ability to harness these powers for the greater good. These energies took physical form as visible, embossed symbols all over his body.

His hands bore raised imprints of sacred icons like the OM, trishul, Shivling, Gileri, Ganpati, Nandi, and a radiant *jyot*. The OM symbol was prominently displayed on both his chest and back. Additionally, other symbols adorned his feet and even his fingernails. Each symbol was not just a mark but represented the unique powers he wielded for seva. He was, in essence, a living, breathing Shivalay.

I first saw the OM in Gurudev's hands in 1977, though I did not fully understand its significance at the time. As my spiritual journey deepened, I explored its meaning further and was astounded by what I discovered. The OM is more than a symbol; it acts as a divine certification, lifting those marked by it into the realm of the divine.

Soon after, Gurudev bestowed the OM and other symbols upon my hands, silently indicating his intention for me to share them further. Since then, I have shared these symbols with many people, hoping to transform their lives meaningfully.

It is essential to recognise that these symbols appear within the aura and subtly influence the recipient subconsciously. Unlike Gurudev, who had perfected the art of interpreting and utilising these symbols, many individuals are still in the process of becoming fully aware of and effectively applying the capabilities these symbols embody.

The meaning of OM

Gurudev imparted his insights into the OM's significance to many, including Raji Sharma ji.

Raji ji recalls a particular day when Gurudev said, "Grab a paper and pencil. Let me explain the meaning of the OM and its connection to the Mahaguru mantra."

Gurudev placed the pencil on a point, saying, "This origin point represents Brahma". Drawing the upper curve of the OM, he continued, "As the upper curve begins to form, Brahma's influence wanes, and Vishnu takes over". This curve, he noted, "symbolises *utpatti*[1] and mirrors the foetal position of a child in the womb."

Next, the mahaguru drew a second, elongated curve and said, "This represents Devo Maheshwara". He pointed to the juncture where both curves meet in the middle and drew a line extending outward, which he referred to as the *sund*[2] of Ganesh. "The line that extends from these semi-circles represents Ganesh, who embodies

1 Refers to creation in Sanskrit. It signifies the process of coming into existence. In a metaphysical context, *utpatti* often represents the creative force or energy that brings forth life, aligning with the role of Vishnu, who is traditionally regarded as the preserver and sustainer in Hindu cosmology

2 Refers to the trunk of Lord Ganesh. The trunk symbolises adaptability, efficiency, and intelligence, reflecting Ganesh's ability to overcome obstacles and his role as the remover of barriers

gyan," he elaborated. "It also symbolises the guru, who leads one out of delusion and ignorance towards enlightenment. Thus, the Mahaguru mantra begins with '*Guru Brahma*', followed by '*Guru Vishnu*', and then '*Guru Devo Maheshwara*', before culminating in '*Guru Sakshat Par Brahm*'.[1] The guru—the *par brahm*—can take you out of the *Brahmand*,[2] beyond the limitations of the three realms, transcending the cycle of life and death."

Raji ji further explains, "Gurudev then explained the symbolism of the *chaand* or crescent moon, which he said represents the Ajna chakra, located just above the eyebrows in the human body. Between the *sund* and the crescent lies a stretch of darkness. The guru guides one through this darkness toward the divine light symbolised by the crescent's soft, bluish glow. This is the same crescent which also adorns Lord Shankar's head.

"After this, one must traverse another stretch of darkness—a journey made possible only through unwavering faith, devotion, and complete belief in the guru. It is like leaping backwards into the unknown. This journey leads one to the ultimate destination where the light of the realised self resides in its divine brilliance, in its glorious *Vareniyam Bharga*."[3]

Gurudev suggested visualising the OM in people and surroundings to strengthen one's connection with all forms of consciousness. This visualisation would help them overcome their physical limitations and expand their awareness.

Over time, I understood the importance of this practice—by envisioning the OM outside of ourselves, its powerful energy became even more pronounced within. Furthermore, I have

1 Translates to 'The Guru is the direct manifestation of the Supreme consciousness'
2 Refers to the cosmos in Hindu cosmology and encompasses all of creation, including the celestial bodies and various planes of existence
3 Refers to the divine and radiant light of the self which is worthy of respect

realised that when blessed with the power of the OM, it can manifest in places other than our hands.

Pooja Seth ji shares, "Upon receiving the OM from Guruji (Gurudev's disciple), I started noticing the OM symbol everywhere—on walls, in my food, on the ground. It happened effortlessly. Even now, whenever I light the *jyot* in my home temple, the flame often takes the shape of an OM."

At sthans, the OM frequently manifests in everyday objects. One such instance occurred in Gurgaon during Guru Purnima in 2007. Bittu ji discovered an OM etched in the first tomato he cut while preparing the *langar*. He recalls, "The OM within the tomato was gleaming. I shared this find with Mataji, Malhotra ji, and others present at the time. Since we could not preserve the tomato, we diced it and distributed it as *prasad*."

I witnessed a similar phenomenon on the eve of Mahashivrati in Gurgaon in the late 1980s. A group of *sevadaars* were slicing potatoes for the *prasad* that was to be served to people breaking their fasts at midnight when they initiated a knife-down strike. In the centre of each potato, they discovered a naturally imprinted trishul. They refused to continue, believing it was sacrilegious to cut through the symbol. When Gurudev heard about this, he sprinkled *jal* over the sacks of potatoes, and remarkably, the imprinted trishuls disappeared. This allowed the preparation of potato chips to resume, much to everyone's relief.

The OM symbol is deeply intertwined with the spiritual grace of the sthan.

FC Sharma ji shares, "Gurudev frequently used the OM as a tool for healing. When encountering someone gravely unwell, he would show them the OM and assure them that by the next morning, they would see this sacred symbol in their hands. Such interventions often led to miraculous recoveries."

Kapil Mahtani ji adds to the anthology of grace: "During my wife's pregnancy with our first child, she was deeply anxious about the delivery process and expressed her fears to Guruji (Gurudev's disciple). In response, Guruji revealed the OM symbol on his hand and reassured her as she approached her delivery date. Remarkably, throughout the labour, my wife saw the same OM symbol that Guruji had shown her glowing on the wall of the delivery room! She interpreted this as a sign of Guruji's spiritual presence during the birth of our child."

Many disciples and devotees have reported seeing sacred symbols in their dreams, often accompanied by profound and transformative realisations.

Gautam Bhushan ji provides a fascinating example: "In a dream, I saw a symbol that combined an OM with a Swastik.[1] Initially, I dismissed it as a figment of my imagination. However, the symbol reappeared in my dream the next day. My scepticism persisted until an astonishing moment in Dehradun when the same symbol manifested on Guruji's (Gurudev's disciple) forehead right before my eyes!"

While the OM represents divinity, the trishul empowers one to wield Shakti or dynamic cosmic energy. Shakti enhances the capabilities of the body's left side and enables individuals to manage, attract, and channel power beyond their own requirements. This surplus energy can be used to positively impact other life forms, particularly in healing practices.

Gurudev had the symbol of the trishul on his hands and back. Santlal ji recalls seeing silver trishuls shining on the mahaguru's

1 Refers to an ancient symbol in Hinduism, Buddhism, and Jainism, typically depicted as a cross with arms of equal length, each bent at a right angle. It is frequently used in religious rituals and ceremonies to invoke blessings, symbolise auspiciousness, and attract good fortune

fingernails. Before Gurudev acquired the trishul, he and his disciples would internalise some of the negativity and ailments of those they were trying to heal. However, when he finally acquired this power symbol, he shared its essence with his disciples, saying, "You no longer need to absorb negativity; now, you possess Shakti to deal with it effectively."

"One day, a distinct shiny white circle appeared on Gurudev's palm, from which five tridents radiated outward," Dr Shankarnarayan ji recalls. "These included four large tridents and a smaller one, arranging themselves into a circular pattern."

While Shankarnarayan ji identified these symbols on Gurudev's hands as tridents, Mataji and Gurudev's neighbour, Uma Shankar ji, interpreted them as a *Sudarshan chakra*.[1]

Interpreting these manifestations was a complex challenge for many of Gurudev's disciples and devotees, especially those without religious backgrounds. Gurudev offered no detailed explanations, perhaps to let each unravel the meaning over time.

Reflecting on these symbols, my mind formulates some intriguing hypotheses. The symbols appeared permanently etched on Gurudev's palms; however, when members of the Sikh community visited, he would display the *Ek Onkar*[2] symbol rather than the OM, suggesting a selective revelation based on the audience.

I only ever saw the OM, which appeared deeply embossed and raised, indicative of a permanent and unchangeable mark.

1 A spinning, disc-like weapon used by Lord Vishnu. It is said to have immense destructive power and is depicted as a sharp-edged discus that can cut through anything
2 Translating to 'One Supreme Reality', this phrase is a central tenet in Sikhism, symbolising the fundamental belief in the oneness of God

Geeta Nagpal ji shares her vision of Nandi's horns: "When I first started visiting the sthan, I began having visions, and Guruji (Gurudev's disciple) asked me to paint them. I would paint and show him the results, and he would interpret them for me."

Geeta ji experienced a recurring vision of a curly illuminated form, yet she initially resisted painting it due to its perceived lack of significance. However, as the vision continued to appear for about a week, she decided to paint it precisely as she visualised it. "I felt inclined towards specific colours during the drawing process, which I incorporated into the sketch," she explains. "Upon presenting the final painting to Guruji, he explained that I had painted Nandi's horns. The next year, when I met Gurudev, he showed me the various symbols on his hands," she reveals, "and to my astonishment, one of them was the same symbol of Nandi that I had seen in my vision!"

Ravi ji shares insights detailing the significance of symbols in the hands of Gurudev and other advanced spiritual practitioners: "Gurudev told me that if I did a lot of seva, a Shivling would appear on my hand. I worked hard in my spiritual practices and saw the Shivling appear on my hand after Mahashivratri. This motivated me even more.

"Gurudev then told me that if I increased my seva, the OM would appear on my hand. I followed these instructions, and the OM symbol appeared, deepening my faith in the connection between spiritual advancement and the emergence of these sacred icons."

Later, Gurudev advised Ravi ji to follow a specific routine of *paath*. He predicted that by the following Mahashivratri, a trishul would appear on Ravi ji's hand, and it did.

Ravi ji asserts, "These symbols represent different levels of spiritual growth achieved through dedicated practice."

The symbols in Gurudev's hands

Gurudev would tailor his techniques, inspiring and motivating individuals according to their unique needs and abilities. With adept skill, he employed practical demonstrations to ignite the passion of those like Ravi ji, who could be easily motivated. However, for individuals like me, Santosh ji of Nadaun, Gupta ji from Parwanoo and his family, and Captain Sharma of Mumbai, who were less ambitious, it was an automatic transmission.

The mahaguru's extraordinary skill of transferring power symbols at will is an ability that many find both astonishing and complex to grasp. He extended this distinctive capability to his disciples, empowering them to emulate this impressive feat.

FC Sharma ji vividly recalls one of the methods Gurudev used for transferring these power symbols: "Gurudev would show the OM in his hand to an individual, promising that the same symbol would appear on their hand the next day. And it invariably did!"

In certain instances, this power transfer occurred instantaneously. During a memorable meeting, Gurudev summoned Gupta ji of Parwanoo and his family, and declared, "I have bestowed the OM upon each of you". To their surprise, the OM symbol materialised on everyone's hands, leaving them awestruck.

The mahaguru imparted these symbols so subtly that we only became aware of the gifts we had received as he led us to uncover and realise their presence within us.

Gurudev's transfer of his divine powers was contingent upon his discernment of a disciple's worthiness. After he departed from the earthly realm, some disciples initially hesitated about passing on these powers and sacred symbols. Yet, upon deep contemplation, many disciples chose successors, ensuring the continuation of these remarkable abilities for future generations. This act of succession honours Gurudev's legacy and secures the ongoing journey of spiritual enlightenment and seva.

Chapter 18

Spiritual Oversight

Steering disciples entangled in worldly desires toward self-realisation was a significant undertaking for Gurudev. It required his relentless commitment and the disciple's steadfast faith. While the mahaguru, with his acute insight, had already discerned the disciple's potential and pitfalls, he still posed tests, not as an assessment for his knowledge, but as a mirror for the disciple to introspect and self-reflect.

Gurudev's spiritual presence was so formidable that it could unnerve men of steel. Yet, his intention was always to uplift and inspire. He did not merely want his disciples to reach his spiritual level but to surpass it. This explains his boundless patience and unyielding dedication to guiding them.

His tests were so subtle that we were often unaware that we were being evaluated. One day, I observed how he assessed Rajpal ji at his Curzon Road office. As we sat, a guest arrived, and Gurudev said, "Take Rajpal's car. Use it and return it later". After the guest left, Gurudev, with a twinkle in his eye, confided, "I had previously told Rajpal not to lend his car. Now, after instructing someone to use it, let us observe his reaction."

I was eager to see how Rajpal ji would fare. He entered Gurudev's office and promptly placed the car keys on the table, stating, "Gurudev, here are the keys". When he exited the room, Gurudev

Gurudev punishes Rajpal ji, then provides healing

remarked with a hearty laugh, "Shrewd fellow. He has managed to pass the test". By entrusting Gurudev with the car keys and allowing him to determine their rightful recipient, Rajpal ji neither disregarded the mahaguru's instructions nor faltered in upholding his words.

Another time, Gurudev's unique teaching methods again placed Rajpal ji in the thick of things. Ravi Trehan ji shares: "It was Bada Guruvar at the Gurgaon sthan, and disciples were busy in seva. Gurudev had devised a system allowing disciples to rest for 30 minutes after a few hours of seva. During one such break, Rajpal ji, a few others, and I sat on the staircase. Aware of Rajpal ji's fondness for singing, I urged him to sing a *ghazal.*[1] He obliged, but after completing seva, Gurudev summoned him and sternly asked, 'Seva was ongoing downstairs while you sang above. With people coming here for solace, what impression might they have formed?' Strangely, after that, Rajpal ji noticed a distinct change in the clarity and timbre of his voice, as if some of his vocal cords had been tempered."

Ravi ji continues, sharing the twist in the tale, "After several months, Rajpal ji accompanied Gurudev to a camp in the mountains. He implored Gurudev to heal him. Gurudev's prescription was the most unexpected—'Eat the snow from the ground on which you stand, and you'll find your voice'. Rajpal ji complied without hesitation, and his voice was restored."

Surrendering to the wisdom of a *siddh* guru is essential. Even if their demeanour often reflects gentle calm and benevolence, their ability to seamlessly navigate from the worldly to the ethereal realm testifies to their spiritual depth, vast understanding, and transformative influence.

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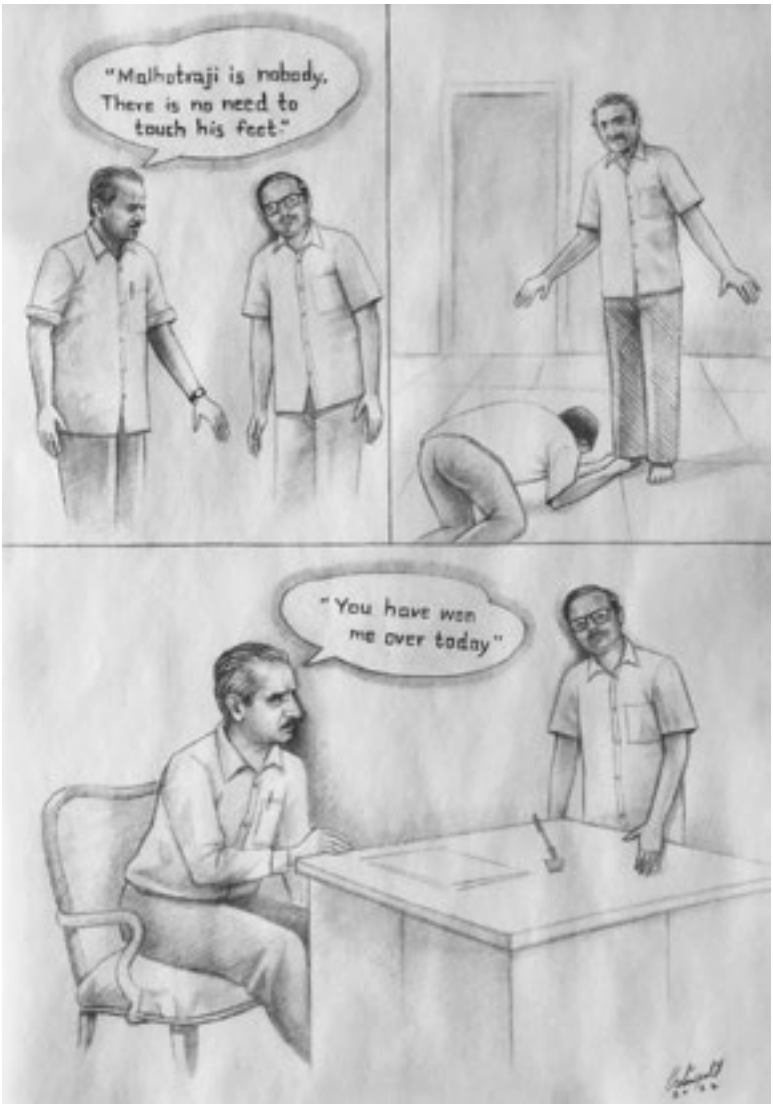
1 A form of poetic expression, characterised by rhyming couplets and a refrain, each line sharing the same metre



Gurudev tests Shankarnarayan ji's humility and sincerity

In their initial journey, many disciples wrestled with grasping the complexities of disciplehood, resulting in occasional lapses. Suresh Kohli ji shares a moving story from those early days: "I remember an episode with Shambhu ji, who was battling cancer. One afternoon, Gurudev decided to cure him. Both Shambhu ji and Nagpal ji were present. Gurudev blessed *jal* and offered it to Shambhu ji, urging him to drink it. However, Shambhu ji hesitated, believing he saw worms in the glass. Despite Gurudev's reassurances of the water's purity, Shambhu ji declined and did not drink the *jal*."

Recognising the fragile nature of human faith, Gurudev remarked that perhaps Shambhu ji's destiny was not to be healed that day. He then offered the water to Nagpal ji, who drank it trustingly without a second thought.

For Shambhu ji, yielding to momentary doubts instead of maintaining steadfast faith had catastrophic consequences; it ultimately cost him an extension of life.

Dr Shankarnarayan ji shares an incident involving RC Malhotra ji, a junior technical assistant in his office: "I held Malhotra ji in high esteem". This respect was challenged when Gurudev instructed him to obtain a mantra from Malhotra ji. However, shortly afterwards, the mahaguru remarked, "Malhotra is a nobody; there is no need to touch his feet". Such conflicting guidance left Shankarnarayan ji in an ethical dilemma.

The next day, in an unforeseen turn of events, Malhotra ji visited Shankarnarayan ji's home. Without much thought, Shankarnarayan ji, guided by instinct, respectfully touched Malhotra ji's feet. As he later reflected on his gesture, a realisation struck him: he had acted contrary to Gurudev's advice. He became anxious about the mahaguru's possible reaction. Yet, when they met at the office, Gurudev greeted him with an approving smile.

"Today, you've won me over", he remarked. At that moment, Shankarnarayan ji understood that Gurudev had tested his humility and sincerity—a test he had fortunately passed.

Gurudev had a unique way of guiding his disciples. He often employed what appeared as contradictions in his teachings, challenging the perceptions and convictions of those he mentored. These apparent paradoxes were not whimsical but intricately crafted to see who could pierce through the surface and grasp the underlying essence. He observed the depth of their spiritual understanding by occasionally endorsing their superficial tendencies. While many stumbled on this path, it gave Gurudev valuable insights, allowing him to fine-tune his guidance. Despite these hurdles, his unwavering commitment to his disciples' spiritual development underscored his relentless pursuit of their advancement.

Disciplehood is a complex journey. Interacting with a *siddh* guru's subconscious power demands tact and experience. Due to the guru's approachable demeanour, there is a risk of losing sight of formal boundaries, leading to guru *avhelna*.

Bade Jain Saheb learnt this lesson the hard way. He was influenced by an energy that appeared before him as a manifestation of Shiv. This overwhelming experience disrupted his mental balance, leading him to challenge Gurudev. This caused him to go insane and publicly fall from grace. Tragically, this event also marked the plateau of his spiritual journey. Although Gurudev extended his compassion and forgiveness, the incident cast a shadow over Bade Jain Saheb's reputation. Some disciples even harboured lingering resentment, resulting in diminished respect.

Bittu ji offers an account of this turn of events. "Once revered, Bade Jain Saheb sadly became the subject of ridicule. Some younger disciples even resorted to mocking his appearance and

belittling him openly". I was dismayed by the disrespect directed towards Bade Jain Saheb and turned to Gurudev for insight. His perspective was enlightening—those who insulted Jain Saheb were unknowingly racking up their karmic debt, thereby aiding Jain Saheb in clearing his own karmic slate!

Guru *avhelna* is more than just upsetting or going against the guru. It combines disrespect, lying, and other wrongs. Though they may seem harsh, the consequences help correct and prevent these mistakes from recurring. Viewed in this light, such punishment becomes an indirect blessing from the guru—a sentiment I have come to understand, having experienced this backhanded act of grace alongside Rajpal ji, Santlal ji, Bade Jain Saheb, Malhotra ji, and several others.

I was closely associated with my gurubhai Santlal ji. Our spiritual journeys intersected when we simultaneously attained *guru charan prapti*, signalling the activation of our forehead chakra and an elevation of our conscious awareness.

Santlal ji's initial spiritual journey was tumultuous. Lying to Gurudev led to his peculiar punishment—a constant itch. This affliction inadvertently compounded his troubles, especially with a female colleague at his workplace.

He bravely and humorously shares his ordeal: "During my time in Rohtak, my superior at work was a Bengali woman who also visited the sthan. I had a persistent itch that became a problem. She even reported me to Dr Sikka, our district-in-charge, labelling me uncouth because of my scratching. I desperately sought Gurudev's help, saying, 'I need your grace'. I explained my distressing condition and how I would scratch myself with an iron rod until I bled, staining my shirts and vests. I confided in him about the lady's accusations and sought his judgment. Gurudev laughed when he heard my story. He assured me,

Captain Sharma demands meals prepared with desi ghee at the langar

saying, 'Do not worry'. From then on, my itch would disappear every morning at 9 am, only to return as the office hours ended at 5 pm!" he recalls with a laugh.

Puran ji remembers a fellow *sevadaar*, Captain Sharma from Mumbai, who always insisted on having his meals prepared in *desi* ghee, often refusing the simple offerings of the sthan's *langar*. However, this preference led him down a difficult path. He fell seriously ill and faced dietary challenges for over a year. This was not a consequence of his love for *desi* ghee but rather a lesson for someone who was overly demanding, hard on those who served him, and constantly sought attention.

In Gurudev's world, even punishments were meted out with a measure of compassion. I experienced a fleeting yet painful ankle sprain that healed in days. Rajpal ji grappled with a persistent sore throat for several months, Captain Sharma faced health challenges for a year, and Santlal ji was tested with a terrible itch. Jain Saheb's punishment was more severe. Yet, when we compare our experiences, they seem mild compared to what disciples of some other gurus have endured.

Mataji shares a story that reinforces my point. She recalls the beginnings of seva in Shivpuri in 1974: "When the sthan was established, visitors began to arrive to meet Gurudev. Among them was a woman who desperately sought the blessing of motherhood. After being denied a small amount of bus fare, her guru had cursed her to miscarry four months into each pregnancy. She came seeking relief from this curse. Initially, Gurudev advised her to return after 40 days.

"During her second visit, her guru's spirit confronted Gurudev, questioning his decision to help her. Gurudev firmly replied, 'She has come seeking help of her own accord. I did not summon her. She requires assistance, and it is my duty to provide it'. The spirit urged him to send her to his *ashram* for forgiveness. Gurudev advised her to go but warned against accepting anything. Unfortunately, she accepted a locket there and tragically miscarried once again."

I once met a family in Toronto who spoke of their ex-guru and his disciples haunting their dreams relentlessly, creating problems for them. Unfortunately, guru *avhelna* cannot be wished away, and one must bear its consequences.

The mahaguru continues to test, assess, and guide his disciples and their downlines. Shyam Gala ji and Roshini ji's experiences confirm this vigilant supervision.

Shyam ji, who has been a devoted follower of the sthan from his youth and now participates in seva from the United States, recounts a dream that affirms this ongoing spiritual oversight: "I stood next to Gurudev, who was deeply immersed in meditation. Suddenly, a group entered the room, radiating negative energies. Instinctively, I began chanting the Mahagayatri mantra to protect us". Shyam ji

observed that although these figures initially confronted him with aggressive glares, they ultimately withdrew.

Upon reflecting on this dream with his Guru (Gurudev's disciple), Shyam ji received a compelling interpretation: "Gurudev was testing your resolve to see if you would stand firm or retreat."

Similarly, Roshini ji shares a transformative dream that occurred on the morning of Guru Purnima, which impacted her spiritual commitment. "In my dream, I observed Gurudev and Guruji discussing my spiritual progress. At the time, I had become negligent about seva," she reveals. She distinctly remembers Gurudev commenting, "She has become complacent", which her Guru agreed with.

"Awakening the next morning, I was embarrassed about my complacency and determined to change my ways," she admits. "This was a clear indication that Gurudev remains watchful, though not physically present, evaluating our progress and steering us towards becoming evolved versions of ourselves."

The journey of disciplehood is akin to navigating a labyrinthine path towards self-realisation. Throughout this complex journey, disciples encounter a myriad of tests and challenges. Despite the diverse forms these trials may take, Gurudev's intention is always constructive—to teach, inspire, and elevate. He continues to lead his spiritual family beyond their inherent limitations, guiding them toward fulfilling their spiritual destinies.

Chapter 19

Humble Titan

Navigating the seas of humility when millions revere and worship you is no small feat. When placed on pedestals of power, many succumb to the intoxication of arrogance and egotism. Yet, Gurudev stands as a remarkable exception to this norm.

Reflecting on the mahaguru's demeanour, Suresh Prabhu ji notes, "Gurudev never sought the limelight. While the world boasts of many gurus, meeting one like Gurudev, who never claimed to be a guru or showcased his abilities to impress, is rather rare."

Nitin Gadekar ji echoes Suresh ji and paints a vivid picture of Gurudev, highlighting the contrasts between him and some conventional spiritual leaders: "Among the many attributes that made Gurudev stand apart, his commitment to living a routine life was particularly striking. While I harbour no criticism for spiritual leaders who choose *ashram* life, Gurudev was different. He preferred the simplicity of his home over the grandeur of an *ashram*. Unlike many gurus who adorn themselves in saffron and project a certain image, he shied away from such displays. He never wore religious beads, and you could often find him casually smoking a cigarette in public view. He seemed more intent on avoiding attention than attracting it. Yet, underlying all his actions was immense compassion."

"Fame," FC Sharma ji discloses, "was something Gurudev often compared to the ups and downs of a roller coaster. In the public

eye, even a minor deed can be blown out of proportion, leading to excessive praise or unwarranted criticism. This understanding was one of his many reasons for avoiding the spotlight. He had no desire to be a public figure or be swayed by the shifting tides of public opinion."

Pehelwanji narrates an incident involving some followers who had printed pamphlets titled 'Gurudev: The Ultimate Truth' and placed them on vehicles parked around the sthan. "When they attempted to place one on my car, I objected," he recalls. "The group leader questioned, 'Why can't we place it on your car? Isn't this the car Gurudev frequently uses?' I replied, 'Indeed, Gurudev often travels in this car, but I would prefer if you did not place the pamphlet on it.'"

While driving Gurudev back from the farm the following day, Pehelwanji shared the events from the previous day. Gurudev nodded and said, "Son, I do not appreciate such publicity either."

Like his guru, Buddhe Baba, the mahaguru held that keeping a low profile was crucial for steering clear of unwanted attention and remaining focused on his spiritual mission.

FC Sharma ji notes, "Taking his photograph was almost impossible. More often than not, any attempt to capture his image on camera would inevitably yield a blank picture."

"I have heard at least 20 different accounts of people failing to capture him on film," says Jain Saab, who oversees a sthan in Jammu. "Once, I, too, experienced this. I asked Gurudev for a photograph and he reluctantly agreed. However, my camera malfunctioned whenever I attempted to take the picture. Yet, the camera worked perfectly when I stepped outside his room. That incident was the last time I ever requested him for a photo, realising he had reasons for avoiding being captured on camera."

While Gurudev occasionally permitted photographs, he did so with an understanding of humanity's need for a tangible connection. Many sought his photograph to feel his presence, communicate, and worship. Though they could sense his power, they often wanted a physical representation to reaffirm their faith. However, Gurudev remained modest, steering clear of any deification and always wary of adoration or undue prominence.

Speaking of his junior at work, Pratap Singh ji paints a portrait of an unassuming man: "His spiritual abilities were hidden from most. He lived in simplicity, and his compassion was limitless. Whenever he learnt of someone in need, he would discreetly extend his help in any way possible."

FC Sharma ji, aligning with Pratap ji's insights, presents a striking juxtaposition of Gurudev's demeanour in personal and professional realms. He observes, "Beyond the professional sphere, Gurudev was held in high spiritual esteem, yet within the workplace, he was particularly conscious of formalities."

He elaborates, "Gurudev sought permission before entering his superiors' office and addressed them with deference as 'Sir'. What stands out is the remarkable scenario where Gurudev's seniors, who revered him for his spiritual guidance outside work, witnessed him observing strict office protocols as their junior."

Anand Parashar ji shares insights from his time with Gurudev. Reflecting on a memorable episode during a visit to Kashmir, he recalls, "I had developed an aversion to brinjals following an unpleasant incident. Gurudev observed my reluctance and took it upon himself to address it. He personally prepared brinjal *pakoras*[1]

1 Indian snack made by dipping vegetables in spiced gram flour batter and deep-frying them until crispy

at our camp. Pretending to check their seasoning, he coaxed me into tasting one, subtly helping me to move past my distaste for the vegetable". This narrative goes beyond merely overcoming a dislike for a particular food; it exemplifies Gurudev's humility and willingness to invest personal effort for the benefit of others, be it disciples or colleagues. His cooking for Anand ji and others was not an isolated gesture but a regular practice during camps. Here was the man considered by many as the most spiritually powerful being on the planet, yet he never let the perceptions of others influence his actions or dim his humility.

Bittu ji adds, "Gurudev was revered by many, yet he never presented himself as a high and mighty guru with a vast following. His way of interacting with people was extraordinary—he made everyone feel truly seen and heard". Addressing how someone constantly exposed to the problems of others can maintain such a calm and positive demeanour, Bittu ji explains, "This is the true nature of a guru. Where an ordinary person might struggle to remain happy amidst endless challenges, a *siddh* guru takes on the sorrows of others. He is beyond joy and suffering."

In 1976, Raji Sharma ji had newly embarked on his garment enterprise, but his heart always yearned for time with Gurudev. He combined every trip to Gurgaon with his work responsibilities. He would inform his office, prepared to handle any work tasks near Gurudev's sthan.

He shares an anecdote highlighting Gurudev's greatness, "Once, I had errands at an embroidery shop, and I packed a heavy sack of garments in my car's trunk. At that time, Gurudev would travel to devotees' homes for seva, and I drove him around. He inquired if I had any tasks left after a long day of visits. He immediately agreed to accompany me when I mentioned needing to deliver the sack to the shop. Upon arrival, with no one available to assist, I attempted to move the sack alone, not

wanting to inconvenience Gurudev. Struggling with the weight, I was amazed that it suddenly became lighter. Turning, I saw Gurudev lifting the other end of the sack by my side. Despite my objections, he insisted on helping, saying, 'My son, if you can bear this weight, why shouldn't I share it with you?'"

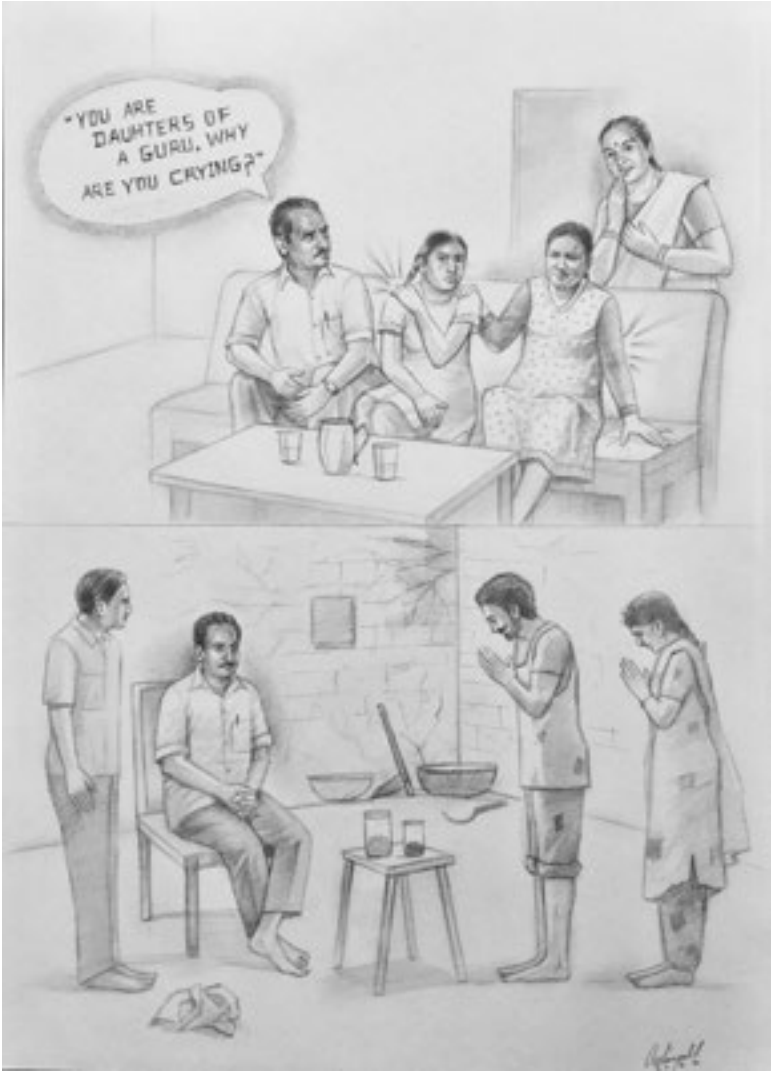
Bakshi ji adds, "Despite possessing extraordinary abilities, Gurudev always chose to stand with us, not above. He avoided any form of ostentation or the allure of spiritual elitism, treating everyone as equals and never acting superior."

Gurudev epitomised 'devoted to devotion'—a phrase that could well be his legacy. He sensed its delicate nuances as well as its fervour. At a camp in Bathri, a unique white flower on a bush caught my eye. While fetching it involved a bit of trepidation and rock climbing, I silently laid it at his feet during his *paath*, and discreetly left to avoid drawing attention. Hours later, when he beckoned me, I found him appreciating the flower. His knowing gaze met mine, leaving words superfluous.

The mahaguru was known to bend his own rules to honour devotion occasionally. When an elderly and frail devotee brought him home-made *gulab jamuns*, the mahaguru, who typically did not accept food paid for by others, graciously accepted the offering, humbly likening it to "*Shabari ke ber*."[1]

Bittu ji shares another touching account: "Pradhan ji, a resident of a village near Palampur in Himachal, became a devotee after he retired from the Indian Army. Gurudev had a fondness for *makki*

1 Shabari, an uneducated but deeply devoted disciple of Matanga Rishi, was entrusted with the care of his *ashram* as he neared the end of his life. He foretold that she would be graced with the vision of Lord Ram. Faithfully, Shabari maintained the *ashram*, eagerly anticipating Ram's arrival despite her advancing age and frailty. When Lord Ram finally arrived, Shabari, deeply moved, washed his feet with tears. Offering fruits, she tasted each berry first to ensure its sweetness, oblivious to the traditional norms this might breach. Touched by her devotion, Lord Ram delightedly accepted and ate the berries, valuing Shabari's devotion over any formalities



Gurudev chooses to spend time with a mason's family over his own

ki roti.[1] Pradhan ji took it upon himself to procure the cornflour for Gurudev. From his village, he journeyed 15 to 20 kilometres on foot to the nearest bus stop, the weight of his travel bag on his shoulders and the bag of flour atop his head. He then travelled by bus through Kangra, Chandigarh, Delhi, and finally to Gurgaon while clutching the precious flour bag and never keeping it on the ground. In acknowledgement of this unwavering devotion, Gurudev handed him 100 rupees, remarking, 'Son, this is not payment for the flour. It is invaluable to me, forever a cherished debt. This amount is simply a blessing of *barkat*.'"

Gurudev lived under constant scrutiny from other powers. It was vital for him to emanate strength and remain unemotional. Mastery in roleplay was essential, ensuring he was always several steps ahead despite the challenges looming. Thus, his actions often took unexpected turns, a testament to his strategic insight and constant awareness.

Giri ji recalls, "One night in Gurgaon, Gurudev abruptly entered my room at 3 am. Rousing me from sleep, he insisted we immediately depart for Sonipat. En route, I learnt of an accident involving Gurudev's family—his two daughters, nephew, and nephew's wife. Upon our arrival in Sonipat, we discovered his elder daughter, Renu ji, had fractured ribs, while his younger daughter, Ila ji, had suffered a broken shoulder. Seeing them in tears, he gently chided, 'Why the tears? Remember, you are daughters of a guru'. Seeking to comfort Mataji, he reassuringly said, 'Master, they will be fine'. Our visit was brief, and we soon exited Santlal ji's residence."

Giri ji continues with a surprising turn of events, "Gurudev then guided me to the humble home of Ram Nivas, the caretaker of

1 A traditional North Indian flatbread made from cornmeal (maize flour), commonly served with mustard greens (*sarson ka saag*)

his farm. There, Gurudev sat on a crickety, dusty wooden chair, seemingly indifferent to its state or the dilapidated condition of the room."

When Ram Nivas' parents proposed tea, Gurudev had an unusual request. Giri ji continues, "He asked for tea powder and sugar. Since he wanted to avoid inconveniencing Ram Nivas' family, he suggested we consume the items directly with a sip of water. Playfully nudging me, Gurudev humorously inquired, 'Finished your tea? Ready to depart?' This unexpected gesture lightened the mood, drawing laughter from all present."

"While revered by many as a mahaguru, Gurudev never let his status overshadow his respect for elders," Nikku ji says, reflecting on the mahaguru's sense of protocol. "His deference to his elder cousin, Kishan ji from Gandhinagar, was evident. The respect he showed my father was unbelievable. I remember him discreetly hiding his cigarette when my father was around, jokingly saying, '*Paaji*[1] should not see I smoke.'"

Nikku ji's father, Rudra ji, cherished his brother-in-law but was oblivious to the depth of his spiritual powers. While many yearn for acknowledgement, Gurudev was a study in duality, seamlessly and subtly managing two facets of his life.

Rudra ji recalls, "He appeared so ordinary to me. Rajpal ji once probed if I knew of his spiritual side. I replied that to me, he was just my brother-in-law. He never flaunted his supposed miracles or behaved like a big shot. When he visited Ludhiana, he always regarded me as a senior and would always heed my advice. His respect for me was unparalleled."

1 A respectful term used in Punjabi to address an elder brother or an older male

Nikku ji adds, "He was a revered guru and nothing less than God for us. Yet, despite his spiritual stature, he was mindful and nurturing of the relationships around him."

True greatness is inherently self-aware and does not seek to display its brilliance. Gurudev's humility was genuine and natural, emanating effortlessly from his being. Despite his deep awareness of the limitations of those around him, he never showcased his superior understanding. Instead, he subtly guided his disciples, recognising their flaws while encouraging them to engage in self-reflection and enhance their qualities.

A file photo of Gurudev with a disciple

Chapter 20

Sculpting Divinity

A simple lump of clay, at first glance, appears ordinary. Yet, in the hands of a master sculptor, this malleable substance transforms into a work of stunning beauty that belies its ordinary beginnings. With his vision and skill, the sculptor reveals the hidden potential within the clay. Similarly, Gurudev wielded a transformative influence over his disciples' minds. Much like a skilled puppeteer with a masterful grip on the strings, he delicately steered the course of their thoughts, beliefs, and actions. His guidance was subtle yet powerful, unlocking their inherent potential and directing them toward self-realisation.

Kishanmohan ji reflects on his transformation after meeting the mahaguru, contrasting his earlier materialistic dreams with his spiritual awakening: "In 1970, I dreamt of accumulating wealth. I imagined myself driving an Impala and living a life of luxury. But everything changed when I met Gurudev. Before meeting him, I had even considered becoming an Aghori, driven by a desire to punish those who had wronged me. I found an Aghori master who began teaching me his ways, but midway through, he told me this path was not mine to follow. He said I would one day learn from a *siddh* guru whose arrival in my life was still some time away.

"When I met Gurudev, I understood that one encounters a *siddh* guru only when destined for something beyond worldly desires. Gurudev took someone like me, a ruffian, and turned him into a spiritualist. Thanks to him, my life took a 180-degree

turn. I discovered something more substantial than materialistic wealth—the chance to do seva, a calling far surpassing my previous ambitions. But this transformation is a journey, a multi-lifetime process, and a path of ceaseless spiritual endeavour."

Gurudev was a visionary, painting our lives with a vibrant shade of blue—a colour symbolising Shiv's divine nature in Hinduism. He saw each of us as significant players in this vast 'Blue Man Show', with the promise of unimpeded growth if we did not resist the transformative brushstrokes of his spiritual teachings.

His guidance was unwavering and precise, advocating for fairness and ethical conduct. Moreover, he championed the concept of a debt-free lifestyle, urging us to live within our means and be free from the shackles of obligation or the need to curry favours. He emphasised, "We must be givers, not takers."

Kishanmohan ji reflects on this further, saying, "He blessed me with self-reliance, teaching me to live within my means, even if it meant surviving for days on a handful of chickpeas. Over these years, I have never felt compelled to ask for personal favours from Gurudev. I have only requested his guidance and protection for others."

Those who ask not for themselves but for others benefit from the concept of 'not asking'.

Nitin Gadekar ji reminisces, "In the early days, a group of friends—Srikrishna Deolekar, Suresh Prabhu, Pradeep Sethi, Shyam Dhumatkar, their wives, and I—began gathering at Khar Gymkhana for table tennis. Strangely enough, most of us were not even keen on the game. Yet, we found ourselves drawn together in the evenings. It was during these gatherings that we started sharing stories about Gurudev. Pradeep used to mimic him humorously, offering, 'Show me your forehead, and I'll heal

your headache', which always got us laughing. It was all in jest; none of us took it seriously.

"However, everything changed when Pradeep got engaged. We all went to his engagement, and that is when we had this incredible meeting with Gurudev. That was the exact moment when each of us truly began our journey in this lifetime with him."

After this encounter, Nitin ji felt an inexplicable pull towards the mahaguru. "Coming from a family with a strong preference for non-vegetarian cuisine, where fish or meat graced nearly every meal, my decision to leave non-vegetarian food a few months after meeting Gurudev marked a significant shift. Typically, I am not one to put anyone on a pedestal. However, Gurudev was an exception. His presence was magnetic, captivating my attention entirely. Whenever he was around, it felt as though he was the sole focus of the room, making it impossible for me to notice anyone else or think about anything but him.

"Normally, when you visit a temple, you are still aware of your surroundings. But with Gurudev, it was a completely different experience. I would forget everything else. Sometimes, I would not even remember my own identity as Nitin. All I knew was that I existed and was in the presence of a great being. This experience was so elevated that it continually compelled me to return to him."

In the mahaguru's presence, we experienced a nurturing influence similar to trees flourishing near a sandalwood tree. His aura was so potent that it impacted the atmosphere around him, allowing those in his presence to absorb the scent of his spiritual being. Being near him was like an effortless immersion in his wisdom and insights. Nitin ji articulates the mahaguru's impact precisely, "I think Gurudev was a far greater force than we would like to believe."

Uddhav Kirtikar ji echoes Nitin ji's sentiment: "You cannot contain scenery in a photograph or lock the ocean in a bottle. Gurudev was too vast and very difficult to understand. None of his disciples seem to have got more than just a whiff of his reality."

Many of us were fortunate to receive Gurudev's corrective guidance, as his reprimands steered us towards the right path. On one occasion, when Rajpal ji visited Gurudev, the mahaguru blessed him by placing his hand on Rajpal ji's head. As Rajpal ji prepared to leave the room, Gurudev remarked, "Raje, you have come here after mistreating your factory worker."

Rajpal ji was puzzled at Gurudev's knowledge of the incident, especially in an era without mobile phones or WhatsApp. Gurudev enlightened him, "I am your guru. I can tune in to see you whenever I feel inclined."

In an attempt to rationalise his actions, Rajpal ji recounted how the factory worker's mistake had financially impacted the company. Gurudev responded with a gentle rebuke, "Everyone errs, my son. No one is immune to making mistakes or facing losses. Remember, this man toils in your factory and contributes to your business, yet you spoke to him with undue harshness."

Rajpal ji offered his defence: "Gurudev, I compensate him for the work he does."

Gurudev offered a deep insight, "The wages he receives are his destiny. Your duty is to provide those wages, while his is to earn them. He manufactures products in your factory, enabling you to reap profits and live a life of luxury. However, your actions today placed a debt upon you."

The mahaguru emphasised through his actions and teachings that seva must be recognised as the shared destiny of the server

and the served. Our fortunate alignment of stars cast us in the role of servers, yet it was crucial to understand that we were not architects of fate but simply channels through which it flowed. This insight is a constant reminder that destiny works through us, not because of us, ensuring humility remains a cornerstone of our actions.

Rajpal ji shares another anecdote that reveals the depth of Gurudev's insight: "I sought Gurudev's blessings before flying to Singapore for work. After I had touched his feet, he looked at me intently and said, 'My son is off to deceive the world.'"

Confused, Rajpal ji responded, "Deceive? I have not misled anyone." To which Gurudev enigmatically replied, "If not yet, then you are about to."

Baffled by this cryptic statement, Rajpal ji explained the purpose of his trip. He was visiting a factory in Singapore to examine a dye machine capable of crafting sinks, drain boards, and bowls from a single sheet without welding. It was then that Gurudev pointed out that Rajpal ji had concealed the true intent of his visit. Instead of revealing his genuine interest in the technology, he had misrepresented himself as a potential buyer interested in purchasing 10,000 sinks.

Rajpal ji, still puzzled, sought clarification from Gurudev, "How am I deceiving them?" Gurudev clarified, "You are not just misleading them; you are causing them disappointment. They are eagerly preparing for your arrival, arranging transportation from the airport, yet your intentions are not to buy. You are merely visiting to observe, and they are oblivious."

Rajpal ji acknowledged the truth in the mahaguru's words, "Gurudev, you are absolutely right. I want to learn the technology as I do not know how to create a dye that can produce both the bowl and drain board from the same sheet". Gurudev responded with assurance, "My son, I will teach you," prompting Rajpal ji to cancel his planned visit to Singapore.

Fifteen days later, on Bada Guruvar, Rajpal ji took a short break from seva. He recalls, "As I lay resting with my eyes closed, the dye machine lingered in my thoughts. As I drifted to sleep, a strikingly detailed blueprint of the dye unfolded before me, complete with dimensions, radii, and curvatures!"

This unexpected vision jolted him back to wakefulness. Upon opening his eyes, he found himself in a room at the sthan in Gurgaon. Intriguingly, the precise blueprints reappeared every time he closed his eyes, vividly etched in his mind's eye.

The next day, filled with inspiration, Rajpal ji hurried to his factory. He instructed his head foreman, Ratan Singh, to fabricate the dye following the specs of the blueprint he had envisioned. However, Ratan Singh expressed concerns, believing the design was impractical for production and could lead to financial losses. Despite these objections, Rajpal ji remained adamant. Yielding to his boss' firm resolve, Ratan Singh manufactured the dye using the unique design.

Concluding his captivating tale, Rajpal ji shares, "Once we made the dye, we attached it to the press and initiated a test run. To our amazement, it worked flawlessly in just one attempt. Can you believe that Gurudev gave me the complete blueprint of this dye while I was asleep in Gurgaon?!"

Normally, Gurudev would engineer the float, not the sink. By this, I mean that he advocated for ethical behaviour in the face of challenges, encouraging us to rise above rather than be overwhelmed by circumstances. He dedicated ample time to guiding us through the process of transcending our lower impulses. Our inherent divinity was confined within our limited selves. Gurudev acted as the key, unlocking this inner sanctum and liberating our spiritual potential.

Sushila Chaudhary's story is a chronicle of faith and her husband's remarkable transformation. Her husband, a staunch atheist, firmly disbelieved in religion. He accompanied Sushila ji to sacred places like Gurudwara Bangla Saheb and Hanuman temple, but only as a passive observer, always staying outside to guard her shoes.

Four years following the birth of her daughter Ritu, Sushila ji learnt from her doctors that future pregnancies were improbable due to her having just one operational fallopian tube. Working in the same office as Gurudev allowed her to seek his guidance. During their first meeting, she openly shared her struggles and the medical conclusion that another pregnancy was improbable. Gurudev, however, brushed aside these medical assessments. "Forget what the doctors say. You will have three sons," he proclaimed. This statement overwhelmed Sushila ji with joy. Gurudev's prophecy materialised with the birth of her two sons, and when he foresaw a third, Sushila ji, content with her expanded family, respectfully declined the possibility, focusing only on her existing blessings.

She shares her husband's gradual shift in beliefs: "After Gurudev assured me of having a child within a year, I started making trips to the Gurgaon sthan by bus. It was then that my husband, appalled by the condition of the buses, remarked, 'How can you travel in these stinking buses? Let us see who this person is for whom you go so far and in such unpleasant conditions'. That is when he started driving me to Gurgaon. There, he directly observed Gurudev's extraordinary healing powers.

"Later, he accompanied me to Odi in Himachal Pradesh, where Gurudev had established a sthan. He was shocked to find people arriving on stretchers and leaving on their feet, completely healed. These experiences deeply impacted him and resulted in him developing staunch faith. He once said of Gurudev, 'There is no other guru on Earth with such powers, nor will there ever be'. In time, his faith in Gurudev grew even stronger than mine."

When Gurudev established a sthan in Kathog, he invited Chaudhary ji to do seva there. Despite some initial reservations, Chaudhary ji agreed, comforted by Gurudev's assurance that his duty would simply be to sit on the *gaddi* and offer blessings while Gurudev would manage everything else. In 1982, Gurudev established a sthan at Chaudhary ji's residence in Patel Nagar, New Delhi, a site that continues to be a hub of spiritual activity to this day.

The impact of Chaudhary ji's spiritual work did not diminish with his passing. Numerous people have shared experiences of encountering him in their dreams, where he continues to offer blessings and guidance, helping them to achieve their life goals. Chaudhary ji's spiritual contributions have transcended his physical existence, illustrating the enduring nature of *seva*.

Twenty-three-year-old Tony was the quintessential party-goer. He revelled in the pleasures of parties, enjoyed his beer, and loved meat. His lifestyle choices were a far cry from religious or spiritual paths. His curiosity and a hint of scepticism led him to accompany his girlfriend to meet Gurudev. His intent was more journalistic than spiritual—he wanted to pen a critical article on 'guru culture', highlighting it as a facade, and use the money earned to fund his indulgent habits.

"Gurudev noticed me from a distance and burst into laughter," Tony ji recalls their first encounter. "Then, he said, '*Tu aa gaya* (You've come)', as if he knew me from before. When he placed his hand on my head to bless me, it felt like a few thousand tonnes of weight had been lifted. At that moment, I assumed he was hypnotising me."

Gurudev's miraculous impact left both Tony ji and me in a state of bewilderment. As young men whose preferences leaned more towards disco than divinity, we could not logically comprehend

Gurudev's extraordinary capabilities. Hypnosis seemed the sole plausible explanation, as conventional reasoning failed to account for what we witnessed. Yet, despite our initial doubts, we gradually found ourselves drawn into the sphere of his spiritual influence.

Reflecting on the profound change within him, Tony ji shares, "Encountering Gurudev initiated an unexpected shift in my life. My perception of many things I once enjoyed began to transform. This change unfolded effortlessly, without any deliberate effort or direct guidance from Gurudev. He did not ask me to change; the transformation occurred naturally."

Many of us observed Gurudev's profound influence on people's attitudes, yet we did not fully understand how he brought about these transformations. In hindsight, these changes resulted from his ability to channel his energy towards individuals and maintain a deep connection with them. His powerful energy subtly influenced the chemistry of their aura, raising their level of consciousness.

Tony ji honours the mahaguru's impact: "He was cosmic consciousness. Like a master horticulturist, he cultivated not plants but future gurus, nurturing the realisation of their own divine nature within everyone."

Harish ji is dedicated to seva at the sthan in Hoshiarpur, Punjab, and contributes to the upkeep of the sthan in the mahaguru's birthplace, Hariana.

Ved ji, Harish ji's brother-in-law, underwent a significant transformation from battling alcoholism to becoming a fervent follower of Gurudev. With deep respect in his tone, Ved ji shares his journey, "I was an alcoholic. Upon my first meeting with Gurudev, I received his blessing and a gentle

allowance to consume two pegs daily. Yet, merely a month under his influence, I found myself free from the desire to drink. He never imposed any restrictions upon me; it was the subtle power of his blessings that ignited the will within me to renounce alcohol and non-vegetarian food."

Gurudev's intervention extended beyond changing Ved ji's drinking and dietary habits. His influence opened the doorway for Ved ji and many others to discover their higher purpose. For decades, Ved ji has worked closely with a gentleman known affectionately as Maamaa ji to maintain the sthan established in Maamaa ji's residence in Jalandhar, Punjab.

Suresh Prabhu ji speaks of Gurudev's enduring presence, suggesting that physical absence does not equate to a genuine lack of presence: "I never doubt Gurudev's presence, even in his physical absence. Sometimes, having someone physically present can be limiting, as our interactions are constrained to visible gestures. In contrast, when Gurudev is not physically here, his presence takes on a fuller, more formidable form. It is not confined to the physical realm, but manifests in various, more impactful ways."

He acknowledges Gurudev as a guru who established lofty ideals that were challenging but inspiring for his disciples and followers to strive for: "We endeavour to rise to the benchmark he set, nurturing the hope that, in time, we will fulfil the expectations he had for us."

When Giri ji arrived in Delhi in the late 1980s, he hailed a taxi to Gurgaon. The driver, a kind-hearted Sikh man, curiously asked him about the purpose of his visit. Giri ji shared that he was

going to meet his guru in Gurgaon. Delighted by this, the cabbie remarked, "A guru is like Paaras.[1] He transforms iron into gold."

Giri ji was deeply moved by the driver's insightful analogy: "I was touched by his words and decided to share them with Gurudev."

Upon meeting Gurudev, Giri ji eagerly conveyed the cab driver's comparison. However, the mahaguru's reaction was different from what Giri ji expected. Instead of appreciating the depth of the driver's words, Gurudev was gently dismissive. Sensing Giri ji's confusion, he explained, "My son, a guru's impact is even more significant than Paaras. Paaras can turn iron into gold, but it can't convert iron into another Paaras. A guru does more than improve people or create disciples; he teaches them to be like him and transforms them into gurus, capable of helping, healing and enlightening others."

Giri ji reflects, his voice laced with affection, "He consistently aimed for us to surpass him spiritually. He devoted every moment to our empowerment, nurturing our growth, and awakening the essence of the guru within us."

As we draw the curtains on the narrative of the mahaguru's life through the eyes of those who witnessed his greatness, we are reminded of the alchemical touch he had on the lives he graced—a touch that turned the ordinary into the extraordinary, leading beings from the shadow of their struggles into the luminous realm of self-realisation.

Gurudev was not just a guide; he was a visionary who saw the latent greatness within everyone, nurturing it with the wisdom and care of a master sculptor, revealing the masterpiece within

1 A mystical stone in Indian mythology, believed to have the ability to turn base metals into gold through touch; symbolises transformation

a block of stone. His approach was not forceful correction but gentle guidance—a restoration of the self that often lies buried beneath conditioning and the masks we wear.

As a mahaguru, he awakened many to their true potential, guiding them like a compass pointing unwaveringly to the north star of their innermost truth.

About the author

Hingori began his spiritual journey as the mahaguru's apprentice and has since become a teacher and guru to many. His mission is to share his good fortune with others and prepare them to serve countless more. At the same time, he believes that he is not the doer but merely the facilitator of their transformation. In that light, he advocates gratitude for the abilities and capabilities bestowed upon us. He sees self-projection and self-glorification as impediments to spiritual growth. As a result, he has chosen to remain anonymous, more as a strategy than out of modesty. Sharing knowledge is his way of ensuring that a ripple becomes a wave and then the ocean.

Gurudev was a being in whose presence my nothingness dwarfed to a level of insignificance. Yet, it was in his presence that I found my wholesomeness—the realisation that I exist to serve all beings. And that, in such service, lies the significance of my being.

HINGORI